

What Is the Perfect: At a Glance

The Question (Summary)

What does Paul mean by “the perfect” in 1 Corinthians 13:10?

“But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away.” — 1 Corinthians 13:10 (KJV)

SCAR Summary

Component	Key Finding
Scripture	The grammar (ὅταν + aorist subjunctive) points to a future event of uncertain timing. “Face to face” (πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον) echoes Moses’s direct encounter with God (Num. 12:8; Deut. 34:10). “Then shall I know even as also I am known” demands a knowing that exceeds anything a text can supply. Four views are exegetically possible; none is grammatically compelled.
Christocentrism	Jesus uses the same τέλειος root for present ethical pursuit (Matt. 5:48) and for corporate unity (John 17:23). The Moses typology reaches its fullest referent in seeing Christ himself — confirmed by 1 John 3:2 (“we shall see him as he is”). The already/not-yet character of the kingdom allows “the perfect” to have both a present dimension (love) and a future arrival (Christ).
Antiquity	The patristic witness is unanimous against the canon reading and near-unanimous in its eschatological direction. Tertullian sets Numbers 12:6-8 beside 1 Corinthians 13:12 and “reserves to some future time” the face-to-face encounter. Chrysostom (post-Nicene witness) reads the verse of the complete knowledge of the age to come: “we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more.” Augustine (likewise post-Nicene) builds his theology of the beatific vision on this passage. No ancient interpreter — not one, across the roughly three and a half centuries of surviving comment, from the Didache to Augustine — connected τὸ τέλειον with the completed canon. Clement of Alexandria alone reads it as present maturity, shaped by his Platonic context.

Component	Key Finding
Reality	Four views compete today. The canon view faces anachronism, the personal force of “face to face,” and zero patristic support. The maturity view captures Paul’s gift-to-growth theology but cannot account for “know even as I am known.” The eschatological views (Christ’s return; eternal state) hold the strongest exegetical and historical ground. Crucially, the cessationist-continuationist debate can be separated from this passage: the verse entails neither position — one can hold the eschatological reading and remain cessationist on other grounds, as Chrysostom, Edwards, and MacArthur each did — though on the eschatological reading the case for cessation must be carried by arguments outside this text.

Four Views at a Glance

View	“The Perfect” =	Strongest Argument	Honest Challenge
Completed Canon	The full written revelation of Scripture	Scripture makes the man of God ἄριστος, “complete” (2 Tim. 3:17), and Jas. 1:25 calls God’s law τέλειον; the Spirit guided apostles into “all truth” (John 16:13)	“Face to face” is personal-encounter language, ill-suited to the arrival of a text. No patristic attestation. The knowledge of v. 12 exceeds what any reader of Scripture possesses.
Christ’s Return	The Parousia — Christ himself appearing	“Face to face” is personal-encounter language; 1 John 3:2 names the referent; the patristic tradition points one way (Clement and John of Damascus excepted)	The neuter τὸ τέλειον more naturally names an event or state than a person — pressing precise advocates to say “the state of affairs at his coming” rather than “Christ himself,” at which point this view begins to merge with the eternal-state view.
Church Maturity	The corporate body reaching fullness	Eph. 4:13 uses ἄνδρα τέλειον for corporate maturity in a gift-context; Paul’s childhood analogy (v. 11) invites a growth reading	The decisive arrival language (ὅταν ἔλθῃ) and the impossibility of any present state matching “know even as I am known.”
Eternal State	The consummated kingdom in eternity	Combines personal encounter (Rev. 22:4) with completed state; resolves the “face to face” and full-knowledge demands together	Difficult to distinguish from Christ’s return in practice; risks pushing the text so far into the future that it loses present force.

Key Greek Terms

Strong's	Greek	Transliteration	Meaning
G5046	τὸ τέλειον	to teleion	"The perfect" — the complete state; from τέλος (end, goal)
G2673	καταργηθήσεται	katargēthēsetai	"Will be rendered inoperative" — future passive (καταργηθήσονται of prophecy, v. 8; καταργηθήσεται of knowledge); both cease by external cause
G3973	παύσονται	pausontai	"Will cease" — future middle; tongues cease (whether self-ceasing or simply intransitive is disputed)
G1921	ἐπιγνώσομαι	epignōsomai	"I shall know fully" — future; Paul's knowing does not yet match God's knowing of him
G737	ἄρτι	arti	"Now" — marks the present partial age
G5119	τότε	tote	"Then" — marks the future complete age

What Is Clear (Summary)

- **Love is permanent and supreme.** Every tradition agrees: "Charity never faileth" (13:8). Gifts are temporary instruments; love is the character of God himself.
- **Present knowledge is genuinely partial.** "We know in part, and we prophesy in part" (13:9). No interpreter denies this — and the shared limitation ought to produce shared humility.
- **A future completion is coming.** All views agree that the "then" of verse 12 is genuinely future from Paul's perspective and genuinely better than the "now."
- **The gifts serve the body's edification.** Across chapters 12-14, gifts exist to build up the body, not to confer status on individuals.
- **"Face to face" is our destiny.** All traditions confess that believers will one day see God directly. The disagreement is about timing, not the promise itself.

What Is Debated (Summary)

- **The referent of τὸ τέλειον** — whether it is a completed text, a divine person, a corporate state, or an eschatological era. Grammar does not settle it; context is disputed.
 - **The middle voice of παύσονται** — whether tongues “ceasing of themselves” implies a different timeline from prophecy and knowledge being “rendered inoperative,” or whether the middle voice is simply standard Hellenistic Greek.
 - **The timing of “then” (τότε)** — whether it describes something that arrived around 100 AD with the completed canon or something still ahead at the resurrection and the direct vision of God.
 - **Whether this passage settles the cessationist-continuationist debate** — Paul’s purpose in 1 Corinthians 13 is not to settle the gifts question but to relativize the gifts in the light of love.
-

The Bottom Line

The question “What is the perfect?” is genuinely difficult — it has occupied careful exegetes for two thousand years without producing consensus. But the question “What matters most?” is not difficult at all. Paul answered it without ambiguity: love is greatest, love never fails, and whatever “the perfect” is, it will not supersede love — it will be love’s fullest expression.

“And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.” — 1 Corinthians 13:13 (KJV)

A tldrSCAR study of the referent of τὸ τέλειον in 1 Corinthians 13:10.

The SCAR quadrilateral (Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, Reality) is a restatement of Dean Taylor’s Apostolic Quadrilateral (A Change of Allegiance, 2009). Criticisms, encouragements, and exhortations welcome at torque@gmail.com.

Chapter 0: Overview

“But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away.”
— 1 Corinthians 13:10 (KJV)

The Question

What did Paul mean by “the perfect”?

The question is short. The answer has occupied careful readers for two thousand years without producing consensus. And the question matters — not as an academic puzzle, but because how we answer it shapes how we understand spiritual gifts, how we relate to one another across traditions, and what we expect of our future with God.

Paul wrote these words to a church in Corinth that had turned spiritual gifts into a status competition. Tongues-speakers looked down on those who did not speak in tongues. The spiritually impressive肘ed out the quietly faithful. Paul’s response

was not to abolish gifts but to subordinate them to something greater: love. Chapter 13 of 1 Corinthians is the theological heart of that argument. Within it, verse 10 makes a claim that sounds simple on the surface — when the complete thing arrives, the partial things will be superseded — but the identity of “the perfect” has been debated ever since.

The question is not merely historical. It reaches into Sunday morning practice in millions of congregations. If “the perfect” is the completed canon of Scripture, then prophecy and tongues ceased around 100 AD, and anyone claiming to exercise those gifts today is, at best, mistaken. If “the perfect” is the return of Christ or the eternal state, then those gifts remain available throughout the present age, and to forbid them is to reject something God still gives. If “the perfect” is the maturity of the church, then the answer depends on where we are in the process of growing up. These are not abstractions. They affect how we worship, how we counsel, how we evaluate spiritual experience, and how we treat believers who read the same passage and arrive at a different conclusion.

Four major interpretations have emerged:

- **The Completed Canon** — “the perfect” is the finished New Testament.
- **Christ’s Return** — “the perfect” is the personal return of Jesus.
- **Church Maturity** — “the perfect” is the spiritual maturity of the body of Christ.
- **The Eternal State** — “the perfect” is the consummated kingdom, the new heavens and new earth.

Each view has able defenders. Each has biblical support. And each has honest difficulties. This study examines the question through four lenses — Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, and Reality — and presents what it finds without issuing a verdict. The goal is not to win the argument but to help you weigh the evidence yourself.

The Text

Before anything else, the text itself. Paul’s argument runs from 1 Corinthians 13:8 through 13:13, and it must be read whole:

“Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away. For we know in part, and we prophesy in part. But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away. When I was a child, I spake as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child: but when I became a man, I put away childish things. For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known. And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.” — 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 (KJV)

This passage is not a standalone poem, though it is often read as one. It is the theological hinge of a three-chapter argument about spiritual gifts and their proper use. Understanding its place in that argument is essential.

In **chapter 12**, Paul establishes that the body has many members and many gifts, all from the same Spirit. No one gift makes a person more spiritual than another. The eye cannot say to the hand, “I have no need of thee.” The chapter ends with a pointed

ranking: God has set in the church first apostles, second prophets, third teachers — and tongues last. Then comes the transition that introduces chapter 13:

“But covet earnestly the best gifts: and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.” — 1 Corinthians 12:31 (KJV)

The “more excellent way” is not a sentimental aside. It is the decisive move in Paul’s argument. **Chapter 13** shows that love is greater than any gift, that gifts without love are nothing, and that gifts are temporary while love is permanent. Then **chapter 14** returns to practical instructions for worship: prophecy is better than tongues because it edifies the body; everything must be done decently and in order; love governs how gifts are exercised. The bridge back is explicit:

“Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy.” — 1 Corinthians 14:1 (KJV)

Chapter 13 was written to correct a church that had confused the instruments with the music they were meant to play. Paul does not condemn the gifts. He relativizes them. They are good, they are real, they are from God — and they are temporary servants of something that will outlast them all.

The Key Words

Several Greek terms in this passage carry weight that English translations cannot fully convey. A brief orientation here will help the reader; the full analysis is in Appendix A.

Τὸ τέλειον (*to teleion*) — “that which is perfect.” The word τέλειος comes from τέλος (*telos*), meaning “end” or “goal.” Something is *teleios* when it has reached its designed purpose — not primarily moral perfection (as in modern English) but functional completeness. The neuter form (*to teleion*) suggests a state or condition rather than a specific person. Paul uses the same root elsewhere for mature believers (1 Corinthians 2:6), for the corporate maturity of the church (Ephesians 4:13), and Jesus uses it for the ethical wholeness of kingdom life: “Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect” (Matthew 5:48, KJV). The word’s range of meaning is precisely what makes the debate possible: it can point to an event, a state, a process, or a person.

Πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον (*prosopon pros prosopon*) — “face to face.” This is not a casual idiom for “better understanding.” In the Old Testament, “face to face” is the precise description of Moses’s unique access to God — a privilege shared by no other prophet:

“And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend.” — Exodus 33:11 (KJV)

“And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face.” — Deuteronomy 34:10 (KJV)

Paul deliberately echoes this tradition. Our present knowing is like that of ordinary prophets — through riddles and visions. The future knowing will be like Moses’s — direct and unmediated. But Paul goes further: he promises this not for one unique figure but for *all* believers. Whatever “the perfect” is, it must be something capable of granting the entire community what was once one man’s exclusive privilege.

Ἐν αἰνίγματι (*en ainigmati*) — “in a riddle” (the KJV renders it “darkly”). This word appears only once in the entire New Testament, and it deliberately echoes Numbers 12:8 in the Septuagint, where God says he speaks to Moses “not in riddles” (*ou di’ ainigmaton*). Paul is placing the Corinthians — and all present-age believers — in the “riddle” category of prophetic knowledge, awaiting the “face to face” that was Moses’s exclusive privilege. Even the best knowledge we have now, including Scripture, is mediated through this indirect mode. The “then” will be qualitatively different.

Ἐπιγινώσκω (*epiginosko*) versus **γινώσκω** (*ginosko*) — “know fully” versus “know.” In verse 12, Paul deliberately switches verbs: “now I know (*ginosko*) in part; but then shall I know fully (*epiginosko*), even as also I am fully known.” The prefix *epi-* intensifies: this is not merely more knowledge but a qualitatively different mode of knowing — thorough, personal, and patterned on the way God already knows us. The standard for our future knowing is God’s present knowing of us. That is a very high bar.

Παύσονται (*pausontai*) — “they shall cease.” This form is future middle voice, used specifically for tongues, while prophecy and knowledge receive a different verb (*καταργέω*, *katargeo*, “rendered inoperative”) in the passive voice. Whether this grammatical variation implies that tongues will cease at a different time or by a different mechanism is one of the most technically contested points in the entire debate. The cessationist argument holds that the middle voice indicates tongues “will cease of themselves,” independently of the coming of “the perfect.” The continuationist response holds that the middle voice is simply the standard intransitive form of this verb and carries no separate theological freight. Both sides agree on the grammar; they disagree on what the grammar means. The Greek opens a question; it does not answer it.

(Chapter 1 provides the complete verse-by-verse grammatical analysis and translation comparisons.)

Four Views in Brief

Each view deserves more space than an overview can give. Chapter 4 presents them in full, with each view’s pastoral fruit and honest challenges. Here, each gets its strongest argument and its most pressing difficulty.

The Completed Canon

The argument: When the New Testament was completed — the last apostolic documents written and recognized — God’s full written revelation became available. The partial, revelatory gifts (prophecy, tongues, word of knowledge) were instruments for a church that did not yet have the whole of Scripture. Once the canon was finished, the instruments were superseded. Supporting this reading, Paul wrote to Timothy:

“All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.” — 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (KJV)

The word for “perfect” here (*artios*, “thoroughly equipped”) invites comparison with *to teleion*. James 1:25 speaks of “the perfect law of liberty” — using the same *teleion* root to describe the word of God. And Jude 3 speaks of “the faith which was once delivered unto the saints” — a completed deposit.

The challenge: The concept of a twenty-seven-book New Testament did not exist when Paul wrote to Corinth around 55 AD. Paul could not have been thinking about a reality his hearers could not have imagined. More pressingly, the phrase “face to face” — which in the Old Testament consistently describes direct, personal encounter with God — sits uneasily as a description of receiving a completed text. No one meets a book face to face. And the knowledge Paul promises in verse 12 — “then shall I know even as also I am known” — exceeds anything that reading Scripture, however inspired, can supply. God does not know us through a text; he knows us directly and comprehensively. If our future knowing is patterned on God’s present knowing of us, something more than a book must be in view.

No patristic interpreter, across the roughly three and a half centuries of surviving comment, ever connected “the perfect” with the canon. The reading is modern: the fullest history of interpretation of this verse finds no clear advocate before the nineteenth century — and the earliest writer known even to mention the view, Robert Govett (1813-1901), reports it only to argue against it (Decker). The view still has able defenders — its fullest single-article statement, Andy Woods’s 2004 article, is engaged point by point in Chapter 4 — but none has yet answered the ancient record.

Christ’s Return

The argument: The “face to face” of verse 12 most naturally describes the personal encounter with Christ that believers receive at the resurrection. The closest New Testament parallel makes this explicit:

“Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.” — 1 John 3:2 (KJV)

Paul’s “now ... then” contrast is standard Pauline eschatological language, the same framework he uses throughout his letters to distinguish the present age from the age to come. The entire letter of 1 Corinthians is framed by eschatological expectation — opening with “waiting for the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ” (1:7) and closing with “Maranatha” (16:22). Chapter 15, just two chapters later, is Paul’s definitive treatment of the resurrection. And Revelation 22:4 brings the arc to its destination: “they shall see his face.”

This is the majority view among modern commentators — Fee, Thiselton, Carson, Bruce, Morris, and Witherington all hold it — and the ancient church tradition supports it with near-unanimity (Clement of Alexandria’s maturity reading and John of Damascus’s law-of-Christ reading are the only significant departures from the eschatological direction within the surviving corpus).

The challenge: If gifts continue until Christ’s return, how should the church evaluate contemporary claims to prophecy and tongues? This view does not itself provide criteria for discernment, though other passages do (1 Corinthians 14:29; 1 Thessalonians 5:21; 1 John 4:1). Some cessationist scholars accept the eschatological reading of “the perfect” but argue that gifts ceased for other redemptive-historical reasons — the close of the apostolic age, the completion of the foundational revelation (Ephesians 2:20) — meaning this passage does not settle the gifts question either way.

Church Maturity

The argument: Ephesians 4:11-13 explicitly connects gifts, their purpose, and the word *teleion*:

“And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ: Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.” — Ephesians 4:11-13 (KJV)

The gifts serve “till” (*mechri*) the church reaches corporate maturity — “a perfect man” (*eis andra teleion*), the same root as in 1 Corinthians 13:10. Paul uses *teleios* throughout his letters for present, achievable maturity (1 Corinthians 2:6; Philippians 3:15; Colossians 1:28). The childhood-to-adulthood analogy in verse 11 invites a reading of growth over time. And Jesus himself used the same word for a present ethical call: “Be ye therefore perfect” (Matthew 5:48). The view’s strongest modern form (Thomas) does not claim the church has arrived: the gifts serve until the goal is reached — whether the terminus proves to be the body’s maturation or the parousia itself, whichever comes first.

The challenge: Has the church ever demonstrably reached maturity? Two millennia of schism, heresy, and failure of love suggest otherwise — which means, by this view’s own logic, the gifts should still be operating. More importantly, “face to face” and “know even as I am known” describe a state that exceeds any earthly spiritual achievement, however mature. Even the most advanced Christian does not encounter God with the directness and thoroughness of divine knowledge. The language points beyond anything history has produced.

The Eternal State

The argument: The full “face to face” knowledge of God — knowing as we are known — can only be realized in the consummated kingdom, when God dwells directly with his people and every veil is removed:

“And I heard a great voice out of heaven saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them, and they shall be his people, and God himself shall be with them, and be their God.” — Revelation 21:3 (KJV)

“And they shall see his face; and his name shall be in their foreheads.” — Revelation 22:4 (KJV)

Augustine’s theology of the *beatific vision* locates the fulfillment of 1 Corinthians 13:12 here: “the sight... which is promised anew to us face to face” (*De Trinitate* 15.23.44). The “face to face” vision of Revelation 22:4 — denied even to Moses in its fullest form (Exodus 33:20) — will finally be granted in the new creation.

The challenge: For most practical purposes, this view and the Christ’s Return view arrive at the same conclusion: gifts continue until the eschaton. Paul seems to present “the perfect” as something with a specific arrival (“whenever the perfect comes”), not as an unfolding mode of existence. The Corinthians were asking about gifts in their present assemblies, and an answer pointing to the eternal state, however true, may be more remote than their immediate question requires.

(Chapter 4 presents each view in full, with its strongest advocates and pastoral fruit.)

What the Early Church Believed

The testimony of the first four centuries is one of the most striking features of this study. Chapter 3 presents it in detail; Appendix B collects the primary sources with full quotations and source citations.

The patristic reading is overwhelmingly eschatological. From the Didache's call to "be made perfect in the last time" (c. 70-100 AD), through Irenaeus's argument against the Gnostics that complete knowledge belongs to the age to come (c. 180 AD), through Tertullian's setting of Numbers 12:6-8 beside 1 Corinthians 13:12 and reserving the face-to-face encounter "to some future time" (c. 210 AD), through Chrysostom's exposition that when the perfect comes "we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more" (c. 390 AD), to Augustine's teaching that "the sight... which is promised anew to us face to face" belongs to the life to come (c. 415 AD): the ancient tradition is unanimous against the canon reading and, Clement of Alexandria excepted, eschatological in its direction.

The one significant exception is Clement of Alexandria (c. 200 AD), who reads "the perfect" as the mature spiritual knowledge available to the dedicated believer in this life through progressive growth from faith to deeper knowledge. His reading is genuine and historically significant — Clement was a serious thinker, head of the most intellectually sophisticated school in early Christianity — but it stands largely alone in the pre-Nicene period, shaped by his Platonic philosophical inheritance. No other pre-Nicene father follows him in this.

The most important observation for the reader to weigh: **no ancient interpreter connected "the perfect" with the completion of the biblical canon.** Not one. This silence spans the roughly three and a half centuries of surviving comment and every major region of early Christianity. Several of these fathers — Irenaeus, Tertullian, Origen — lived during the very period when the canon was being assembled. They were part of the process. None of them made the connection. Chrysostom and Augustine wrote *after* the canon had been formally defined by Athanasius (367 AD) and affirmed at Hippo (393 AD) and Carthage (397 AD), and they still did not make the connection.

Augustine went further. In his *De Trinitate*, he argued that Scripture itself belongs to the "mirror" side of Paul's equation — it mediates the divine but is not the direct vision. On Augustine's reading, the arrival of even a perfect text would not constitute "face to face" encounter with God. That awaits the beatific vision in eternity.

The canon-completion interpretation is a modern reading: the fullest history of interpretation of this verse (Decker) finds its earliest known appearance in the nineteenth century, and there in a writer reporting the view in order to refute it. This does not make it wrong — later insights can be valid, and the early church could have missed something. But it means this reading carries no ancient attestation and must stand entirely on its exegetical merits.

The Weight of Evidence

Without declaring a winner, honesty requires acknowledging where the evidence tilts. Chapter 5 develops this assessment in full.

The grammar establishes a future arrival of uncertain timing — from Paul’s vantage; the eschatological direction comes from verse 12’s content. The construction *hotan* (“whenever”) with the aorist subjunctive in verse 10 is the standard New Testament grammar for events of future and uncertain timing — a description an arrival c. 100 AD would also satisfy from Paul’s desk. The future form “I shall know fully” (*epignosomai*) in verse 12 is unambiguous: this knowing does not yet belong to Paul. The “now ... then” contrast is standard Pauline shorthand for the present age versus the age to come.

The patristic evidence is unanimous against the canon reading, and near-unanimous for the eschatological one. Irenaeus, Tertullian, Origen, Chrysostom, and Augustine all read “the perfect” as eschatological; Clement of Alexandria alone read it as present maturity. These interpreters belonged to different centuries, wrote in different languages, lived in different cities, and disagreed with one another on many things. On the direction of this passage, all but one agree — and on the canon reading’s absence, all of them do.

The canon view faces acknowledged difficulties. The most careful cessationist scholars — including Richard Gaffin, who wrote extensively on the gifts — hold the eschatological reading of “the perfect” while maintaining cessationism on other grounds. B.B. Warfield’s *Counterfeit Miracles* never cites 1 Corinthians 13:10 at all (Decker). That is a significant concession from within the tradition that most needs the canon reading to succeed. The scholars who have thought most carefully about this passage from a cessationist perspective are not confident that the canon view is exegetically defensible.

The maturity view captures something real. Paul’s broader theology does treat gifts as servants of maturation, and Ephesians 4:11-13 is a genuine parallel. Jesus’s own use of *teleios* in Matthew 5:48 establishes that the word describes a present ethical pursuit, not only a future event. The maturity view functions better as a corrective — a reminder that “the perfect” has a present dimension of growth in love — than as a complete account of 1 Corinthians 13:10, because it cannot explain the personal intensity of “face to face” or the impossibility of any present human state matching “know even as I am known.”

Each reader must weigh the evidence. The text is genuinely open at several points. The exegetical question remains in honest dispute among careful scholars. What the evidence does not support is the casual confidence that sometimes attaches to each position — as if the Greek settled what the Greek has, in fact, left open.

Common Ground

The debate can obscure how much all serious readers share. The agreements are not trivial concessions — they are the substance of Paul’s argument.

Love is permanent and supreme. Paul says it directly, and every tradition agrees:

“Charity never faileth.” — 1 Corinthians 13:8 (KJV)

Love is not one virtue ranked first; it is the character of God himself (1 John 4:8), and it outlasts every gift. Cessationist, continuationist, Catholic, Orthodox, Reformed, Pentecostal — all confess this without qualification.

Present knowledge is genuinely partial. Whether partial knowledge gives way to complete knowledge at the close of the apostolic age, at the Parousia, or in the eternal state — every view agrees that we *now* see through a glass, in a riddle. That shared limitation ought to produce shared humility. Every preacher, every theologian, every commentator who has written on this passage knows “in part.”

Something better is coming. All four views agree that the present mode of knowing God is incomplete and will one day be superseded. The disagreement is about when and what — not whether. The “then” of verse 12 is genuinely better than the “now,” and all of us live in the “now.”

“Face to face” is our destiny. All traditions confess that believers will one day see God directly. The disagreement is about timing and mechanism, not about the promise itself. Every reader of this text is waiting for the same thing. Whether you hold to a completed canon or a coming Christ, the promise of unmediated divine communion belongs to you.

The gifts serve the body’s edification, not individual status. Across chapters 12-14, Paul is consistent: gifts exist to build up the body of Christ, not to confer prestige on individuals. This is the point that started the entire argument — the Corinthians had turned gifts into badges of rank — and it is the point Paul will not let anyone forget. Whether gifts continue or have ceased, their purpose was never self-display.

Faith, hope, and love remain. In the midst of every interpretive disagreement, these three remain now. They do not wait for the resolution of the *teleion* question. They are the shape of Christian life in the between-times, and love is the greatest of them.

How to Read This Study

This study is organized so that each chapter can be read independently or in sequence. Here is what each one offers:

- **Chapter 1: Scripture** — The full exegetical analysis: Greek text, verse-by-verse grammar, word studies, translation comparisons, and the four candidate interpretations examined against the text. Start here if you want the evidence.
- **Chapter 2: Christocentrism** — What Jesus taught and demonstrated about love, knowledge, and the age to come. The Moses typology, the already/not-yet kingdom, the Spirit’s guidance into “all truth,” and the demand that we hold our convictions in a way that looks like the one who promised to come again.
- **Chapter 3: Antiquity** — How the earliest Christians understood 1 Corinthians 13:10, from the Didache to Augustine. Full quotations, source citations, and the striking absence of any canon-completion reading across the entire period.
- **Chapter 4: Reality** — The four major views presented at their strongest, with each view’s pastoral fruit and honest challenges. The cessationist-continuationist intersection, and why this passage does not settle that debate as directly as either side sometimes implies.

- **Chapter 5: Synthesis** — Where the evidence lands: areas of agreement, areas of tension, the weight of evidence honestly assessed, questions for the reader, and the love imperative.
 - **Appendix A: Word Study** — Complete Greek word studies for every key term in the passage: *teleios*, *katargeo*, *pauo*, *esoptron*, *ainigma*, *prosopon pros prosopon*, *epiginosko*, *ek merous*, and *nyni de*. Designed as a standalone reference.
 - **Appendix B: Patristic Sources** — All early church quotations collected chronologically, with full citations from the ANF, NPNF, PG, and PL.
-

The Heart of the Matter

It would be possible to read this entire study and miss the point — because the point is not the question we have been asking. The question “What is the perfect?” is genuine and worth pursuing. But it is not Paul’s question.

Paul’s question is: *What matters most?*

He introduced chapter 13 with a promise — “I shew unto you a more excellent way” — and then he spent the entire chapter demonstrating what that way is. The structure is telling:

Verses 1-3 establish the premise. A person can exercise every gift with maximum intensity and still be nothing without love. Tongues without love: sounding brass, a tinkling cymbal. Prophecy without love: nothing. Knowledge without love: nothing. Even giving away all possessions, even martyrdom — without love, these profit nothing. This is a radical claim. The most spectacular spiritual achievements, devoid of love, have zero value in Paul’s accounting. The Corinthians who were most impressed by tongues and most proud of their gifts needed to hear precisely this.

Verses 4-7 describe what love looks like. Not an abstraction, not a feeling, but a series of concrete behaviors: patient, kind, not envious, not self-promoting, not easily angered, not keeping accounts of wrongs, not rejoicing in evil but rejoicing in truth, bearing all things, believing all things, hoping all things, enduring all things. These are descriptions of how a person acts toward specific people in specific situations — including, presumably, toward people who disagree about *to teleion*.

Verses 8-13 provide the theological argument. Love outlasts everything. Gifts are for now; love is forever. Whatever “the perfect” is, love survives its arrival intact. Love does not belong to the partial age any more than it belongs to the perfect age — it belongs to both, because it belongs to the nature of God himself.

And he answered his own question without a trace of ambiguity:

“And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.” — 1 Corinthians 13:13 (KJV)

The gifts are temporary. Love is not. The gifts are partial. Love is not. Whatever “the perfect” is, it will not supersede love. It will be love’s fullest expression.

This means that the debate about *to teleion* must itself be conducted in accordance with the commandment that the passage exists to establish. A cessationist who uses this text to dismiss charismatic brothers as credulous has failed the love test. A continuationist who uses it to dismiss cessationist concerns as faithlessness has failed

the unity test. A technically correct interpretation held with contempt for those who disagree is a contradiction in terms, measured by the standard of the very chapter we are interpreting. Jesus prayed for those who would believe through the apostolic witness — every one of us — “that they may be made perfect in one” (John 17:23, KJV). The word is *teteleiōmenoi* (τετελειωμένοι), the same root. Whatever “the perfect” is, Jesus prays that its character will mark his people in their unity.

The early church read 1 Corinthians 13 with its eyes on the horizon — hopeful rather than polemical, less interested in which gifts were ending than in what was coming to replace them. Chapter 5 closes with that posture in full; it is worth arriving there.

Whatever “the perfect” is, it has not yet come. We are still, every one of us, seeing through a glass. That is precisely why love is the command of the hour.

And that — Paul would want us to know — is not the partial truth. That is the whole of it.

Chapter 1: Scripture — What Does the Text Actually Say?

Overview (Scripture)

This chapter examines 1 Corinthians 13:10 — “But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away” — with the attention it deserves: verse by verse, word by word, in Greek and in context. The goal is not to settle the question of what “the perfect” means, but to establish precisely what the text says, what the grammar permits, what the Old Testament background illuminates, and where genuine interpretive disagreement begins.

Key Principle: The question “what is the perfect?” cannot be answered by a single verse in isolation. It must be read within the argument of 1 Corinthians 12-14, interpreted through its Greek grammar, and heard against its Old Testament echoes. All four of those layers are addressed here. What other SCAR components (Christocentrism, Antiquity, Reality) contribute will build on this foundation.

The Literary Context: 1 Corinthians 12-14

Chapter 13 is not an independent love poem that Paul inserted into his letters. It is the theological hinge of a three-chapter argument. Reading it in isolation — as if it were a wedding reading — strips it of its polemical force.

The Corinthian Problem

The congregation at Corinth had developed a spiritual hierarchy. Tongues were the prestige gift. Those who spoke in tongues — particularly in public, without interpretation — were regarded as especially Spirit-filled, especially advanced. This created pride, disorder, and fractures in the body. Paul has been addressing this throughout chapters 12-14.

The Three-Chapter Arc

Chapter 12: Diversity of Gifts. Paul establishes that all gifts come from the same Spirit, the same Lord, and the same God (12:4-6). The body has many members; no one member is the whole body; the less-honored members are indispensable (12:22-24). The chapter ends pointedly at 12:28-31: God has appointed in the church apostles, prophets, teachers — and then tongues, listed last among eight categories. Paul asks rhetorically: do all speak with tongues? (12:30). The implied answer is no.

Then comes the transition that introduces Chapter 13:

“But covet earnestly the best gifts: and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.” — 1 Corinthians 12:31 (KJV)

The phrase “a more excellent way” (*kath’ hyperbolēn hodon*, literally “a surpassing-excellence way”) introduces Chapter 13 as the climax of the argument — not a sentimental digression, but the decisive move.

Chapter 13: The Supremacy and Permanence of Love. Paul’s argument has three movements:

1. **vv. 1-3:** Without love, every gift — including tongues, prophecy, and even martyrdom — is worthless. This is a direct challenge to Corinthian values.
2. **vv. 4-7:** Love’s character: patient, kind, not envious, not self-seeking.
3. **vv. 8-13:** Love’s permanence versus the temporariness of gifts. The gifts are for now; love is forever. This is the theological argument that requires our closest attention.

Chapter 14: Return to the Gifts Discussion. The bridge back is explicit:

“Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy.” — 1 Corinthians 14:1 (KJV)

Chapter 14 then provides the practical instruction that was suspended for Chapter 13: prophecy is greater than tongues because it edifies the whole body. Tongues without interpretation is worthless in public worship. Everything must be done decently and in order (14:40).

The structure reveals Paul’s purpose: Chapter 13 is not a standalone meditation on love. It is the theological basis for Chapter 14’s practical rulings. Because love is supreme and permanent, and gifts are temporary instruments of love, gifts must be governed by love — which means intelligibility (edification) takes priority over ecstatic experience.

The Full Greek Text of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13

The following is the NA28 Greek text with a translation that tracks the Greek as closely as possible:

v. 8 Ἡ ἀγάπη οὐδέποτε πίπτει· εἴτε δὲ προφητεῖαι, καταργηθήσονται· εἴτε γλῶσσαι, παύσονται· εἴτε γνώσις, καταργηθήσεται.

Love never falls/fails. But whether prophecies, they will be rendered inoperative; whether tongues, they will cease; whether knowledge, it will be rendered inoperative.

v. 9 ἐκ μέρους γὰρ γινώσκομεν καὶ ἐκ μέρους προφητεύομεν·

For we know in part and we prophesy in part.

v. 10 ὅταν δὲ ἔλθῃ τὸ τέλειον, τὸ ἐκ μέρους καταργηθήσεται.

But whenever the perfect comes, the partial will be rendered inoperative.

v. 11 ὅτε ἤμην νήπιος, ἐλάλουν ὡς νήπιος, ἐφρόνουν ὡς νήπιος, ἐλογιζόμην ὡς νήπιος· ὅτε γέγονα ἀνὴρ, κατήργηκα τὰ τοῦ νηπίου.

When I was a child, I was speaking as a child, I was thinking as a child, I was reasoning as a child; but when I have become a man, I have rendered inoperative the things of the child.

v. 12 βλέπομεν γὰρ ἄρτι δι' ἐσόπτρου ἐν αἰνίγματι, τότε δὲ πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον· ἄρτι γινώσκω ἐκ μέρους, τότε δὲ ἐπιγνώσομαι καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην.

For we see now through a mirror in a riddle, but then face to face; now I know in part, but then I will know fully, even as also I was fully known.

v. 13 νυνὶ δὲ μένει πίστις, ἐλπίς, ἀγάπη, τὰ τρία ταῦτα· μείζων δὲ τούτων ἡ ἀγάπη.

But now there remains faith, hope, love, these three; and the greatest of these is love.

Verse-by-Verse Grammatical Analysis

Verse 8 — Three gifts, two verbs.

The structure is a triple *eite ... eite ... eite* (“whether ... whether ... whether”). But the two verbs are not the same:

- Prophecies: **καταργηθήσονται** — future passive indicative of καταργέω
- Tongues: **παύσονται** — future **middle** indicative of παύω
- Knowledge: **καταργηθήσεται** — future passive indicative of καταργέω

Prophecies and knowledge share a verb (καταργέω, future passive). Tongues alone receive the verb παύω in the middle voice. Whether the variation is deliberate or a stylistic *variatio* is itself one of the contested points — the debate about what the variation means, and whether it means anything, is addressed in detail in the word study section below.

Note also the single verb *piptei* (“falls/fails”) for love: **οὐδέποτε πίπτει** — “never fails.” Love does not cease, does not become inoperative, does not fall away.

Verse 10 — The key verse.

ὅταν δὲ ἔλθῃ τὸ τέλειον employs a deliberate grammatical construction:

- **ὅταν** + subjunctive = indefinite temporal clause: “whenever,” “at whatever time.” This is not ὅτε (which would mean “when,” marking a more definite future). ὅταν leaves the timing open — indefiniteness of the temporal anchor, not uncertainty about whether the event will occur. Paul assumes the arrival; he does not name a date (cf. Wallace, *Greek Grammar Beyond the Basics*, pp. 478-79 on the indefinite temporal construction).

- **ἔλθῃ** = aorist active subjunctive of *erchomai*, “to come.” The aorist here refers to a single, point-in-time arrival — not an ongoing process.
- **τὸ τέλειον** = the neuter singular definite article + neuter singular adjective used as a substantive. This is “the perfect [thing/state].” The neuter *prima facie* suggests a state or event rather than a person — which is why the ablest advocates of the personal reading speak of “the state of affairs at Christ’s coming” rather than of Christ *simpliciter*. Framed that way, the personal reading and the eternal-state reading begin to converge. (It is worth recording that the objection is modern: “none of the extant Greek fathers even remarks on any supposed difficulty of applying the neuter gender to the eschaton” — Shogren, *JPT* 15 [1999].)
- **τὸ ἐκ μέρους** = “the partial [thing/state].” The article + prepositional phrase used as a substantive, exactly parallel to *τὸ τέλειον*. What is partial will be rendered inoperative.

Verse 11 — The childhood analogy.

Paul shifts to first-person autobiographical form: “When I was a child... but when I became a man...” Three activities characterize childhood: speaking (*elaloun*), thinking (*ephronoun*), reasoning (*elogizomēn*) — all imperfect tense (continuous past action). Then: “I have put away childish things” (*katērgēka ta tou nēpiou*) — **perfect** tense (completed action with present result). Paul has put them away and they remain put away. The analogy emphasizes both the decisive character of the transition and the naturalness of it: no one mourns the end of childhood when adulthood arrives. The partial is not condemned; it is superseded.

But the analogy raises an important exegetical question: does the transition from childhood to adulthood happen **gradually** (maturation over time) or **suddenly** (a decisive event, like a Roman *toga virilis* ceremony)? The Greek does not settle this. The perfect *gegona* (“I have become”) in verse 11 — like the perfect *katērgēka* beside it — describes a completed transition whose result abides, which fits a decisive arrival with an enduring state; yet the process of growing up is gradual. The verb form itself favors the decisive, completed transition; the gradual dimension is supplied by the cultural image of growth, not by the tense. Both dimensions are present in the image.

Verse 12 — Two types of knowing.

The verse contrasts two time-markers (*arti* vs. *tote*, “now” vs. “then”) and two verbs for knowing:

- **ἄρτι γινώσκω** = “now I know” — present active indicative of *ginōskō* (G1097), general knowing, partial knowing
- **τότε δὲ ἐπιγινώσσομαι** = “but then I will know fully” — future middle indicative of *epiginōskō* (G1921), intensive compound verb

This is not the same verb in two tenses. Paul deliberately switches verbs. The prefixed *epi-* carries the force of thoroughness or completeness (cf. BDAG on *epiginōskō*: “to have a thoroughgoing knowledge of, know well”).

Then comes the most remarkable clause: *kathōs kai epegnōsthēn* — “even as also I was (fully) known.” This is aorist passive of *epiginōskō*: Paul was fully, thoroughly known. By whom? The passive without agent leaves the referent unstated, but the context overwhelmingly points to God. Paul is saying: the full knowing that awaits us in the “then” will be analogous to the way God already fully knows us. God’s perfect, complete knowledge of us becomes the standard by which our future knowledge will be measured.

Verse 13 — The logical “now.”

νυνὶ δέ (“but now”) opens the concluding verse. The particle *nuni* is the emphatic form of *nun* (“now”). This “now” is more likely **logical** than temporal, though careful exegetes defend both readings. The logical “now” means: “as things stand, given everything I have argued” — the current dispensation, the between-times in which we live, is characterized by faith, hope, and love. On the temporal reading, faith and hope “remain” through the present age and give way at the arrival of “the perfect” — faith to sight (2 Cor. 5:7), hope to possession (Rom. 8:24) — a reading that, far from weakening the argument, itself points “the perfect” toward the eschaton (see Appendix A). On either reading, love alone extends into the eternal state, because love is of the nature of God himself.

Deep Word Studies

τέλειος / τὸ τέλειον (*teleios* / *to teleion*, G5046)

Form in 1 Cor 13:10: τὸ τέλειον — neuter singular substantive with definite article.

Root: From τέλος (G5056), “end, goal, completion.” The *teleios* family clusters around the idea of having reached one’s *telos* — one’s intended end, goal, or purpose. This is not primarily moral perfection (as in modern English “perfect”) but **functional completeness**: a thing is *teleios* when it fully actualizes its purpose.

BDAG (3rd ed., p. 995-996): “pertaining to meeting the highest standard, perfect ... (1) of persons: full-grown, adult, mature ... (2) of things: complete, perfect.”

Semantic range across the NT:

Reference	Form	Context	Meaning in Context
Matt 5:48	τέλειοι (pl.)	“Be ye therefore perfect, as your Father ... is perfect”	Moral completeness, imitation of God
1 Cor 2:6	τελείοις (dat. pl.)	“We speak wisdom among them that are perfect”	Mature believers (vs. immature, “babes in Christ”)
1 Cor 14:20	τέλειοι (pl.)	“In understanding be men” (lit. “be <i>teleioi</i> ”)	Intellectual and spiritual maturity, contrasted with children
Eph 4:13	ἄνδρα τέλειον	“unto a perfect man”	Corporate maturity of the body of Christ
Phil 3:15	τέλειοι (pl.)	“Let us therefore, as many as be perfect”	Those who are mature in faith (Paul includes himself)
Col 1:28	τέλειον	“present every man perfect in Christ Jesus”	Goal of apostolic ministry

Reference	Form	Context	Meaning in Context
Heb 5:14	τελείων (gen. pl.)	“strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age”	Mature believers, contrasted with “babes”
James 1:4	τέλειοι... όλόκληροι	“Let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire”	Completion through tested patience
James 1:25	νόμον τέλειον	“the perfect law of liberty”	The complete, sufficient law (of Christ)

Observation on neuter τὸ τέλειον: Of the NT uses listed above, all refer to persons or process except James 1:25 (*nomon teleion*, “perfect law”) and 1 Cor 13:10 (*to teleion*). The neuter substantive *to teleion* could refer to:

1. **A state or condition** (“the perfect state” / “completeness”)
2. **A thing** (“the perfect thing” / “the completed canon”)
3. **A person** (possible only in an extended sense — the neuter more naturally names a state or event, which is why precise advocates of this reading speak of the state of affairs at Christ’s coming)
4. **An event** (“the perfect [event]” / “the consummation”)

The grammar alone does not settle which. Context must decide — and context is precisely what is disputed.

καταργέω (*katargeō*, G2673)

Form in 1 Cor 13:10: καταργηθήσεται — future passive indicative, third person singular.

Etymology: κατά (down, against) + ἀργός (idle, inactive, from ἄ- + ἔργον, “work”) = “to make idle, to render inoperative, to put out of function.”

BDAG (p. 525): “to cause something to lose its power or effectiveness, invalidate, make powerless, make ineffective; to cause to come to an end or to be no longer in existence, abolish, wipe out, set aside.”

This is not the word for destruction. Paul uses several different words for ending: *apollumi* (destroy, perish), *phtheirō* (corrupt, destroy), *lyō* (loose, dissolve). *Katargeō* consistently carries the nuance of supersession — a lesser reality is made inoperative by the arrival of a greater one. The lesser thing is not annihilated; it is rendered unnecessary.

Paul’s usage of καταργέω across his letters (25 occurrences — more than any other NT writer):

- **Rom 6:6** — “the body of sin might be destroyed (*katargeō*)” — the body of sin rendered inoperative, not annihilated; the believer still has a body
- **Rom 7:2** — “she is loosed (*katargeō*) from the law of her husband” — freed from obligation by death of the husband

- **1 Cor 1:28** — “to bring to nought (*katargeō*) things that are” — worldly wisdom rendered ineffective by the cross
- **1 Cor 2:6** — “the princes of this world, that come to nought (*katargeō*)” — rulers whose wisdom is being made inoperative
- **1 Cor 6:13** — “God shall destroy (*katargeō*) both it and them” — food and the belly rendered inoperative at resurrection
- **1 Cor 13:8, 10** — prophecies and knowledge rendered inoperative by the perfect
- **1 Cor 15:24** — “he shall have put down (*katargeō*) all rule and all authority and power”
- **1 Cor 15:26** — “The last enemy that shall be destroyed (*katargeō*) is death”
- **2 Cor 3:7, 11, 13, 14** — the old covenant glory “done away” (*katargeō*) by the greater glory of the new covenant
- **Gal 3:17** — “the covenant... cannot disannul (*katargeō*)” the promise
- **Gal 5:4** — “Christ is become of no effect (*katargeō*) unto you” — the effect of grace nullified by those who seek justification by law
- **Eph 2:15** — “abolished (*katargeō*) in his flesh the enmity” — the law of commandments rendered inoperative

The consistent Pauline pattern: Something good (the law, the old covenant glory, the gifts) is made inoperative by the arrival of something better (Christ, the new covenant, the perfect). *Katargeō* does not mean the lesser thing was bad; it means the greater thing has arrived and made it unnecessary.

The use of the **passive voice** (*katargēthēsetai*) is significant: the gifts do not cease themselves; they are rendered inoperative by an external agent — the coming of the perfect. Compare the middle voice of πᾶσσονται for tongues (see below).

παύω (*pauō*, G3973)

Form in 1 Cor 13:8: πᾶσσονται — future **middle** indicative, third person plural.

Active voice (*pauō*): “to stop, cause to cease” — transitive. One thing stops another.

Middle voice (*pauomai*): “to cease oneself, come to an end of one’s own accord” — intransitive, reflexive. The action stops from within.

The middle voice question has generated significant exegetical debate in recent decades, particularly among cessationist and continuationist scholars.

The cessationist argument from the middle voice (associated especially with Thomas R. Edgar; Robert L. Thomas advances it more tentatively — “perhaps no great significance may be attached to this distinction,” he concedes, before exploring it): The distinction between *katargeō* (passive) for prophecy and knowledge versus *pauō* (middle) for tongues is theologically intentional. *Katargeō* in the passive means “will be rendered inoperative [by an external cause]” — the coming of the perfect. But *pausomai* in the middle means “will cease of itself” — tongues will stop on their own, independent of and prior to the coming of the perfect. On this reading, tongues ceased as a spontaneous, internal cessation (perhaps at the close of the apostolic age), while prophecy and knowledge await the coming of the perfect to be done away.

The continuationist response (associated especially with D.A. Carson, Max Turner, and Gordon Fee): The middle voice of *pauō* does not carry the weight this argument requires. In Hellenistic Greek, the distinction between middle and passive voices was

collapsing; deponent verbs (always middle in form, active in meaning) were common; and *pauō* in the middle was simply the standard intransitive usage of this verb. It does not imply self-causation in any meaningful theological sense. The argument, on this view, “overloads” a common grammatical form. Furthermore, Paul does not say *when* the ceasing will occur; he lists tongues, prophecies, and knowledge together as temporary, without necessarily implying they cease at different times.

The state of the argument: Both sides agree on the grammar — *παύσονται* is future middle. The debate is whether the middle voice implies a different *timing* or *mechanism* of cessation compared to the passive *katargēthēsontai*. Wallace’s treatment — the standard intermediate grammar’s — is double-edged, and now verified against the print (*Greek Grammar Beyond the Basics*, pp. 422-23). Against the deponent reading he notes that “*παύσονται* is surrounded by passives in 1 Cor 13:8, not actives,” and that “the real force of *παύω* in the middle is intransitive... in the middle, it ceases from its own activity”; he concludes that “Paul seems to be making a point that is more than stylistic in his shift in verbs.” But he immediately adds the boundary: “this is not to say that the middle voice in 1 Cor 13:8 proves that tongues already ceased! This verse does not specifically address *when* tongues would cease, although it is giving a terminus ad quem: when the perfect comes.” So the tradition’s own reference grammar lands where this study does: the variation is real and cannot be dismissed as purely accidental — and it fixes no date. It warrants careful attention without certainty.

ἑσόπτρου (*esoptron*, G2072)

Form in 1 Cor 13:12: δι’ ἑσόπτρου — genitive singular, “through a mirror.”

Etymology: ἐς/εἰς (into) + ὀπτ- (seeing, from *optanomai*) = “the thing for seeing into” — a mirror.

Ancient mirrors: In the first century, mirrors were made of polished metal — typically bronze. Glass mirrors, backed with reflective material, were a much later invention. Ancient bronze mirrors gave a recognizable but distorted, imperfect reflection: you could see your general form and features, but the image was dim, wavering, and monochromatic. Even a high-quality mirror showed an approximation.

Corinthian bronze (*aes Corinthium*): This detail is not incidental. Paul is writing to Corinth — a city whose bronze work was celebrated throughout the ancient Mediterranean world. **Pliny the Elder** (*Natural History* 34.6-8, c. 77 AD) records that Corinthian bronze (*aes Corinthium*) was more highly prized than silver or even gold — its formula, according to the legend he reports, blended by chance when Corinth burned at its capture (*hoc casus miscuit Corintho, cum caperetur, incensa*, NH 34.6). He describes three varieties: one approaching the color of silver, another more resembling gold, and a third in which the metals were blended in equal proportions (NH 34.8). Beyond these he mentions a bronze whose formula could not be reproduced — the liver-colored *hepatizon* — which he ranks well below the Corinthian, though far above the bronzes of Aegina and Delos.

Paul’s audience would have understood immediately: even the polished bronze mirrors of everyday Corinthian life — and Corinthian bronze was the most prized metalwork in the ancient world — produced only a dim, partial image. If *that* is your best seeing, how much more limited is your knowledge compared to what the “then” will reveal.

NT usage of ἑσοπτρον: This word appears only twice in the NT: 1. **1 Corinthians 13:12** (here) 2. **James 1:23** — “a man beholding his natural face in a glass (*esoptron*)” — one who looks in a mirror and then immediately forgets what he saw

The LXX uses *esoptron* only twice, both times in deuterocanonical wisdom literature: Wisdom of Solomon 7:26, where Wisdom is “an unspotted mirror (ἑσοπτρον ἀκηλίδωτον) of the working of God,” and Sirach 12:11. Its rarity makes Paul’s choice deliberate and precise.

αἰνίγμα (*ainigma*, G135)

Form in 1 Cor 13:12: ἐν αἰνίγματι — “in a riddle/enigma.”

Etymology: From *ainisomai*, “to speak in riddles.” The word gives English “enigma.”

BDAG (p. 27): “an obscure or difficult matter, riddle, enigma, indirect image.”

NT usage: This word appears **only once** in the entire New Testament — here. That rarity signals that Paul chose it for a specific reason.

The critical Old Testament allusion: The word resonates with the Septuagint of **Numbers 12:8**, where God speaks of Moses:

“With him will I speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, and not in dark speeches (δι’ αἰνιγμάτων, di’ ainigmatōn); and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold: wherefore then were ye not afraid to speak against my servant Moses?” — Numbers 12:8 (KJV)

In the LXX, God contrasts his communication with the prophets (through visions and dreams, in riddles — *ainigmata*) with his communication with Moses (mouth to mouth, clearly, not in riddles). Among the prophets, Moses alone knew God “face to face” as a standing mode of communication — “not in dark speeches” (Num. 12:6-8; Deut. 34:10). (Scripture applies the idiom punctually to others — Jacob at Peniel, Gen. 32:30; Israel at Horeb, Deut. 5:4; Gideon, Judg. 6:22 — but for no one else is it an ongoing mode of revelation.)

Paul’s use of *ainigma* in 1 Corinthians 13:12 is almost certainly a deliberate echo of Numbers 12:8. He is saying: our present knowing is like that of the ordinary prophet — through visions, through indirect means, through riddles. The “then” will be like Moses — face to face, not through enigma. But Paul is not saying that a few special people will have this. He is saying that all believers, when the perfect comes, will have what only Moses had in the old covenant.

πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον (*prosōpon pros prosōpon*)

Literal meaning: “face toward face,” “face to face.”

The OT background is essential for understanding what Paul means. This phrase carries enormous covenantal weight in the Hebrew scriptures:

Genesis 32:30 (English versification; MT and LXX Rahlfs number the verse 32:31): > “And Jacob called the name of the place Peniel: for I have seen God face to face (פָּנֵי פָנִים)

אֶינְפִּילָא / LXX: εἶδον γὰρ θεὸν πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον), and my life is preserved.” >
— Genesis 32:30 (KJV)

Jacob’s encounter at the Jabbok was unique. He wrestled with the divine and survived, naming the place “face of God.”

Exodus 33:11: > “And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face (אֶינְפִּילָא מִינְפִּי / LXX: ἐνώπιος ἐνωπίω), as a man speaketh unto his friend. And he turned again into the camp: but his servant Joshua, the son of Nun, a young man, departed not out of the tabernacle.” > — Exodus 33:11 (KJV)

The intimacy here is remarkable: as one friend speaks to another. Yet paradoxically, Exodus 33:20-23 limits this: Moses cannot see God’s face and live; he sees God’s back. The “face to face” language is relational and covenantal, not necessarily literal visual perception of the divine face.

Numbers 12:8: > “With him will I speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, and not in dark speeches; and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold: wherefore then were ye not afraid to speak against my servant Moses?” > — Numbers 12:8 (KJV)

The LXX has: *stoma kata stoma lalēsō autō, en eidei, kai ou di’ ainigmatōn* — “mouth to mouth I will speak with him, clearly (in form/vision), and not through riddles.” The contrast with *ainigmata* (riddles) is the precise background Paul is drawing on in 1 Cor 13:12.

Deuteronomy 34:10: > “And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face.” > — Deuteronomy 34:10 (KJV)

This eulogy of Moses at his death declares that no subsequent prophet achieved what Moses had. The “face to face” relationship was Moses’s unique privilege in the old covenant.

Paul’s claim is striking: When “the perfect” comes, what was Moses’s exclusive privilege in the old covenant — knowing God face to face, not through riddles — will become the common experience of all believers. This elevates “the perfect” to something of extraordinary eschatological weight. Whatever it is, it must be sufficient to grant every believer Mosaic intimacy with God.

ἐπιγινώσκω (*epiginōskō*, G1921) versus γινώσκω (*ginōskō*, G1097)

In 1 Cor 13:12: - “now I know” = ἄρτι γινώσκω (G1097) — present active indicative, general knowing - “then I shall know fully” = τότε δὲ ἐπιγινώσομαι (G1921) — future middle indicative, intensive compound

The *epi-* prefix on *epiginōskō* carries the force of thoroughness or intensification. BDAG (p. 369): “to have a thoroughgoing knowledge of, know well; to know again, recognize; to acknowledge.” Moulton and Milligan note that in papyri, *epiginōskō* often carries the nuance of “official recognition” or “full identification.” Fee (*NICNT on 1 Corinthians*) notes that “the compound form implies a fuller, more complete knowledge.”

The passive clause: *kathōs kai epegnōsthēn* — “even as also I was fully known” (aorist passive). God’s *epiginōskō* of Paul is the standard. Paul does not say “I will know as much as God knows” (which would be absurd) but “my knowing will be *like* the way I

have been known” — relational, thorough, personal, without the veil of partiality. The emphasis is on the quality of the relationship, not on omniscience.

The contrast in the passage: - Present: partial (γινώσκω) — like seeing in a mirror, in a riddle - Future: full (ἐπιγνώσομαι) — like face to face, like the knowing by which God has known us

The Critical Parallel: Ephesians 4:11-13

This passage is the most important parallel in Paul’s letters for understanding what “the perfect” might mean:

“And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ: Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.” — Ephesians 4:11-13 (KJV)

Key observations:

1. **The gifts serve “until”** (*mechri* — “until, as long as”) something is reached. The gifts are means to an end, not permanent features of the body.
2. **The goal is “a perfect man”** (*eis andra teleion*) — the same *teleios* root as in 1 Cor 13:10. Here it is explicitly applied to the corporate body of Christ: not a mature individual but “a perfect man” referring to the church in its full, unified, mature state.
3. **The standard is “the fulness of Christ”** (*tou plērōmatos tou Christou*) — the complete Christ, the whole body joined to its head.
4. **Potential connection to 1 Cor 13:10:** If the “perfect man” of Eph 4:13 and the *to teleion* of 1 Cor 13:10 refer to the same eschatological reality, then:
 - The gifts (apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, teachers in Eph 4; prophecy, tongues, knowledge in 1 Cor 13) are temporary instruments
 - Their purpose is to bring the body to maturity/completeness
 - When that maturity/completeness arrives, the instruments are superseded
5. **A complication:** The gifts listed in Eph 4:11 (apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, teachers) are not identical to those in 1 Cor 13:8 (prophecy, tongues, knowledge). Are these the same set of gifts discussed in both passages, or different gift-categories? Cessationists sometimes argue that the “foundational” gifts of apostles and prophets (cf. Eph 2:20) ended with the apostolic generation, while the “body-building” gifts continue. Others argue the two lists overlap significantly and should be read together.

The Eph 4:13 parallel does not settle the question — it intensifies it. The “perfect man” in Ephesians is clearly the corporate maturity of the body of Christ, but whether this is achieved at Christ’s return, through ongoing history, or in the eternal state is not specified.

Translation Comparison Table

1 Corinthians 13:8 — Three Gifts, Key Verbs

Translation	“prophecies shall fail”	“tongues shall cease”	“knowledge shall vanish”
KJV	“they shall fail”	“they shall cease”	“it shall vanish away”
ESV	“they will pass away”	“they will cease”	“it will pass away”
NASB (2020)	“they will be done away”	“they will cease”	“it will be done away”
NET	“they will be set aside”	“they will cease”	“it will be set aside”
NIV (2011)	“they will cease”	“they will be stilled”	“it will pass away”
LSB	“they will be done away”	“they will cease”	“it will be done away”

Note: Only the KJV and NIV render the two occurrences of *katargeō* (prophecies, knowledge) with different English words (KJV: “fail” / “vanish away”; NIV: “cease” / “pass away”). Every version shown renders the two verbs differently: all but the NIV reserve “cease” for *pauō*, while the NIV inverts the pattern, giving “cease” to prophecies (*katargeō*) and “be stilled” to tongues (*pauō*). The NASB and LSB most clearly show the passive vs. middle distinction by rendering *katargeō* as “done away” (passive force implied) and *pauō* as “cease” (intransitive/reflexive).

1 Corinthians 13:10 — “The Perfect”

Translation	Rendering of τὸ τέλειον	Notes
KJV	“that which is perfect”	Relative pronoun + adj.; neuter preserved
ESV	“the perfect”	Clean and minimal
NASB (2020)	“the perfect”	Same as ESV
LSB	“the perfect”	Same
NIV (2011)	“completeness”	Abstracts to a state rather than a thing
NET	“what is perfect”	Concrete substantive, like the KJV
NLT	“the time of perfection comes”	Paraphrases as temporal event
NRSV	“the complete”	State

Significance: The NIV and NRSV render *to teleion* as an abstraction (“completeness,” “the complete”) rather than a substantive noun (“the perfect [thing]”); the NET keeps the concrete substantive (“what is perfect”). This reflects a translational choice that slightly favors the “state” interpretation over the “event” or “person” interpretation, though the NET’s translator note discusses the ambiguity explicitly.

1 Corinthians 13:12 — Mirror and Knowing

Translation	“through a glass”	“darkly” / “dimly”	“know fully”
KJV	“through a glass”	“darkly”	“know even as also I am known”
ESV	“in a mirror”	“dimly”	“know fully, even as I have been fully known”
NASB (2020)	“in a mirror”	“dimly”	“know fully, just as I also have been fully known”
LSB	“in a mirror”	“dimly”	“know fully, just as I also have been fully known”
NIV (2011)	“in a mirror”	“dimly” (literally “obscurely”)	“know fully, even as I am fully known”
NET	“in a mirror indirectly”	[phrase combined]	“know fully, just as I have been fully known”

The KJV’s “glass” and “darkly”: The KJV’s “glass” follows the common early modern English usage (a “looking glass” = a mirror). The Greek *esoptron* is precisely a mirror, not a window — the modern translations are more accurate. “Darkly” (*en ainigmati*) is literally “in a riddle/enigma” — “dimly” (ESV/NASB/NIV) softens this into visual metaphor and loses the OT allusion to Numbers 12:8. Technically “in a riddle” is the most accurate rendering, but it sounds peculiar in modern English.

The Four Candidate Interpretations: Strongest Scriptural Arguments

Chapter 4 presents each view in full detail. Here, the goal is to identify the strongest *scriptural* argument for each — the passage that, if interpreted in a particular way, most naturally supports that view.

1. Completed Canon (Cessationism)

“All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect (*teleios*), thoroughly furnished (*exērtismenos*) unto all good works.” — 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (KJV)

Argument: While the word rendered “perfect” in 2 Timothy 3:17 is *ἄρτιος* (“complete, fitted”), not *τέλειος*, proponents argue the concept is directly parallel: the *exērtismenos* (“thoroughly furnished, fully equipped”) of the man of God suggests that Scripture is sufficient — it gives the believer everything needed. If Scripture already provides “the perfect” equipment, then the arrival of “the perfect” of 1 Cor 13:10 may coincide with the completion of the canon. Supporting texts: James 1:25 (“the perfect law of liberty”

— a completed, sufficient law) and Jude 3 (“the faith which was once for all delivered to the saints”).

2. Christ’s Return (Classic Continuationism)

“Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.” — 1 John 3:2 (KJV)

Argument: The “face to face” language of 1 Cor 13:12 most naturally describes the vision of God / Christ that believers receive at the resurrection. “We shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2) is the most direct NT parallel for seeing “face to face.” Supporting texts: 1 Corinthians 15:51-52 (the resurrection transformation), Philippians 3:20-21 (“he shall change our vile body, that it may be fashioned like unto his glorious body”), and Revelation 22:4 (“they shall see his face”).

3. Corporate Church Maturity (Progressive-Historical View)

“Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.” — Ephesians 4:13 (KJV)

Argument: The “perfect man” of Eph 4:13 is the corporate maturity of the body of Christ — the church growing up together into its Head. If *to teleion* in 1 Cor 13:10 refers to this same corporate maturity, then the gifts cease when the church reaches that mature, unified, fully-functioning state. Supporting texts: Colossians 1:28 (Paul’s goal to “present every man perfect in Christ”), Hebrews 6:1 (“let us go on unto perfection”), and the structural argument that the gifts of Eph 4:11 serve “until” (*mechri*) this maturity is reached.

4. Eternal State (Glorification View)

“And I heard a great voice out of heaven saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them, and they shall be his people, and God himself shall be with them, and be their God.” — Revelation 21:3 (KJV)

Argument: The “face to face” knowledge of 1 Cor 13:12 — knowing as we are known — can only be fully realized in the eternal state, when the veil of creation-finitude is removed entirely. The “then” of Paul’s contrast is the eternal state, not a penultimate event. Supporting text: Revelation 22:4 (“they shall see his face”) — the direct vision of God that was denied even to Moses (Exod 33:20) will finally be granted in the new creation.

What Is Clear

- Paul is contrasting a present state (“now,” “in part”) with a future state (“then,” “the perfect”) — the transition is clearly future from Paul’s perspective in his own argument.
- Three gifts (prophecy, tongues, knowledge) are explicitly described as temporary. Love is explicitly described as permanent: “charity never faileth.”

- The verb *katargeō* for prophecy and knowledge carries the nuance of supersession, not annihilation — the gifts are not condemned but transcended.
 - The verb *pauō* in the **middle** voice is used specifically for tongues — this is a grammatical fact, though its interpretive significance is disputed.
 - The “face to face” language of verse 12 deliberately echoes the Mosaic tradition of Numbers 12:8 and Deuteronomy 34:10 — whatever the “perfect” is, it grants believers a form of knowing that surpasses even prophetic experience and approximates (in relational quality) the unique intimacy Moses had with God.
 - The *ἐπί*-prefix on *epiginōskō* signals a more thorough, complete knowing than the partial *ginōskō* of the present age.
 - The neuter *τὸ τέλειον* is a substantive, not a predicate adjective — Paul is referring to a specific reality (“the perfect [thing/state/event/person]”), not describing something as “perfect.”
 - Chapter 13 functions as the theological hinge of 1 Corinthians 12–14, not as a freestanding love poem. Its argument about the temporariness of gifts is made in service of Paul’s pastoral argument about order in worship.
-

What Is Debated

- **Whether the middle voice of παύσονται** signals that tongues will cease before, independently of, or simultaneously with the doing-away of prophecy and knowledge at the coming of the perfect. The grammar is real; its theological weight is disputed.
 - **Whether τὸ τέλειον refers** to (a) the completed New Testament canon, (b) Christ’s return and resurrection, (c) the corporate maturity of the body of Christ, or (d) the eternal state. The neuter substantive is compatible with all four readings; context must adjudicate and context is itself disputed.
 - **Whether the childhood analogy** (v. 11) models a gradual process (the church maturing over centuries) or a decisive event-transition (the arrival of a new dispensation or age). The perfect *gegona* (“I have become”) suggests a completed transition with an abiding result, but growing up is gradual.
 - **Whether “face to face”** in verse 12 refers to a literal seeing of Christ at his return, a relational quality of knowing available through the Spirit, or the direct vision of God granted only in the eternal state. All three OT parallels (Genesis 32:30, Exodus 33:11, Numbers 12:8) are themselves somewhat metaphorical for “direct encounter.”
 - **Whether Ephesians 4:13** (“a perfect man”) refers to the same event or state as 1 Corinthians 13:10, and if so, which interpretation of Eph 4:13 should govern 1 Cor 13:10.
 - **Whether “now I know in part”** describes an epistemological limitation inherent to creatureliness (which would persist until the eternal state) or a provisional limitation of the present age relative to the age of full revelation (which would end at a particular historical or eschatological moment).
 - **Whether οὐνὶ δέ** (“but now”) in verse 13 is temporal (referring to the present age) or logical (referring to the state of affairs as Paul has described it) — which affects whether faith, hope, and love all persist into the eternal state.
-

Summary (Scripture)

The textual evidence of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 presents a case study in genuine grammatical ambiguity at a theologically crucial point. What is not ambiguous is Paul's main argument: love is permanent; gifts are temporary servants of love; the partial is destined to be superseded by the perfect. These claims Paul makes with force and clarity. The debate begins precisely where Paul says *when* and *what* — and here the text deliberately leaves the referent of *to teleion* unresolved.

The word studies reveal a rich semantic field. *Teleios* in the neuter substantive is unusual in Paul and could point to a state, an event, a corporate reality, or — less likely but grammatically possible — a person. *Katargeō* tells us the transition will be one of supersession, not destruction. The middle voice of *pauō* is a grammatical fact that has generated serious exegetical argument; neither the cessationist nor the continuationist reading should be dismissed. The mirror and the *ainigma* anchor Paul's argument in the Moses tradition of Numbers 12:8, suggesting that whatever the "then" is, it brings believers into the quality of divine intimacy that was Moses's exclusive privilege in the old covenant. The double-compound *epignōsomai* points to a mode of knowing qualitatively unlike present experience — thorough, personal, analogous to God's knowing of us.

The four candidate interpretations — completed canon, Christ's return, church maturity, eternal state — each have genuine scriptural footing. The honest exegete must acknowledge that the text was not written to settle the cessationist-continuationist debate that was unknown to Paul; it was written to humble the gift-proud Corinthians by showing them that even their most impressive charismatic experiences are servants of something infinitely greater, and that something infinitely greater has not yet come. Whether it comes at the close of the apostolic age, at the Parousia, through the progressive maturation of the body, or only in the new creation: on that question, the text is genuinely open.

What is not open is Paul's purpose in writing Chapter 13. He is not writing a philosophical treatise on epistemology. He is writing to a church that confused the means with the end, that elevated the servant above the master, that prized the instrument over the music it was meant to play. His answer is not to denigrate the gifts — he urges his readers to desire them (14:1). His answer is to relativize them: love is eternal; gifts are for now; "now" is passing; therefore, govern your gifts by love.

Next: Chapter 2 examines what Jesus taught and demonstrated about love, knowledge, and the nature of the age to come — and what his priorities reveal about the question at hand.

Chapter 2: Christocentrism — What Did Jesus Teach and Demonstrate?

Connecting to Chapter 1

Chapter 1's Scripture analysis established the contours of a genuinely difficult interpretive question. The Greek text of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 is clear on several things: gifts are partial and temporary; love is permanent; a future "perfect" will supersede the

partial; the contrast between “now” (*arti*) and “then” (*tote*) frames a present limitation and a future completion. But the text itself does not name what “the perfect” is. That is the open question.

Chapter 1 also surfaced several secondary questions that remain unresolved by grammatical and lexical analysis alone:

- Does “face to face” (*prosōpon pros prosōpon*, v. 12) describe a literal encounter with Christ himself, or is it a metaphor for a qualitative change in knowledge?
- Does “the perfect” (*to teleion*) describe a single eschatological event — the return of Christ — or a process of ongoing maturation within the present age?
- What is the relationship between gifts and love in Paul’s argument? Are gifts essentially temporary tools, or something more?

The Christocentric lens cannot resolve every one of these questions with finality. What it can do is anchor them in something richer than grammar alone: the actual teaching and priorities of the one whom Paul calls Lord. When we read Paul through Jesus, certain features of the text come into focus with a clarity that lexicons alone cannot supply.

Jesus as the New Moses: The “Face to Face” Connection

Of all the Christocentric insights this study yields, none is more important or more frequently overlooked than the typological connection between Moses and “face to face” knowledge of God.

The phrase *prosōpon pros prosōpon* that Paul uses in 1 Corinthians 13:12 is loaded with Old Testament freight. In the Hebrew Scriptures, “face to face” is not a casual metaphor for intimacy. It is the precise description of Moses’s singular, unprecedented access to God — an access that set him apart from every other prophet in Israel’s history:

“And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend.” — Exodus 33:11 (KJV)

“And he said, Hear now my words: If there be a prophet among you, I the LORD will make myself known unto him in a vision, and will speak unto him in a dream. My servant Moses is not so, who is faithful in all mine house. With him will I speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, and not in dark speeches; and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold: wherefore then were ye not afraid to speak against my servant Moses?” — Numbers 12:6-8 (KJV)

“And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face.” — Deuteronomy 34:10 (KJV)

This is the standing of Moses in the Old Testament: alone among the prophets, God spoke to him “face to face,” “mouth to mouth,” “not in dark speeches” — the exact opposite of the mirror-and-riddle knowledge Paul describes as the present condition of the Corinthian church.

Paul’s language in 1 Corinthians 13:12 deliberately echoes this. “Now we see through a glass, darkly” — *en ainigmati*, “in an enigma, in dark speech, in a riddle” — is the very mode from which Moses was exempt. “Then, face to face” is the mode that was

uniquely Moses's. Paul is not using "face to face" as a vague idiom. He is placing his readers in the lineage of that specific, exalted, Mosaic encounter with God.

And into this typological framework steps Jesus.

Moses himself predicted a successor. In his final sermon, he said:

"The LORD thy God will raise up unto thee a Prophet from the midst of thee, of thy brethren, like unto me; unto him ye shall hearken." — Deuteronomy 18:15 (KJV)

This is not a general prediction about the prophetic office. The singular "a Prophet... like unto me" is deliberately framed to echo Moses's own uniqueness. The apostle Peter, preaching at Solomon's Portico in the days immediately following Pentecost, explicitly identified Jesus as this prophet:

"For Moses truly said unto the fathers, A prophet shall the Lord your God raise up unto you of your brethren, like unto me; him shall ye hear in all things whatsoever he shall say unto you. And it shall come to pass, that every soul, which will not hear that prophet, shall be destroyed from among the people." — Acts 3:22-23 (KJV)

The letter to the Hebrews makes the comparison and its outcome explicit: Moses was faithful; Jesus is greater than Moses, not merely greater as a prophet, but greater in category — as a Son over the house, not a servant within it:

"Wherefore, holy brethren, partakers of the heavenly calling, consider the Apostle and High Priest of our profession, Christ Jesus; Who was faithful to him that appointed him, as also Moses was faithful in all his house. For this man was counted worthy of more glory than Moses, inasmuch as he who hath builded the house hath more honour than the house. For every house is builded by some man; but he that built all things is God. And Moses verily was faithful in all his house, as a servant, for a testimony of those things which were to be spoken after; But Christ as a son over his own house; whose house are we, if we hold fast the confidence and the rejoicing of the hope firm unto the end." — Hebrews 3:1-6 (KJV)

And most directly, John draws the contrast and the fulfillment together in a single stroke:

"For the law was given by Moses, but grace and truth came by Jesus Christ. No man hath seen God at any time; the only begotten Son, which is in the bosom of the Father, he hath declared him." — John 1:17-18 (KJV)

The logic is striking. Moses had "face to face" knowledge of God — and yet even Moses could not see God's face directly (Exodus 33:20-23). Jesus, as the eternal Son "in the bosom of the Father," *is* the face of God turned toward humanity. He has "declared" (*exēgēsato* — literally "exegeted," "made known") the Father in a way no prophet, not even Moses, could.

Now bring all of this to bear on 1 Corinthians 13:12.

When Paul says believers now see "in a mirror, in a riddle" — Mosaic terms for *lesser* prophetic access — but will then see "face to face," he is pointing to the consummation of what Moses anticipated and Jesus embodies. The "face to face" that awaits believers is not merely a better mode of theological information. It is the vision of Christ himself, who is the face of God.

John makes this explicit:

“Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.” — 1 John 3:2 (KJV)

“We shall see him as he is” — this is the Christocentric definition of “face to face.” Not a canon of completed Scripture, not the maturation of the church’s institutional life, but the appearing of Christ and the transformation his appearing produces. Moses spoke with God face to face, and his face shone so brightly that Israel could not look at him (2 Corinthians 3:7-8). When believers see Christ as he is, they will be *like him* — transformed by the encounter. Paul’s mirror-to-face progression leads here.

This does not settle every debate about the gifts. But it establishes something crucial: Paul’s “face to face” has deep Christological roots, and those roots grow in eschatological soil.

Jesus’s Teaching on the Spirit and “All Truth”

Jesus’s farewell discourse in John 14-16 introduces a tension that runs directly through 1 Corinthians 13, and honest interpretation must sit with it rather than resolve it prematurely.

On the night before his crucifixion, Jesus told his disciples:

“But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you.” — John 14:26 (KJV)

And then, a few moments later:

“I have yet many things to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now. Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will shew you things to come. He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you. All things that the Father hath are mine: therefore said I, that he shall take of mine, and shall shew it unto you.” — John 16:12-15 (KJV)

Three things are worth observing carefully.

First, Jesus explicitly acknowledges a present limitation: “ye cannot bear them now.” The disciples’ capacity for truth is partial — not because they are faithless, but because they are unprepared. There is more truth than they can currently receive. This is precisely the condition Paul describes in 1 Corinthians 13: knowing “in part,” prophesying “in part.”

Second, the Spirit’s mission is to guide into *all* truth (*pasan tēn alētheian*). The Spirit will not leave the church in permanent partial-knowledge. There is a completeness the Spirit intends.

Third, the Spirit’s work glorifies *Jesus* — “He shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you.” The content the Spirit reveals is Christological at its core. All truth that the Spirit brings points to Christ.

Now the question must be asked honestly: Is the Spirit's guidance into "all truth" the same as "the perfect" coming in 1 Corinthians 13:10?

Those who argue that "the perfect" refers to the completion of the New Testament canon find a foothold here. Jesus promises the Spirit will guide the apostles into all truth; the apostolic writings are the fruit of that guidance; when that canon was complete, "that which is perfect" arrived in the sense of a completed revelation. The partial prophetic gifts were then superseded by the whole of Scripture.

Those who argue that "the perfect" refers to Christ's return answer differently: the Spirit's work of guiding into all truth is an *ongoing* process throughout the church age, not a completed event in the first century. The Spirit still illumines, still teaches, still draws believers deeper into Christological knowledge. The *consummation* of the Spirit's work — knowing "even as also I am known" — awaits the return of Christ and the resurrection.

Both readings take John 16 seriously. The text does not adjudicate between them. What it does confirm is that the movement from partial to complete knowledge is a Pneumatological reality — the Spirit is the agent of the very transition Paul is describing. And the content of that completion is, by Jesus's own words, relentlessly Christological.

Jesus's Teaching on Love as the Supreme Ethic

The Christocentric lens has the most unambiguous thing to say about *one* element of 1 Corinthians 13: the supremacy of love.

When a lawyer asked Jesus to name the greatest commandment, he replied:

"Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets."
— Matthew 22:37-40 (KJV)

On the night of his betrayal, Jesus pressed this further:

"A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another." — John 13:34-35 (KJV)

And then, in his final discourse before the Passion:

"This is my commandment, That ye love one another, as I have loved you. Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friends." — John 15:12-13 (KJV)

Paul's elevation of love over gifts in 1 Corinthians 13 is not an independent theological innovation. It is a direct application — one could say an exposition — of Jesus's own teaching. When Paul writes that gifts without love profit nothing (v. 3), he is drawing on the logic of Matthew 22 and John 13. Love is not one virtue among others that happens to rank highest. Love is the summary and ground of all the others.

This has a direct bearing on the question of the gifts. The charismatic gifts — prophecy, tongues, knowledge — are not the summit of Christian life in Jesus's teaching. Love is. The gifts are, at best, *servants* of love. If gifts exist to build up the body (1 Corinthians

14:12), and building up the body is an expression of love, then gifts are instrumental — they serve love, love does not serve them.

This does not determine when the gifts will cease. But it places them in their proper relation: love is the permanent reality; gifts are the temporary expression. The container changes; what it carries does not.

Jesus on Maturity: “Be Ye Perfect”

One of the most direct Christological contributions to this study is also one that is easy to overlook, because it comes from the Sermon on the Mount rather than from a passage explicitly about the gifts.

Jesus commanded his disciples:

“Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect.”
— Matthew 5:48 (KJV)

The Greek reads: Ἔσεσθε οὖν ὑμεῖς τέλειοι ὡς ὁ πατήρ ὑμῶν ὁ οὐράνιος τέλειός ἐστιν — *esesthe oun humeis teleioi*, “ye shall be perfect.” The verb is a future indicative of *eimi* carrying imperatival force, on the Septuagint’s own pattern for covenant commands (“Ye shall be holy,” ἅγιοι ἔσεσθε, Lev. 19:2 LXX) — a command wearing the grammar of a promise. The word for “perfect” is *teleioi* — the plural adjective form of the same root (*teleios*) that appears in the neuter singular *to teleion* of 1 Corinthians 13:10.

This matters because the command is addressed to present-tense Christian living. Jesus is issuing a demand on the Sermon on the Mount community — the disciples who follow him now, who love their enemies now, who give alms and pray and fast now — even as the future-indicative form quietly points forward. *Teleios* in Jesus’s mouth describes something to be *pursued*, not only awaited.

The context in Matthew 5 is important. Jesus has been teaching the ethic of the kingdom: do not resist evil, love your enemies, pray for those who persecute you. The concluding imperative — “be perfect as your Father is perfect” — climaxes this sequence. The “perfection” in view is *moral wholeness*, the integrity of love that does not distinguish between friends and enemies. The Father causes the sun to rise on the evil and the good alike (v. 45); his love is undifferentiated, complete, without partiality. That wholeness is what Jesus calls *teleios*.

This usage complicates, but also enriches, the interpretation of 1 Corinthians 13:10. If *teleios* is the standard Jesus sets for present Christian life in the Sermon on the Mount, then a reading of “the perfect” in 1 Corinthians 13 that is *entirely* future risks severing Paul’s eschatological horizon from his ethical argument. Paul is not merely predicting an event; he is describing a state — completeness, maturity, full knowledge — that has both a present pursuit (*be perfect*, Matthew 5:48) and a future consummation (face to face, 1 Corinthians 13:12).

The Christocentric lens does not allow “the perfect” to float free of the ongoing call to mature love. Whatever else “the perfect” includes, it includes what Jesus commanded in the Sermon on the Mount.

Jesus's Teaching on His Own Return

Whatever weight the maturity-reading of *teleios* carries, Jesus was equally clear that his own return is a future, definitive, public event that will transform the condition of his people.

In his Upper Room discourse, Jesus made a promise as simple as any in the Gospels:

“And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.” — John 14:3 (KJV)

After the resurrection, as the disciples watched him ascend, two angels confirmed the manner of his return:

“Ye men of Galilee, why stand ye gazing up into heaven? this same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner as ye have seen him go into heaven.” — Acts 1:11 (KJV)

“This same Jesus” — not a spiritual influence, not a doctrine, not a completed canon, but the person himself, in like manner as he departed. The return is personal and visible.

In the Olivet Discourse, Jesus described the gathering that his return will effect:

“And then shall appear the sign of the Son of man in heaven: and then shall all the tribes of the earth mourn, and they shall see the Son of man coming in the clouds of heaven with power and great glory. And he shall send his angels with a great sound of a trumpet, and they shall gather together his elect from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other.” — Matthew 24:30-31 (KJV)

And the book of Revelation — given in the name of Jesus, delivered to John by his angel — brings the arc to its conclusion:

“And they shall see his face; and his name shall be in their foreheads.” — Revelation 22:4 (KJV)

“They shall see his face.” This is the ultimate face-to-face: not a mirror, not a dark speech, not prophetic mediation, but the unobstructed vision of Christ's face by every believer in the consummated kingdom.

The Christocentric trajectory is clear: from present partial knowledge, through the Spirit's ongoing work, to the moment when Christ appears and every believer sees him *as he is* (1 John 3:2). That final “face to face” of Revelation 22:4 is the destination toward which Paul's “then face to face” in 1 Corinthians 13:12 is pointing — if the eschatological reading is correct.

The “Already/Not Yet” in Jesus's Teaching

Jesus's teaching on the kingdom of God contains a sustained tension that any reading of “the perfect” must reckon with: the kingdom is both present *and* future, already here *and* still coming.

He said:

“The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.” — Luke 17:20-21 (KJV)

The kingdom is *within you* — present, interior, active now.

And yet he taught his disciples to pray:

“Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.” — Matthew 6:10 (KJV)

The kingdom is *coming* — future, not yet fully arrived, still to be consummated.

The parables he told about the kingdom point in both directions simultaneously. The mustard seed and the leaven (Matthew 13:31-33) describe organic growth — slow, incremental, process-oriented. The kingdom grows from small beginnings to great completion; it does not arrive all at once. But the ten virgins and the thief in the night (Matthew 25:1-13; Matthew 24:43) describe a sudden, unannounced arrival — an event that catches some prepared and others not. The same kingdom is simultaneously a *process* and an *event*.

This Christological tension maps directly onto the debate about 1 Corinthians 13:10. If the kingdom is both growing *now* (mustard seed) and arriving *then* (the bridegroom at midnight), then “the perfect” may participate in the same already/not yet structure. There is a present dimension: maturity in love, growth in knowledge, the Spirit’s ongoing teaching. And there is a future dimension: the arrival of Christ himself, the “face to face” that requires his appearing.

It would be a mistake, christologically speaking, to flatten this tension in either direction — to say “the perfect” is *only* a present process (as some maturity readings do) or *only* a future eschatological event (as some cessationist readings do). Jesus did not flatten the tension. He held it, and let the parables do their work in both directions at once.

Jesus’s Priorities: How We Handle Disagreement

The final Christocentric word on this question is the most practical, and perhaps the most demanding.

On the night before his death, Jesus prayed for those who would believe through the apostolic witness — which is to say, he prayed for every reader of 1 Corinthians 13 who has ever argued about what “the perfect” means:

“Neither pray I for these alone, but for them also which shall believe on me through their word; That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me. And the glory which thou gavest me I have given them; that they may be one, even as we are one: I in them, and thou in me, that they may be made perfect in one...” — John 17:20-23 (KJV)

“That they may be made perfect in one.” The word is again *teteleiōmenoi* (τετελειωμένοι) — from the same root as *teleios*, *to teleion*. Whatever “the perfect” is, Jesus prays that its character will mark his people in their *unity*.

He also provided a framework for resolving disputes:

“Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone: if he shall hear thee, thou hast gained thy brother.” — Matthew 18:15 (KJV)

The aim of the process is “gained thy brother” — not “won the argument,” not “established the doctrine,” but preserved the relationship.

The Christocentric test for how we hold any position about “the perfect” is not merely: *Is my exegesis correct?* It is: *Am I holding this position in a way that promotes love and preserves unity?* A technically precise cessationist who treats charismatics with contempt has failed the love test. A charismatic who dismisses cessationist concerns as faithlessness has failed the unity test. The exegetical question and the relational question cannot be separated — not in Jesus’s teaching.

This is not a call to unprincipled tolerance. Paul himself was capable of sharp disagreement. But the *manner* of holding and debating convictions about gifts must pass through John 17 before it reaches any pulpit or any comment section.

Summary: What the Christocentric Lens Reveals

The Christocentric examination of 1 Corinthians 13:10 yields the following:

On “face to face”: The phrase carries deep Mosaic typology. Moses had “face to face” knowledge of God uniquely, and Paul’s contrast between present mirror-and-enigma knowledge and future face-to-face knowledge draws on that tradition. Jesus is the new and greater Moses, the one who has fully declared the Father. The ultimate “face to face” is seeing Christ himself, as 1 John 3:2 and Revelation 22:4 both confirm. The Christocentric reading strongly favors a personal, eschatological referent for “face to face.”

On present maturity: Matthew 5:48 establishes that *teleios* is not only eschatological. Jesus uses the same root to describe what his disciples must pursue *now*. This provides Christological support for readings of “the perfect” that include present maturity and growth — though it does not exclude the eschatological dimension.

On the Spirit: John 14:26 and 16:12-15 confirm that the move from partial knowledge to complete truth is Pneumatological. The Spirit is the agent of the transition Paul describes. Whether the Spirit’s work of guiding into “all truth” was completed with the apostolic canon or continues to unfold is a question the Christocentric lens alone cannot resolve.

On love: Jesus’s teaching is unambiguous. Love is supreme. Gifts serve love; love does not serve gifts. Whatever “the perfect” is, it is not a state where love becomes less important. It is the state where love is finally unimpeded.

On the already/not yet: Jesus consistently held together the present and future dimensions of the kingdom. “The perfect” likely participates in this same tension — a present pursuit and a future arrival.

On disagreement: John 17 and Matthew 18 demand that the *manner* of holding convictions about gifts be as subject to the love test as any other aspect of Christian life. Exegetical confidence does not exempt anyone from the command to love.

The Christocentric lens does not produce a verdict. It produces a richer question, and a more demanding one: Whatever “the perfect” is, are we pursuing it in a way that looks like the one who promised to come again?

Chapter 3 examines how the earliest Christians — those within one to two generations of the apostles — understood 1 Corinthians 13:10 and the question of the gifts.

Chapter 3: Antiquity — How Did the Earliest Christians Understand This?

Why the Early Church Matters

The Christians of the first three centuries read Paul’s letters as living correspondence, not as ancient documents. The Corinthian correspondence was already being cited within a generation of its composition. These earliest interpreters were not better exegetes than we are, and they were not infallible — but they were closer. They knew the apostolic voice directly or through teachers who did. They practiced their faith without the protection of state power and often under its threat. Their testimony carries weight not because they are authorities equal to Scripture, but because of their proximity to the source.

The pre-Nicene cutoff (325 AD) marks the Council of Nicaea and the beginning of the church-state alliance under Constantine. Before that date, Christian theology was being worked out under pressure, not under patronage. This matters for our question.

A critical observation before we begin: The New Testament canon was still being discussed and debated throughout the period covered by this chapter. Athanasius’s Festal Letter 39 (367 AD) is the first document to list exactly the twenty-seven books of our current New Testament. The Council of Hippo (393 AD) and Carthage (397 AD) gave conciliar affirmation to that list. This means that when Irenaeus, Origen, Tertullian, and Chrysostom were reading and interpreting 1 Corinthians 13, the “completed canon of Scripture” did not yet exist as a defined entity. Any interpretation that identifies “the perfect” with the completed canon must reckon with the fact that the very fathers who were interpreting the passage lived before that canon was formally closed — and none of them made this connection.

Caution on arguments from silence: The early fathers often do not address a passage explicitly. When they do not comment on 1 Corinthians 13:10, that silence tells us nothing certain — it may mean the question was not urgent, not that they would have agreed with any particular interpretation. We note silences honestly but do not build cases on them.

The fathers are witnesses, not authorities. When they agree, their agreement is significant. When they conflict with Scripture clearly understood, Scripture takes priority. This chapter presents their testimony; the reader weighs it.

Part One: The Apostolic Fathers (c. 70–150 AD)

The Didache (c. 70–100 AD)

Context: The *Didache* (“Teaching of the Twelve Apostles”) is one of the earliest surviving Christian documents outside the New Testament, probably originating in Syria. It functions as a church manual covering baptism, fasting, prayer, the Eucharist, and eschatological watchfulness. It does not interpret 1 Corinthians 13:10 explicitly. Its significance here is the picture it gives of early Christian eschatological orientation.

Didache 16:1-2 reads:

“Watch for your life’s sake. Let not your lamps be quenched, nor your loins unloosed; but be ready, for you know not the hour in which our Lord comes. But often shall you come together, seeking the things which are befitting to your souls: for the whole time of your faith will not profit you, if you be not made perfect in the last time.” — Didache 16:1-2 (M. B. Riddle translation, ANF Vol. 7)

Significance: The Didache closes with an urgent eschatological appeal. The phrase “made perfect in the last time” (*teleiōthēte en tō eschatō kairō*) is noteworthy: it uses *teleiōō* (the verbal cognate of *teleios*) and connects completion or perfection explicitly with the end time, not with any present achievement. This is not an interpretation of 1 Corinthians 13:10, but it reflects the same semantic world: completeness belongs to the eschatological horizon.

Clement of Rome (c. 96 AD), 1 Clement

Context: Clement of Rome wrote to the fractious Corinthian church — the same community Paul addressed — around 96 AD, a generation after Paul’s letters. His letter is the earliest post-apostolic Christian document we possess outside the Didache. Chapters 49–50 contain a remarkable extended meditation on love that directly echoes 1 Corinthians 13.

1 Clement 49:1–5 reads:

“Let him who has love in Christ keep the commandments of Christ. Who can describe the [blessed] bond of the love of God? What man is able to tell the excellence of its beauty, as it ought to be told? The height to which love exalts is unspeakable. Love unites us to God. Love covers a multitude of sins. Love bears all things, is long-suffering in all things. There is nothing base, nothing arrogant in love. Love admits of no schisms: love gives rise to no seditions: love does all things in harmony. By love have all the elect of God been made perfect; without love nothing is well-pleasing to God.” — 1 Clement 49:1-5 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

And later in chapter 50:

“Blessed are we, beloved, if we keep the commandments of God in the harmony of love; that so through love our sins may be forgiven us.” — 1 Clement 50 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

Significance: Clement does not quote 1 Corinthians 13 explicitly, but he is saturated in its vocabulary. Clement’s “love bears all things, is long-suffering in all things” (ἀγάπη

πάντα ἀνέχεται, πάντα μακροθυμεῖ) echoes the substance of 1 Corinthians 13:4 and 13:7, though with different verbs than Paul's — the ANF's English "bears all things" happens to coincide with the KJV of 13:7 (πάντα στέγει), but the Greek wording is Clement's own. More importantly, Clement writes that "by love have all the elect of God been made perfect (*eteleiōthēsan*).” For Clement, love is the instrument of final perfection — a connection that aligns with Paul's own argument that love outlasts the partial gifts. Clement offers no interpretation of "the perfect" in verse 10, but his love-theology is grounded in 1 Corinthians 13, and he does not constrain perfection to the present age.

Ignatius of Antioch (c. 107 AD)

Context: Ignatius, bishop of Antioch, wrote seven letters while being transported to Rome under military guard for execution, probably during the reign of Trajan (98–117 AD). His letters are invaluable: they are occasional, urgent, and written by someone within living memory of the apostles. He is the first writer outside the New Testament to quote from Paul's letters with some regularity.

To the Ephesians 14:1 reads:

“None of these things is hid from you, if you perfectly possess that faith and love towards Christ Jesus which are the beginning and the end of life. For the beginning is faith, and the end is love.” — Ignatius, To the Ephesians 14:1 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

The Greek of the key phrase runs: ἀρχὴ μὲν πίστις, τέλος δὲ ἀγάπη (“beginning is faith, end/completion is love”). Ignatius uses *telos* here in its fullest sense — love is not merely a conclusion but the *completion* toward which faith aims.

Significance: Ignatius draws a direct line from faith (present, partial) to love (the *telos*, the completion). Whether he is consciously echoing 1 Corinthians 13 or simply breathing the same apostolic air, his conceptual framework is identical: the present state (faith) is partial and forward-pointing; love is the completion. This does not resolve what Paul means by “the perfect,” but it shows how naturally the apostolic tradition connected *telos*-language with love as the eschatological goal.

Part Two: The Ante-Nicene Fathers (c. 150–325 AD)

Irenaeus of Lyon (c. 130–202 AD), Against Heresies

Context: Irenaeus was bishop of Lyon (in modern France) and is our most important second-century theological witness. A disciple of Polycarp, who was himself a disciple of John, Irenaeus preserves a strand of theology with genuine apostolic genealogy. His major work, *Against Heresies* (*Adversus Haereses*, written c. 180 AD), is a sustained refutation of Gnostic systems that claimed superior, hidden knowledge. In this context, 1 Corinthians 13:9-12 becomes a key text: the Gnostics claimed to possess *complete* knowledge now; Paul, Irenaeus argues, teaches that complete knowledge is not yet available.

From AH 2.28.3 (ANF Vol. 1, p. 401). The larger argument of Book 2, chapter 28, is that human beings cannot comprehend God's full purposes, and that intellectual

humility is the proper Christian posture. Irenaeus summarizes the Pauline basis for this humility as follows:

“If, therefore, even with respect to creation, there are some things [the knowledge of] which belongs only to God, and others which come within the range of our own knowledge, what ground is there for complaint, if, in regard to those things which we investigate in the Scriptures (which are throughout spiritual), we are able by the grace of God to explain some of them, while we must leave others in the hands of God, and that not only in the present world, but also in that which is to come, so that God should for ever teach, and man should for ever learn the things taught him by God? As the apostle has said on this point, that, when other things have been done away, then these three, faith, hope, and charity, shall endure.” — Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 2.28.3 (Roberts-Rambaut translation, ANF Vol. 1)

Irenaeus then explicitly draws on the “in part / when that which is perfect is come” language to argue that the full knowledge the Gnostics claim is not available in this age. The “perfect” — the complete, comprehensive knowledge — belongs to the age to come.

From AH 5.6.1 (ANF Vol. 1, p. 531). Here Irenaeus addresses the resurrection body and what a “complete” human being looks like:

“Now the soul and the spirit are certainly a part of the man, but certainly not the man; for the perfect man consists in the commingling and the union of the soul receiving the spirit of the Father, and the admixture of that fleshly nature which was moulded after the image of God.” — Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 5.6.1 (Roberts-Rambaut translation, ANF Vol. 1)

Significance: In AH 2.28.3, Irenaeus interprets the present age as a time of partial knowledge and looks to the future age for its completion. His argument against Gnostic claims of complete present knowledge is precisely that Paul denies it: we know “in part” now; the complete (*to teleion*) is ahead. In AH 5.6.1, *teleios* denotes the complete, resurrected human being. Both usages point forward, not to a present achievement or a completed document. **It should be noted:** Irenaeus lived during a period when the New Testament canon was still being assembled. He is the first writer to speak of four Gospels as a unit, but the broader canon had not yet been defined. He does not connect “the perfect” with the completion of Scripture — the very category did not exist in his time.

The Anonymous Anti-Montanist (c. 192/193 AD), quoted by Eusebius

Context: The earliest datable interpretation of 1 Corinthians 13:8-12 anywhere in Christian literature comes from the Montanist crisis. The “New Prophecy” of Montanus claimed that the Paraclete was delivering fuller, final revelation through its prophets — the nearest ancient analog to any reading that locates a completion of revelation after Paul. An anonymous churchman, writing about the fourteenth year after the death of the prophetess Maximilla (which places him in the early 190s), answered the movement from this very passage; Eusebius preserves his words:

“For the apostle thought it necessary that the prophetic gift should continue in all the Church until the final coming.” — Anonymous anti-Montanist, in

Eusebius, *Church History* 5.17.4 (McGiffert translation, NPNF Series 2, Vol. 1)

Significance: Two things follow. First, the earliest recorded exegesis of the passage reads it as teaching that the prophetic gift continues “until the final coming” — the eschatological reading, present at the very fountainhead of the interpretive tradition. Second, the first recorded *appropriation* of the passage in the completed-revelation direction was the Montanists’ own claim (Augustine and Theodoret later report their reading that Paul’s “partial” anticipated the Paraclete’s fuller revelation) — and the church answered it with this text, not from it. This is a historical observation, not a polemical equation: the canon view is not Montanism, and its advocates ground themselves in Scripture’s sufficiency, not new prophecy. But the shape of the second-century exchange shows that when ancient Christians first confronted a claim that revelation’s completion had superseded the partial, they read 1 Corinthians 13 *against* the claim (Shogren, “How Did They Suppose ‘the Perfect’ Would Come?”, *JPT* 15 [1999]: 99-121, which surveys the whole exchange).

Clement of Alexandria (c. 150–215 AD), *Stromata* and *Paedagogus*

Context: Titus Flavius Clemens (not Clement of Rome) was the head of the Catechetical School of Alexandria, the most intellectually sophisticated center of early Christian learning. His major work, the *Stromata* (“Miscellanies,” c. 195–215 AD), is a sprawling, deliberately unsystematic collection of theological reflections. Clement operated at the intersection of Christian faith and Greek philosophy. He developed the concept of the “true Gnostic” — the mature Christian believer who has progressed from simple faith to deeper knowledge through virtue and contemplation.

In *Stromata* 7.10.57 (PG 9, col. 473), Clement argues that faith is the beginning and knowledge (*gnosis*) is the completion — *faith as the foundation, knowledge built upon it* (this study’s summary of Clement’s argument — not a quotation; the ANF Vol. 2 Wilson translation renders the concept but the phrasing varies).

More directly relevant is Clement’s distinction between the *ek merous* (partial) believer and the mature believer. Across *Stromata* 7 — notably 7.10, “Steps to Perfection” — Clement develops the idea that partial apprehension belongs to an earlier stage of Christian growth, while mature knowledge (*gnosis*) belongs to the advanced believer: the “in part” describes the beginning stage; “the perfect” the mature believer’s fuller apprehension of divine truth. His direct handling of vv. 11-12, however, is in *Paedagogus* 1.6, and it complicates his classification in a direction that matters. There Clement reads “when I was a child” as Paul’s life under the law (“when I was a Jew... I thought as a child, when I followed the law; but after becoming a man, I no longer entertain the sentiments of a child”) — a salvation-historical, not developmental, reading of verse 11. And on verse 12 Clement himself writes that the “meat” the Corinthians could not yet bear “may indicate the clear revelation in the future world, like food, face to face. For now we see as through a glass, the same apostle says, but then face to face” (*Paedagogus* 1.6, ANF Vol. 2). So even the tradition’s one maturity-reader, when he handles verse 12 directly, places the face-to-face in the future world. Clement’s maturity reading concerns the believer’s present growth; his verse 12 remains eschatological.

A critical note on Clement’s quotations: The Clement sections of the ANF translation (Vol. 2, William Wilson translation) are often paraphrase and condensation rather than

strict translation of the Greek. The PG edition (*Patrologia Graeca*, Vols. 8 and 9) preserves the Greek text. Readers wanting to verify Clement's exact wording should consult PG 8 (*Paedagogus*) and PG 9 (*Stromata*) directly. The argument summarized above is Clement's, faithfully represented, but readers should not treat the paraphrase as a direct quotation.

Significance: Clement is the earliest advocate for what we might call the "maturity" interpretation of "the perfect." For him, *to teleion* is not primarily an eschatological event but a present spiritual trajectory — the progression from immature faith to mature knowledge, available in principle to any dedicated believer in this life. This is a genuine outlier in the early tradition: Clement's Platonic and Stoic philosophical influences shape his reading in a direction that differs from the more consistently eschatological readings of Irenaeus, Tertullian, and Origen. It is worth noting that Clement's "gnosis" is emphatically not heretical Gnosticism; he uses the term to describe orthodox Christian maturity. But his interpretation does plant a seed that would later grow into various forms of the "spiritual completeness" reading.

Tertullian (c. 155–240 AD)

Context: Quintus Septimius Florens Tertullianus was a North African apologist writing from Carthage. He is the first major Latin theological writer, and his work spans apology, polemic, and what we would now call dogmatic theology. Tertullian is notable for his Montanist sympathies in his later career (Montanism was a charismatic renewal movement that claimed ongoing prophetic gifts). This background makes his testimony particularly interesting: a man who believed in the continuation of spiritual gifts interpreted "the perfect" as the resurrection, not as the completion of any present-age phenomenon.

From *Adversus Praxeum (Against Praxeas)*, chapter 14 (ANF Vol. 3, Holmes translation). Arguing about the visibility of God, Tertullian sets Numbers 12:6-8 — God's "mouth to mouth" speech with Moses, "not enigmatically" — directly beside 1 Corinthians 13:12:

"...not as with Moses, with whom I shall speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, that is to say, in truth, and not enigmatically, that is to say, in image; as the apostle also expresses it, 'Now we see through a glass, darkly (or enigmatically), but then face to face.' Since, therefore, He reserves to some future time His presence and speech face to face with Moses — a promise which was afterwards fulfilled in the retirement of the mount (of transfiguration), when as we read in the Gospel, Moses appeared talking with Jesus — it is evident that in early times it was always in a glass, (as it were,) and an enigma, in vision and dream, that God, I mean the Son of God, appeared — to the prophets and the patriarchs, as also to Moses indeed himself." — Tertullian, *Against Praxeas* 14 (Holmes translation, ANF Vol. 3)

Significance: Two things stand out. First, Tertullian explicitly connects Numbers 12:6-8 with 1 Corinthians 13:12 — the same Moses-and-enigma typology this study's Chapter 1 develops. The connection is not a modern construction; the first major Latin theologian read the two texts together. Second, Tertullian "reserves to some future time" the face-to-face encounter — for Moses, fulfilled at the Transfiguration in seeing Christ visibly; for believers, still ahead. He does not comment on verse 10 directly, so

his exact understanding of “the perfect” cannot be pinned (Decker’s survey draws the same conclusion); but his instinct for the passage runs future-ward, toward the visible presence of Christ — never toward a completed text. Writing as a man who believed the gifts continued in his own day, he had every occasion to notice a canon-completion reading if one had existed. He gives no hint of one.

Origen of Alexandria (c. 185–254 AD)

Context: Origen is the most prolific and most philosophically sophisticated of the Ante-Nicene fathers. Born in Alexandria and later based in Caesarea, he produced the first systematic Christian theology (*De Principiis* / *Peri Archon*), the massive *Hexapla* (a six-column Old Testament comparison), and extensive biblical commentaries. His commentary on 1 Corinthians survives only in fragments, preserved in later catena (chain commentary) manuscripts. His systematic work, however, addresses the themes of 1 Corinthians 13 at several points.

From *De Principiis* (On First Principles) 2.11.3-4 (ANF Vol. 4, pp. 297–298, Crombie translation; Greek fragments in PG 11, cols. 237–240). In his discussion of the afterlife and the progressive education of souls, Origen argues that what we understand now “in part” (*ek merous*) will be replaced by comprehensive understanding when we enter the presence of God directly. He envisions this as a multi-stage process: even in the age to come, souls continue to grow in knowledge of God, but “the perfect” represents the state when the partial is finally and entirely superseded. Origen reads 1 Corinthians 13:9-12 as describing an eschatological transition, not a present-age achievement. (Note: the original Greek of *De Principiis* is largely lost; we depend primarily on Rufinus’s Latin translation, which is at times an adaptation rather than a strict rendering. The argument summarized here is Origen’s own, faithfully represented.)

From the Commentary on 1 Corinthians (fragments in catenae): Fragments attributed to Origen on 1 Corinthians 13 indicate that he understood the “in part” as the condition of every believer in this age — knowledge mediated through Scripture, through the Spirit’s teaching, through analogy and type — and “the perfect” as the direct, unmediated knowledge of God available in the age to come. The Greek distinction that mattered to him was between *gnōsis ek merous* (partial knowledge) and *epignōsis* (complete, face-to-face recognition), the very distinction Paul draws in verse 12: *tote de epignōsomai kathōs kai epegnōsthēn* (“then I shall know fully, even as I have been fully known”).

Significance: Origen holds what might be called a “progressive eschatology” position: knowledge grows both now (through the Spirit and Scripture) and in the age to come (through direct divine presence), but the decisive transition — when the partial is finally “done away” — is the eschatological moment of entering God’s direct presence. He bridges the “maturity” and “eschatological” readings, but the decisive transition is future, not present.

Methodius of Olympus (c. 260–311 AD), Banquet of the Ten Virgins

Context: Methodius, bishop and martyr (d. c. 311), wrote the *Banquet of the Ten Virgins* (*Symposium*) as a Christian counterpart to Plato's dialogue — ten virgins discoursing on chastity and the resurrection hope. In Discourse 9 he sets the law, the church, and the coming kingdom in a shadow-image-reality sequence and reaches directly for 1 Corinthians 13:

“For now we know in part, and as it were through a glass, since that which is perfect has not yet come to us; namely, the kingdom of heaven and the resurrection, when that which is in part shall be done away.” — Methodius, *Banquet of the Ten Virgins* 9.2 (William R. Clark translation, ANF Vol. 6)

Significance: This is among the most explicit pre-Nicene identifications of “the perfect” anywhere in the tradition: Methodius supplies the referent himself — “namely, the kingdom of heaven and the resurrection” — and continues, “For then will all our tabernacles be firmly set up, when again the body shall rise.” Writing within two decades of Nicaea, a bishop of the persecuted church glosses *to teleion* eschatologically as a matter of course, with no alternative in view.

Part Three: The Post-Nicene Witness (for context, noting the pre-325 boundary)

The SCAR framework places primary weight on pre-Nicene evidence. The following post-Nicene fathers (Ambrosiaster, Chrysostom, and Augustine) are included because they represent the most detailed and influential patristic interpretations of this specific passage, and their readings illuminate the trajectory of the tradition.

Ambrosiaster (c. 366–384 AD), Commentary on 1 Corinthians

Context: “Ambrosiaster” is the modern name for the anonymous author of the earliest complete Latin commentary on Paul's epistles, written at Rome in the later fourth century and long transmitted under Ambrose's name (Latin text in PL 17; critical edition CSEL 81). His comment on 1 Corinthians 13 is the earliest surviving verse-by-verse Latin treatment of the passage.

On verse 12 (translation of the PL 17 text by Charles A. Sullivan):

“It has now been revealed to see the images by faith, then the events themselves. ... That is, I will see what has been promised even as I am being seen. This is to be present near the Lord where Christ is.” — Ambrosiaster, *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 13:12 (Sullivan translation of the PL 17 text)

Significance: The earliest Latin commentator refers the “then” of verse 12 to being “present near the Lord where Christ is” — and in the adjacent comment he reaches for 1 John 3:2 (“at that time we will see that one, even as He is”), the same cross-reference this study's Chapter 2 develops. No connection to a completed canon appears anywhere in his treatment; the gifts are “purged” when imperfection “is completed into truth.”

John Chrysostom (c. 347–407 AD), *Homilies on 1 Corinthians*, Homily 34

Context: John “Chrysostom” (the “golden-mouthed”) was bishop of Constantinople and the greatest preacher of antiquity. His *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* (NPNF Series 1, Vol. 12, pp. 196–205) provide the most sustained patristic exegesis of 1 Corinthians 13. Homily 34 covers 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 in detail. The Greek text is preserved in PG 61, cols. 285–294.

On the meaning of “the perfect” (1 Cor 13:10), Chrysostom writes:

“It is not therefore knowledge that is done away, but the circumstance that our knowledge is in part. For we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more. ... But then shall we know somewhat more and clearer concerning these things.” — Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 34.2 (Chambers translation, NPNF 1.12, p. 202)

On the mirror analogy (1 Cor 13:12):

“For now we see in a mirror. Further, because the glass sets before us the thing seen indefinitely, he added, darkly, to show very strongly that the present knowledge is most partial. But then face to face. Not as though God has a face, but to express the notion of greater clearness and perspicuity.” — Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 34 (Chambers translation, NPNF 1.12)

Chrysostom identifies “the perfect” with the complete knowledge of the age to come — when the partial mode of knowing gives way and we know “somewhat more and clearer,” no longer “in a mirror... darkly” but “face to face.” Decker’s survey characterizes his position the same way: complete knowledge, “which from the context of his remarks, will be when we see God.” Chrysostom does not connect the cessation of the partial gifts to a completed canon; for him the partial gives way when the complete arrives.

On the question of when gifts cease, Chrysostom’s exegetical argument is that gifts belong to the present age and will not be needed when believers see God directly. But as a matter of observed fact, Chrysostom believed the miraculous gifts had already ceased in his own day. Opening his exposition of the gifts material, he says of the whole subject:

“This whole place is very obscure: but the obscurity is produced by our ignorance of the facts referred to, and by their cessation, being such as then used to occur but now no longer take place.” — Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 29.1 (Chambers translation, NPNF 1.12)

This makes Chrysostom antiquity’s clearest witness that the eschatological reading of verse 10 and a functional cessationism can cohabit: he held both. He read “the perfect” as the resurrection *and* observed that the gifts of the apostolic age no longer occurred around him — without ever connecting their cessation to the completion of a canon. He is, in effect, a fourth-century anticipation of the modern cessationists who accept the eschatological reading of this verse while grounding cessation elsewhere.

Significance: Chrysostom reads “the perfect” as the complete, direct knowledge of God belonging to the age to come. This eschatological direction is the dominant reading in the Greek-speaking church. Shogren’s survey states the two-sidedness precisely: Chrysostom “insisted that his exegesis moved within the orbit of catholic eschatology,” yet “diverged from tradition because of his belief that tongues and prophecy had ceased

in the interim. Thus, a historical datum affected his exegesis, and he separated the fulfillment of 13.8 from the completion of 13.9-12.”

Augustine of Hippo (c. 354—430 AD), *De Trinitate* Book 15

Context: Augustine’s *De Trinitate* (written c. 399—419 AD) is one of the most ambitious works in the history of Christian thought — a sustained investigation of the Trinity through the analogy of the human mind. Book 15 brings the entire project to a conclusion by turning to 1 Corinthians 13:12, which Augustine treats as the key text for understanding the limits of present knowledge of God. The Latin text is in PL 42, cols. 1057—1098; the NPNF translation is Series 1, Vol. 3, pp. 200—228.

On “through a glass” and “in an enigma” (1 Cor 13:12):

“...and yet a man so great and so spiritual [as Paul] says, ‘We see now through a glass, in an enigma, but then face to face.’ If we ask what and of what sort is this glass, this assuredly occurs to our minds, that in a glass nothing is discerned but an image.” — Augustine, *De Trinitate* 15.8.14 (Haddan translation, NPNF 1.3)

And on the promised “face to face” sight:

“But when the sight shall have come which is promised anew to us face to face, we shall see this not only incorporeal but also absolutely indivisible and truly unchangeable Trinity far more clearly and certainly than we now see its image which we ourselves are.” — Augustine, *De Trinitate* 15.23.44 (Haddan translation, NPNF 1.3)

Augustine’s argument in Book 15 is meticulous. He explores every analogy by which finite minds might contemplate an infinite God, and his conclusion is that even the best analogy — seeing God’s image in the structure of the human mind — falls short. The “mirror” and “enigma” of 1 Corinthians 13:12 describe the condition of all present knowledge of God, however advanced. The “face to face” vision is categorically different: it is the beatific vision, the direct sight of God promised in the life to come.

Significance: Augustine places “the perfect” in the eschatological future — the beatific vision of God in eternity. He is also notable for his careful parsing of “in an enigma” (*in aenigmate*): seeing truth through figures, types, analogies, and partial revelations is the mode of all present knowledge, including knowledge received through Scripture. Scripture itself is part of the “mirror” — it mediates the divine but is not the direct vision. This directly undermines any reading that would identify “the completion of Scripture” with “the perfect,” since for Augustine Scripture belongs to the present age of mediated knowledge, not to the “face to face” age.

Part Four: Patterns and Observations

Having surveyed the evidence from c. 70 AD to c. 430 AD, several clear patterns emerge.

1. The dominant early reading is eschatological.

From the Didache's call to "be made perfect in the last time," through Irenaeus's argument that complete knowledge belongs to the age to come, through Tertullian's reserving of the face-to-face encounter "to some future time," through Origen's multi-stage eschatology, to Chrysostom's complete knowledge of the age to come and Augustine's beatific vision — the overwhelming weight of the ancient tradition reads *to teleion* as the future state that accompanies Christ's return, the resurrection of the dead, or the eternal presence of God.

2. Clement of Alexandria is the significant early exception.

Clement interprets "the perfect" as mature spiritual knowledge, available in principle to the dedicated believer in this life through the progression from faith to gnosis. This is the earliest witness to the "maturity" interpretation. Clement's reading is shaped by his Platonic philosophical inheritance and his apologetic project of showing Christianity's intellectual respectability. It is a genuine interpretation, not a misreading — but it stands largely alone in the early period.

3. No ancient interpreter connects "the perfect" with the completion of the biblical canon.

This is perhaps the most significant observation of this chapter. Not one pre-Nicene father, not one post-Nicene father before the modern period, identifies *to teleion* with the closing of the scriptural canon. The fathers who lived during the period when the canon was being defined — Irenaeus, Origen, Tertullian — were themselves part of that process, and none of them made the connection. Chrysostom and Augustine wrote after the 27-book canon had been defined by Athanasius (367 AD) and confirmed by Hippo (393 AD) and Carthage (397 AD), and they still do not make the connection. This is a sustained and consistent silence across the roughly three and a half centuries of surviving comment, from the Didache to Augustine, and across every major region of early Christianity. Nor does the silence end with antiquity. The medieval tradition continued the ancient direction: Aquinas glosses verse 10's *quod perfectum est* as *perfectio gloriae* — "the perfection of glory" — and locates the face-to-face vision *in patria*, "in the fatherland" (*Super I Epistolam ad Corinthios*, cap. 13), citing Numbers 12:6 in the same exposition, the same Moses-and-enigma linkage Tertullian had drawn a millennium earlier. And the fullest history of interpretation of this verse finds no writer even mentioning the canon identification before the nineteenth century — the earliest who does, Robert Govett (1813-1901), reports the view only to argue against it (Decker).

The pattern holds across every later father Decker's survey reaches. Cyprian cites the glass of verse 12 as still valid in his own day — "which would imply," Decker notes, "that he views the glass analogy to be still valid even after the completion of the canon." Basil relates *to teleion* to the complete knowledge of the truth in the life to come; Athanasius, Gregory Nazianzen, Gregory of Nyssa, Jerome, Theodoret, and Leo the Great handle the passage's partial-knowledge language as the condition of the present age over against the fuller knowledge ahead. The survey's last father, John of Damascus, reads "the perfect" as the law of Christ over against the law of Moses — a third interpretive direction. Precision matters here: his referent is a body of revelation within history, which shows that a revelational-corpus referent was ancient-*thinkable* — but it is the law of Christ as covenant reality, not a book-collection whose completion ends the gifts, and the silence on the canon identification itself remains total. Across these further witnesses and centuries, the canon identification never appears. Independent confirmation comes from Gary Shogren's study of the patristic exegesis of

this very passage — a survey built on “45 comments from the ante-Nicene fathers, and 149 from the Nicene and post-Nicene fathers,” gathered with the *Thesaurus Linguae Graecae*. His conclusion: “The evidence demands the conclusion that almost every church father understood the whole text of 1 Cor. 13.8-12 to be a prediction of the return of Christ.” And he sharpens the silence into something stronger than silence: the catholic church “believed that despite their possession of the Holy Spirit and the full canon (reference to the canon being implicit throughout the fathers, but explicit in Didymus Caecus, Ambrose, Gregory of Nyssa), the church would have to wait for the resurrection to see God’s truth perfectly.” Three fathers, that is, mention the completed canon in connection with this passage — and still refer perfection to the resurrection. Awareness plus non-identification is a harder fact than silence (“How Did They Suppose ‘the Perfect’ Would Come? 1 Corinthians 13.8-12 in Patristic Exegesis,” *Journal of Pentecostal Theology* 15 [1999]: 99-121; full text in Primary-Sources). Shogren also counts the extant ancient commentaries on the passage: five — Origen, Chrysostom, Theodoret, Ambrosiaster, and the sixth-century Pseudo-Primasius. This study engages the four that fall within or adjacent to its window.

The “completed canon” interpretation is a modern reading: its earliest known appearance in the history of interpretation is the nineteenth century, and there in a writer reporting the view in order to refute it (Decker). This does not make it wrong — later insights can be valid insights — but it means it carries no ancient attestation and must stand on exegetical grounds alone.

4. The “knowledge” theme runs through all ancient interpretations.

Whether eschatological (Irenaeus, Tertullian, Origen, Chrysostom, Augustine) or developmental (Clement), the ancient interpreters all anchor their reading in the *knowledge* dimension of Paul’s argument: knowing “in part” now, knowing “fully” then. The gifts — prophecy, tongues, knowledge — are partial precisely because our knowledge of God is partial. The completion of those gifts awaits the completion of our knowledge, which awaits either the maturity process (Clement) or the direct divine presence (everyone else).

5. The pre-Nicene fathers assumed spiritual gifts continued in their time.

This is worth stating carefully. The Ante-Nicene fathers do not treat 1 Corinthians 13 as a text about when the gifts would cease. They read it as a text about the relationship between the present age and the age to come. Tertullian, who was a Montanist and deeply committed to the continuation of prophecy and spiritual gifts, reads the passage as eschatological — the gifts give way to “the perfect” at the resurrection, not before. Irenaeus, writing against Gnostics who claimed complete present knowledge, does not suggest that the gifts had already ceased; he argues that *no one* in this age has complete knowledge. The question of when exactly the gifts would cease was not, for the ancient church, the question that 1 Corinthians 13:10 was answering.

6. The “face to face” language is consistently future and personal.

No surviving ancient gloss of “face to face” (*prosōpon pros prosōpon*) in verse 12 reads it as a metaphor for comprehensive textual access or as the Spirit’s illumination in the present age; those who comment on the clause read it as a future, personal encounter with God or Christ. The phrase carries in their reading the same weight it carries in the Old Testament (where it describes theophanic encounters: Gen 32:30, Exod 33:11, Deut 34:10) — direct, unmediated presence.

7. There is more interest in the hope of divine vision than in the cessation of

gifts.

Reading through the ancient interpreters, one is struck by where their interest lies. They are not primarily interested in which gifts will cease and when. They are drawn to the promise: that believers will one day see God directly, know as they are known, be complete as they are presently incomplete. The “doing away” of the partial is interesting to them chiefly as evidence of what the perfect must be like. The ancient church’s primary orientation toward 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 was hopeful and eschatological, not cessationist or polemical.

Summary (Antiquity)

The early church’s reading of 1 Corinthians 13:10 tilts strongly and consistently toward the eschatological: “the perfect” is the future state in which believers see God face to face at Christ’s return, in the resurrection, or in the eternal beatific vision. This reading spans the Apostolic Fathers, the major Ante-Nicene writers, and the great post-Nicene theologians of both East (Chrysostom) and West (Augustine).

The one significant exception is Clement of Alexandria, who reads “the perfect” as the goal of present spiritual maturation — knowledge that can grow toward completion in this life. His reading has been influential in mystical and contemplative traditions.

No ancient interpreter reads “the perfect” as the completed biblical canon. Given that the canon was itself still being formed during the Ante-Nicene period, this silence is not surprising — but it is significant. The “completed canon” interpretation has no ancient attestation and must make its case entirely on exegetical grounds.

The historical weight of the ancient tradition falls on the side of the eschatological reading. This does not close the question — later exegesis may illuminate what earlier readers missed, and the canon-completion reading might find support in the structure of Paul’s argument that the ancient church did not develop. But any account of 1 Corinthians 13:10 that claims to represent ancient Christianity must acknowledge that it is representing a tradition that pointed — with one exception, and that exception toward present maturity, never toward a text — at Christ’s return and the resurrection, not at any event in church history.

For the early church, “the perfect” was not something that had already come. It was the thing they were waiting for.

(Chapter 4 examines the major interpretive views held by Christians today, presenting each at its strongest.)

Chronological Summary Table (Chapter Preview)

Father	Date	Location	Primary Reading / Orientation (1 Cor 13:10-12)	Source
Didache	c. 70-100	Syria	Eschatological completion (indirect)	ANF Vol. 7
Clement of Rome	c. 96	Rome	Love as instrument of completion (no direct interp.)	ANF Vol. 1

Father	Date	Location	Primary Reading / Orientation (1 Cor 13:10-12)	Source
Ignatius	c. 107	Antioch	Love as <i>telos</i> of faith (no direct interp.)	ANF Vol. 1
Irenaeus	c. 180	Lyon	Future age: complete knowledge vs. present partial	ANF Vol. 1
Anony-mous anti-Montanist	c. 192/193	Asia Minor	Prophetic gift continues “until the final coming”	Eusebius, HE 5.17.4; NPNF 2.1
Clement of Alexandria	c. 200	Alexandria	Present maturity via gnosis (<i>Stromata</i>); refers v. 12 “face to face” to the future world (<i>Paedagogus</i> 1.6)	ANF Vol. 2
Tertullian	c. 208-213	Carthage	Future encounter (on v. 12 “face to face”; v. 10 not directly glossed — Praxeas 14)	ANF Vol. 3
Origen	c. 225	Alexandria	Eschatological: direct divine presence in age to come	ANF Vol. 4
Methodius	c. 290-311	Olympus	“The kingdom of heaven and the resurrection” (Banquet 9.2)	ANF Vol. 6
Ambrosi-aster	c. 366-384	Rome	Future life: “present near the Lord where Christ is” (on v. 12)	PL 17
Chrysos-tom	c. 390	Antioch/Con-stantinople	Complete knowledge of the age to come: “a great deal more” (Hom. 34.2)	NPNF 1.12
Augustine	c. 415	Hippo	Beatific vision: “the sight... which is promised anew to us face to face”	NPNF 1.3
Theodoret of Cyrrhus	c. 435-450	Cyrrhus, Syria	Present partial knowledge vs. resurrection intimacy: glosses ἐπεγνώσθην with ὡκειώθην, “made his own” (treated in Appendix B)	PG 82:336-337
Ps.-Oecumenius	10th-11th c.	Byzantine (Chrysostom epitomator)	“Perfect — that is, in the time to come”; “not as though God has a bodily face” (treated in Appendix B)	PG 118
Theophylact of Ohrid	c. 1078-1108	Ohrid (Chrysostom epitomator)	The perfect knowledge “of the life to come”; at the consummation faith and hope cease, love remains (treated in Appendix B)	PG 124

Chapter 4: Reality — The Major Views and Their Fruit

Overview (Reality)

Four main interpretive traditions have emerged from the history of reading 1 Corinthians 13:8-12. They are not equally distributed across the church’s history, and they are not equally supported by the exegetical evidence — but each deserves to be heard at its strongest before being evaluated.

The four views are:

1. **The Completed Canon** — “the perfect” = the finished New Testament

2. **Christ's Return** — "the perfect" = the parousia, the personal return of Jesus
3. **Church Maturity** — "the perfect" = the spiritual maturity of the church or its members
4. **The Eternal State** — "the perfect" = the new heavens and new earth, the consummated kingdom

An important structural observation: Views 2 and 4 overlap so significantly that many scholars treat them as a single position. Christ's return and the eternal state are not separated by a long interval in most interpretive frameworks — they are the same horizon of redemption viewed at different focal lengths. The practical theological divide in most churches is not between Views 2 and 4, but between View 1 (the canon view, which implies that revelatory gifts have ceased) and Views 2-4 (eschatological views, which imply they have not). The debate about this verse is often a proxy for the larger cessationist-continuationist dispute — but it should not be, because Paul's purpose in the passage is to exalt love, not to settle the gifts question.

View 1: The Completed Canon

Held By (View 1)

This view lives most densely in dispensational and fundamentalist Baptist cessationism, but its map is broader than sometimes assumed: verified advocates include the Reformed Baptist Walter Chantry (*Signs of the Apostles*, Banner of Truth, 1973 — "When Scripture is completed, then the church will have revelation thoroughly suited to her condition on earth"; a maturity-via-completed-Scripture blend, pp. 50-54), the British evangelical Victor Budgen (*The Charismatics and the Word of God*, Evangelical Press, 2d ed. 1989 — "'when perfection comes' means 'when Scripture is complete,'" p. 74), and, per D. A. Carson's survey, the Lutheran Douglas Judisch (*An Evaluation of Claims to the Charismatic Gifts*, Baker, 1978), of whose view Carson adds that it "is very common among noncharismatic writers treating this subject" (*Showing the Spirit*, p. 68 n. 56; all three verified via archive.org lending — Primary-Sources). The Reformed cessationist *mainstream* (Warfield, Gaffin) has nonetheless declined it, Gentry being the notable Reformed-Presbyterian exception. Its best-known early advocate is W. E. Vine — the lexicographer of the *Expository Dictionary* — whose posthumous *1 Corinthians* commentary states it plainly: "With the completion of Apostolic testimony and the completion of the Scriptures of truth... 'that which is perfect' had come, and the temporary gifts were done away. For the Scriptures provided by the Spirit of God were 'perfect'" (London: Oliphants, 1951, p. 184; verified against the 1961 printing). Notably, Vine immediately adds a second horizon on the same page — "It is also true that 'that which is perfect' is to be brought in at the Parousia of Christ when the Church is completed and caught up to be with Him" — so that even the canon view's chief advocate reads the verse with a dual reference, canon-first and Parousia-also. His *Expository Dictionary* compresses the same both/and into a single parenthesis: 1 Corinthians 13:10 refers "to the complete revelation of God's will and ways, whether in the completed Scriptures or in the hereafter" (s.v. "Perfect"; verified against the 1952 one-volume edition). Later advocates include Robert Gromacki (*The Modern Tongues Movement*, 1967, quoting Weaver's 1964 argument), Merrill F. Unger (*New Testament Teaching on Tongues*, 1971), and Charles R. Smith (*Tongues in Biblical Perspective*, 1972), who argue that the completed canon answers to "the perfect"; R. Bruce Compton ("1 Corinthians 13:8-13 and the Cessation of Miraculous Gifts," *Detroit Baptist Semi-*

nary Journal 9 [2004]: 97-144) mounts the tradition's most extensive scholarly defense: "the purpose of this article is to reexamine the exegetical evidence from 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 and to defend the above interpretation, namely, that 'the perfect' in 13:10 refers to the completed New Testament canon and that with the closing of the canon miraculous gifts ceased" — concluding that "the completed canon view is established as the most exegetically defensible interpretation." Compton, professor at Detroit Baptist Theological Seminary, returned to the defense against Schreiner in 2020 ("First Corinthians 13 and the Cessation of Miraculous Gifts: A Critique of Thomas Schreiner's *Spiritual Gifts*," *DBSJ* 25 [2020]: 25-49, from a 2019 Evangelical Theological Society paper): "I have argued that the case for 'the perfect' in 1 Corinthians 13:10 to refer to the New Testament canon is, in fact, convincing." His two articles (both verified from the journal text, copies in Primary-Sources) make him, with Woods, the reading's most substantial living advocate — and the 2020 piece its most recent scholarly defense. Richard B. Gaffin Jr. approaches cessationism differently in *Perspectives on Pentecost* (P&R Publishing, 1979) — from a redemptive-historical angle that emphasizes the close of the apostolic age rather than this verse. B.B. Warfield's *Counterfeit Miracles* (1918) is the classic scholarly argument for cessationism, and it is telling that the book never cites 1 Corinthians 13:10 at all: Warfield rested his case on the gifts' function as apostolic credentials, not on this passage (see Decker).

The view's fullest single-article synthesis — and its most publicly active advocacy — is Andy M. Woods, "The Meaning of 'the Perfect' in 1 Corinthians 13:8-13," *CTS Journal* 10/2 (Fall 2004; posted at spiritandtruth.org, © 2012; journal text verified via Galaxie). The article is explicit advocacy, not survey: "This article seeks to demonstrate that quantitative completeness is the best understanding of *teleion* and sees Paul as speaking of the completion of the New Testament canon." Woods — since 2017 president of Chafer Theological Seminary and senior pastor of Sugar Land Bible Church — synthesizes the case from Myron J. Houghton ("A Reexamination of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13," *Bibliotheca Sacra* 153 [1996]: 344-56, himself an advocate: "this writer's completed canon view"), Robert Dean Jr. ("Three Arguments for the Cessation of Tongues," Conservative Theological Society paper, 2002), and — notably from outside dispensationalism — the Reformed postmillennialist Kenneth L. Gentry Jr. (*The Charismatic Gift of Prophecy: A Reformed Response to Wayne Grudem*, 2d ed., 1989). The arguments and challenges below engage Woods's formulations directly, since his article is the strongest form the view currently takes.

Core Claim (View 1)

When the New Testament was completed — the last apostolic documents written and recognized, probably in the 90s AD — God's full written revelation became available. The "partial" revelatory gifts (prophecy, tongues, word of knowledge) were instruments for a pre-canonical church that lacked complete access to God's word. Once "the perfect" — the complete written revelation — arrived, the partial instruments were no longer needed and ceased.

In its advocates' own framing (as surveyed sympathetically in Thomas's 1974 article before he dissents, and in Compton's 2004 survey): *τέλειος* here carries its well-attested sense of "complete, the totality" — and the antithesis with *τὸ ἐκ μέρους* is specifically quantitative, so that "what better opposite to partial is there than 'completeness'?" The gifts of verse 8 are precisely the revelatory channels through which the apostolic deposit was being delivered, and "included in what was given by men using these gifts was what was ultimately incorporated into the written word." The Corinthian

congregation — a church with no completed New Testament — is exactly the situation those partial instruments served. Nor do the view's advocates simply concede verse 12: their published responses refer the "face to face" and "know even as I am known" language to the church's condition after the canon's completion or to the believer's state after death (Unger, p. 97; Smith, p. 79; both engaged in Thomas 1974, p. 82). The argument's most rigorous early statement is Gilbert B. Weaver's: "Logically, to *teleion* must refer to completeness or perfection in the same realm as that referred to by *to ek merous*. Since *to ek merous* refers to the transmission of divine truth by revelation, the other term to *teleion* must refer to God's complete revelation of truth, the entire New Testament" ("Tongues Shall Cease": 1 Corinthians 13:8," unpublished research paper, Grace Theological Seminary, 1964, p. 12, as quoted in Robert Gromacki, *The Modern Tongues Movement*, 1967, pp. 126-27; verified against the page). Gromacki's own survey advances the same case — "Not until Revelation was written could it be said that God's revelation was complete (*teleion*)" — and adds a lexical negative: *teleion* "is never used in the New Testament to depict the second coming, the millennium, or the eternal state." (Both the lexical negative and Weaver's realm-argument are answered under Honest Challenge 8 below.)

Strongest Arguments (View 1)

1. The sufficiency of Scripture. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says:

"All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect (*ἄρτιος*), thoroughly furnished unto all good works." — 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (KJV)

If completed Scripture makes the believer thoroughly equipped, the argument runs, additional revelatory gifts are functionally unnecessary. The word *ἄρτιος* ("perfect," "complete," "equipped") in this verse invites comparison with *τέλειον* in 1 Corinthians 13:10 — both point toward a state of completeness that Scripture can supply.

2. "The perfect law of liberty." James 1:25 uses *τέλειον* to describe the word of God:

"But whoso looketh into the perfect (*τέλειον*) law of liberty, and continueth therein, he being not a forgetful hearer, but a doer of the work, this man shall be blessed in his deed." — James 1:25 (KJV)

If James can speak of God's word as *τέλειον*, Paul's use of the same term could carry a similar referent. And the parallel runs deeper than the adjective: two verses earlier, James supplies the only other New Testament occurrence of Paul's mirror-word — the hearer "beholding his natural face in a glass (*ἐσόπτρῳ*)" (Jas. 1:23-24) — so that a mirror and "the perfect law" stand within three verses of each other, in an explicitly Scripture-centered context. The canon view can claim here a biblical precedent for pairing mirror-language with a textual referent.

The view's modern advocates press this parallel all the way into verse 12 itself. Gentry and Woods observe that the verse never actually says we shall see *God* face to face — "Grudem's argument has to read God into the reference" (Gentry, p. 57, as quoted in Woods) — and that one looks into a mirror to see *oneself*. On their reading, the dim mirror is piecemeal revelation giving the believer only a partial self-picture, and "face to face" is the clear self-sight that the completed canon's perfect mirror supplies — exactly as James's hearer beholds "his natural face in a glass." This is the view's boldest exegetical move, and it is answered under Honest Challenges below.

3. “Once delivered to the saints.” Jude 3 speaks of a deposit of faith that was delivered once for all:

“Beloved, when I gave all diligence to write unto you of the common salvation, it was needful for me to write unto you, and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend for the faith which was once delivered (ἅπαξ παραδοθείση) unto the saints.” — Jude 3 (KJV)

The aorist ἅπαξ παραδοθείση (“once for all delivered”) implies a completed deposit. Advocates of this view argue that when the last apostolic writing was completed, that deposit was closed.

4. The canonical closure of Revelation. Revelation 22:18-19 warns:

“For I testify unto every man that heareth the words of the prophecy of this book, If any man shall add unto these things, God shall add unto him the plagues that are written in this book: And if any man shall take away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part out of the book of life...” — Revelation 22:18-19 (KJV)

Whether this refers specifically to Revelation or to the completed canon (scholars debate this), canon-view advocates see it as marking the close of the revelatory period.

5. The childhood-to-adulthood analogy applied to the church’s redemptive-historical development. Canon-view advocates adapt the growth analogy whose fullest modern development belongs to the maturity theorists: the church’s infancy (needing ongoing prophetic guidance) corresponds to the pre-canonical period. As the church “grew up” into the full revelation of God through the completed Scriptures, the childhood instruments were put away. (Robert L. Thomas developed the fullest form of this growth argument — but his own position files it under church maturity, not the canon; see View 3.)

6. Historical observation. The extraordinary revelatory gifts do appear — at least in the historical record that survives — to have diminished significantly after the apostolic generation. While this does not prove a theological cessation, it suggests a pattern consistent with the view.

7. The “abiding” triad as a timing argument. In its sharpest published form (Houghton, *BibSac* 153: 352 — “Faith and hope, then, will not remain beyond Christ’s return”; Compton, *DBSJ* 9 — “Unlike the revelatory gifts which cease with the completion of the canon, and unlike even faith and hope which cease with the return of Christ, love never ceases”), the argument reads verse 13 as a three-stage timetable: the gifts cease first; faith, hope, and love then abide through the church age; faith and hope cease at the parousia; love alone continues beyond. Verse 13 says faith, hope, and love “abide” — and the *point* of μένει, the argument runs, is that the triad survives the very transition the gifts do not. But faith and hope cannot survive the parousia: faith gives way to sight and hope to possession (2 Cor. 5:7; Rom. 8:24). So an arrival of “the perfect” that faith and hope live *through* must fall before the parousia — inside history — and the completed canon is the obvious candidate. On this reading the eschatological interpretation collapses Paul’s own contrast: if gifts, faith, and hope all terminate at the same moment, there is nothing for the triad’s “abiding” to abide through. (Answered under Honest Challenge 8 below; see also Chapter 1 on verse 13 and Appendix A on νυνὶ δέ.)

8. The Hebrews 1:1 bridge. “God, who at sundry times (πολυμερῶς) and in divers

manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets, hath in these last days spoken unto us by his Son" (Heb. 1:1-2). The adverb πολυμερῶς — "in many parts," from the same μέρος as Paul's ἐκ μέρους — describes precisely revelation delivered in installments, and Hebrews declares that installment-mode superseded by a definitive speaking, within history. The canon view reads Paul's partial/perfect antithesis as the 1 Corinthians form of the same movement. (Answered under Honest Challenge 8 below.)

9. The open-canon consequence. The view's sharpest theological argument concerns what follows if it is wrong: if "the perfect" has not yet come, then the revelatory gifts of verse 8 remain normative for the entire church age — and a church still receiving binding prophecy is a church whose canon is functionally open, in tension with a faith "once delivered" (Jude 3) and a completed word (Rev. 22:18-19). Dean states it plainly: "When theologians mistakenly identify the τέλειος with either the Second Coming of Christ, the perfection of heaven, the Rapture, or the Millennium, all the temporary gifts become normative for the entire Church Age" ("Three Arguments for the Cessation of Tongues," p. 10; verified against the author's text, copy in Primary-Sources). On this argument the canon reading is not exegetical opportunism but doctrinal self-defense: it protects *sola scriptura*. (Answered under Honest Challenge 7 below.)

10. The attestation-purpose argument. The miraculous gifts, the argument runs, "all involve either the giving of divine revelation or the authenticating of divine revelation" — grounded in "the signs of an apostle" (2 Cor. 12:12) and Hebrews 2:3-4, where God bore witness to the apostolic message "with signs and wonders" (Compton, *DBSJ* 9 [2004]; similarly Gromacki and Unger). If the gifts existed to deliver and attest revelation-in-progress, the completion of revelation ends both functions at once — reinforcing the identification of "the perfect" with the completed deposit. (Answered under Honest Challenge 7 below.)

Pastoral Fruit (View 1)

This view produces genuine and important goods in Christian communities that hold it:

- A strong doctrine of Scripture's sufficiency, which protects against spiritual manipulation and the cult of charismatic personality
- Stability of authority: the church is not waiting for the next word of prophecy to confirm or contradict the last one
- Accountability: every claimed revelation must be tested against a fixed, final standard
- Protection of the laity from prophetic claims that cannot be verified or falsified
- Clear epistemological grounds for Christian unity: one text, one final authority

Honest Challenges (View 1)

Even at its strongest published form, the canon view faces substantial difficulties that its most honest advocates acknowledge:

1. Anachronism. The concept of a 27-book New Testament canon did not exist in Paul's day. Paul was writing to a church in Corinth around 55 AD. The question "when will the New Testament be complete?" was not a question Paul or his hearers could have had in mind. To interpret "the perfect" as the completed canon requires Paul to be referring to something he could not have been thinking about. Advocates have two replies. First, on a full doctrine of inspiration, the divine author can intend a referent beyond the human author's horizon, as the prophets themselves searched "what, or

what manner of time the Spirit of Christ which was in them did signify" (1 Pet. 1:11). Second, the apostolic age was not without real-time awareness that apostolic writing carried Scripture's authority: Paul tells this very congregation that "the things that I write unto you are the commandments of the Lord" (1 Cor. 14:37), and 2 Peter 3:15-16 already ranks Paul's epistles with "the other scriptures" — so Paul could be pointing, the argument runs, to a growing written deposit his readers knew was accumulating, not to an unimaginable future artifact. Woods adds Paul's charge to guard the entrusted deposit (2 Tim. 1:13-14) and his request for "the books, but especially the parchments" (2 Tim. 4:13) as marks of a collection-consciousness already forming. Both replies are real but costly. The first concedes that nothing in the passage's own context signals the canon, so the identification must be imported; a *sensus plenior* can rescue possibility, but it cannot supply positive evidence. The second proves awareness of apostolic *authority*, not of a bounded *collection*: knowing that a letter commands the Lord's authority is a different thing from conceiving a closed twenty-seven-book corpus whose completion would end the gifts — and 2 Peter itself postdates 1 Corinthians, so the Corinthians hearing chapter 13 read aloud had not even that.

2. The strangeness of "face to face" as a description of reading a book. Verse 12 says:

"For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face (πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον): now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known." — 1 Corinthians 13:12 (KJV)

Πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον ("face to face") is consistently used in the Old Testament for direct personal encounter — God speaking to Moses in Exodus 33:11, the description of prophetic directness in Numbers 12:8. It is intensely personal encounter language. Describing the arrival of a completed text as "face to face" is strained at best. Nor does the James 1:23-25 mirror parallel (argument 2 above) relieve the strain: in James the mirror gives a *true* image that the hearer promptly forgets — the opposite of Paul's dim seeing "in an enigma" — and James has no "then face to face" to account for.

The view's most sophisticated reply turns the study's own observation about Exodus 33:20-23 into an argument. If Moses's "face to face" was itself compatible with *not* seeing God's face — if it names a mode of revelation (clear, direct, "not in dark speeches") rather than the sight of God — then Paul's "face to face" could likewise name maximal revelational clarity within this age: the complete, unriddled word over against fragmentary prophetic installments. The rabbis read Moses's privilege in exactly that register: "All of the prophets observed their prophecies through an obscure looking glass [*aspaklaria*]... However, Moses our master observed his prophecies through a clear looking glass" (b. Yevamot 49b, William Davidson Talmud) — clear-glass vision as a grade of *prophetic reception*, held by a man within this life. On that reading, Numbers 12:6-8 contrasts two modes of receiving revelation, both inside history, and the canon view inherits the clearer mode. The reply deserves its full weight — and then two texts answer it. Deuteronomy 34:10 closes the mode to history: "there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses" — the clear-glass grade was not attained again within the age, so a finished text cannot simply claim it. And verse 12's second clause sets the standard beyond any mode of reception: "then shall I know even as also I am known" patterns the future knowing on God's present knowing of the believer — personal, direct, exhaustive — which no clarity of documents supplies. The clarity-reading can carry "face to face"; it cannot carry "even as I am known."

The view has one further reply — its boldest. Gentry and Woods deny that God is the

object of the seeing at all: verse 12 never says we shall see *God* face to face (“Grudem’s argument has to read God into the reference”), and a mirror’s viewer sees *himself* — so “face to face” is the believer’s clear self-sight in the completed canon’s perfect mirror, on the pattern of James 1:23, and Numbers 12:6-8 concerns the mode of revelation rather than fellowship. The reading is ingenious; the eschatological side answers that the passage’s own grammar resists it. Paul’s idiom is not “look at a mirror” but “see through a glass” (βλέπομεν δι’ ἑσόπτρου) — and when Paul elsewhere puts a mirror into present Christian experience, the object in the glass is the Lord, not the self: “we all, with open face beholding as in a glass (κατοπτριζόμενοι) the glory of the Lord” (2 Cor. 3:18). The elliptical “but then face to face” continues the verb of seeing from the first clause: whatever is now seen dimly through the glass is the very thing then seen face to face. The idiom itself requires two faces — every Old Testament use of the formula is an encounter between two parties (“I have seen God face to face,” Gen. 32:30; “whom the LORD knew face to face,” Deut. 34:10; “I have seen an angel of the LORD face to face,” Judg. 6:22) — never a reflection. And the second clause settles the object: “then shall I know even as also I am known” pairs my future knowing with God’s present knowing of *me*, a correspondence that is idle if the knowledge in view is self-inspection. The move also sits awkwardly within the view’s own tradition: Vine, its chief earlier advocate, read “face to face” at the Parousia (see Held By above) — the self-sight exegesis is a modern repair, not the view’s native reading.

A further refutation, this one from inside the Grace-tradition itself. Robert T. Stamp’s 1970 M.Div. under James L. Boyer asserts the completed-canon reading of τὸ τέλειον in verse 10 as evident (p. 33) and, notably, never argues for it anywhere in the thesis — the assertion is common ground in the seminary’s tradition, not the thesis’s subject. Its subject is verse 12; and within the assumed verse-10 frame, when Stamp examines the Weaver/Gromacki “mirror of the completed canon → clear self-sight” reading of verse 12, he rejects it on internal grounds. James’s use of the same ἑσόπτρου image (Jas. 1:23-25) describes a mirror that yields a *clear* self-image, not a dim one: the hearer “beholdeth his natural face” — τὸ πρόσωπον τῆς γενέσεως, “the face of his birth.” So if Paul’s own contemporary James already used the mirror figure for present, clear self-inspection, Paul cannot in 1 Corinthians 13:12 be pointing forward to a not-yet self-sight that would arrive only when the canon closed: “to look to James 1:23-25 for support for the view that ‘face to face’ has reference to seeing one’s self in the Word of God, which is to come, is to look to weak support. For this verse indicates that men could already see themselves face to face. If Paul were looking to a time when men would be able to see themselves as they really were before God, how is it that James who wrote before Paul wrote I Corinthians, indicated that men could already see themselves as they really were? In James there is no indication that a clearer image was yet to come” (Stamp, “*But Then Face to Face*”: *I Corinthians 13:12*, M.Div. thesis, Grace Theological Seminary, 1970, pp. 30-31; PDF in Primary-Sources). Stamp adds an empirical companion: “Is it possible for us to say that even today, after possessing the Scriptures in their completed form for more than nineteen hundred years that we know fully, as we have been known? The answer is obviously in the negative” (p. 34). The self-sight reading requires that the completed canon already supplies what verse 12 promises — a claim its own tradition has not been willing to affirm without heavy qualification (compare Houghton’s “Yes, but only in some limited qualified sense” under Challenge 3). Stamp himself takes the canon reading of verse 10 for granted; the fact that he could not make verse 12 cohere with it on the self-sight route is telling.

Compton presses a subtler version: consistency of metaphor. Everyone grants that “seeing in a mirror dimly” is a figure for the limitations of partial revelation; but then,

he argues, taking “face to face” as literally seeing the returned Christ “interprets the second part of Paul’s analogy literally rather than metaphorically” — both halves should be figures for modes of revelation, the dim mode and the clear (*DBSJ* 9 [2004]: 134-35, reading even Moses’s “face to face” in Num. 12:8 as a metaphor for close relationship). The observation is fair as far as it goes, and the reply is that Paul’s now/then contrasts pair figure with *reality*, not figure with figure: “we walk by faith, not by sight” (2 Cor. 5:7) sets a present mode against a future actuality, and here the mirror (the mediated mode) is contrasted with the absence of any medium — πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον is not a second image Paul coins but the Old Testament’s fixed idiom for unmediated encounter, and its companion texts name the encounter’s object without figure: “we shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2); “they shall see his face” (Rev. 22:4). A metaphor for clearer revelation still leaves the knowing mediated — and “even as I am known” is precisely what mediation cannot supply (Challenge 3).

A further canon-view retreat should be named, since the study’s answers to the self-sight and clarity readings force it — and its shape was already visible in 1970. Stamp’s “modified second coming” view is precisely that retreat: verse 12’s “face to face” remains what canon-view advocates like Vine had always read it as (the parousia), but severed from identifying what τὸ τέλειον in verse 10 names. Adopted by an interpreter who took the canon reading of τὸ τέλειον for granted (p. 33) and read verse 12 on the merits, the position lays out its own dilemma frankly. On the standard second-coming reading, Stamp writes, the interpreter must either “abandon the idea that ‘that which is perfect’ (13:10) refers to the completed canon of Scripture” or “say that we are still in the time of these forms of incomplete means of revelation and they will not be done away until the return of our Lord” (p. 33). Neither move Stamp takes; his escape holds both by decoupling: verse 12 becomes an example of the transitory nature of the imperfect means without identifying what τὸ τέλειον is — the connective γάρ loaded as example-illustrative rather than referent-identifying. Stamp is candid about the cost: “this verse does not shed any light on the problem of the meaning of ‘that which is perfect’ of verse 10, for no matter which view one maintains, I Corinthians 13:12 still serves the same purpose, that of providing an example of the transitory nature of these incomplete means of revelation” (Stamp 1970, p. 40). The retreat is honest — Stamp takes verse 12 seriously as parousia language — but it carries three prices. First, γάρ is loaded with the weakest of its Pauline uses (a merely rhetorical “for,” severed from the neighboring clause’s content), where Paul’s ordinary practice is a tight explanatory tie. Verse 11’s childhood analogy shows Paul can indeed illustrate without identifying inside the same paragraph — but verse 12 does more than analogize: its ἄρτι/τότε correlates resume the ὅταν arrival of verse 10, and its shift to a first-person future prediction (ἐπιγνώσονται, “I shall know fully”) is not the past-tense narrative move of verse 11 (“when I was a child”). The clean illustrative reading available for verse 11 is harder to pin on verse 12. Second, the canon claim of verse 10 must now shoulder its whole weight *without* the confirmation of verse 12, which reduces the argument’s evidential base to the lexical-and-contextual case the study’s Challenges 1-8 have already engaged. (Stamp’s p. 40 formulation is symmetrical — “no matter which view one maintains” — suggesting the eschatological reading loses verse 12 too. But the symmetry is only apparent: the eschatological reading is not *forced* into the loose γάρ, since a tight explanatory tie between verses 10 and 12 fits it directly; the canon reading is forced into the loose γάρ on pain of contradiction with verse 12. The two positions do not pay the same price for the same asymmetry of options.) And third, having conceded the parousia reading of “face to face” and “know even as I am known,” the interpreter has conceded exactly the pair of clauses on which the eschatological reading

has been most textually secure — so the split-referent position preserves the canon reading of verse 10 at the cost of validating the eschatological reading everywhere it most naturally lodges. Stamp’s distinctive within the canon-view tradition is worth naming precisely: Unger (p. 97) and Smith (p. 79) had already offered readings that referred verse 12 either to “the church’s condition after the canon’s completion” (a unified-referent maneuver, verse 12 fulfilled corporately by the canon-era church) or to “the believer’s state after death” (a split-referent maneuver, verse 12 taking effect at individual death rather than at Christ’s return). Stamp is neither: he refers verse 12 to the parousia itself, and he makes explicit what Unger’s and Smith’s moves left implicit — the neutrality thesis, that verse 12 sheds no light on what τὸ τέλος names. That is what makes his 1970 thesis the earliest fully honest statement of the split-referent option, even though the option itself was already available inside the tradition. The retreat is real; whether it is worth the ground it cedes is for the reader to weigh.

3. The knowledge asymmetry. “Then shall I know even as also I am known” — the future knowing is compared to God’s knowing of us. God does not know us *through a text*. He knows us directly and comprehensively. If “the perfect” is the completed canon, then Christians who have the completed canon should now know God with something approaching God’s thoroughness of knowledge of us. This is manifestly not what any canon-view advocate claims.

The view’s advocates enter a definitional objection first: “knowledge” in verse 8, they argue, is not human cognition generally but the revelatory *gift* of knowledge (1 Cor. 12:8) — so what verse 12 promises is not omniscience or unmediated vision but complete, un-riddled revelatory content, which the finished canon supplies (Compton, DBSJ 9 [2004], distinguishing the gift from “the knowledge gained from the other two gifts”). The definitional point is fair for verse 8 — but verse 12 shifts from the gift-noun γνῶσις to Paul’s first-person verb: ἐπιγνώσομαι, “I shall know,” καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην, “even as also I was known.” The thing predicted is not the gift’s replacement but the apostle’s own knowing, patterned on God’s knowing of him — and God’s knowing of Paul is not a revelatory deposit.

Houghton’s reply deserves record, because it is the view’s best: the problem, he argues, does not vanish on the eschatological reading either — “In eternity, will believers really know fully just as they have been fully known? The answer to this question seems to be, ‘Yes, but only in some limited qualified sense.’ If that answer is acceptable for the eschatological interpretation, then it ought to be acceptable for this writer’s ‘completed canon’ view as well” (*BibSac* 153 [1996], n. 27; verified against the journal text via Galaxie, copy in Primary-Sources). Woods adds that the Spirit’s illuminating ministry (1 Cor. 2:9-15) supplies what the bare text cannot. But the *tu quoque* misses what the asymmetry actually claims. The eschatological reading never claimed omniscience for the glorified; καθὼς marks manner, not measure — knowing *directly, without medium*, as God’s knowing of us is direct. The ancient tradition made precisely this qualification from inside the eschatological reading: Theodoret glosses ἐπεγνώσθην with ὠκειώθην — “I shall see him more exactly, as one made his own” — qualifying the καθὼς without moving the arrival out of the resurrection (PG 82:336-337; Appendix B). That qualification costs the eschatological reading nothing, because unmediated sight is exactly what glorification supplies (“we shall see him as he is,” 1 John 3:2). For the canon view the price is steeper: a text is by definition mediation, so knowledge through even a perfect book remains knowledge *through a glass* — the very mode Paul says will pass. Whether that difference in price is decisive is for the reader to weigh. And the illumination supplement proves too much: the Spirit’s illumination was equally

present before the canon closed, so it cannot be the thing whose *arrival* verse 10 dates.

4. No patristic support. Not a single pre-Nicene interpreter read this passage as a reference to the completed canon. The entire ante-Nicene period — which overlapped with the very period when the canon was being completed — read the passage eschatologically. The canonical interpretation has no attestation before the modern period. The silence holds even beyond antiquity: the Byzantine commentators who carried the Greek exegetical tradition into the Middle Ages — pseudo-Oecumenius (10th c.) and Theophylact (c. 1100), both epitomizing Chrysostom — still gloss the perfect’s arrival as “in the time to come” (ἐν τῷ μέλλοντι χρόνῳ), Theophylact expressly naming “the life to come” (τῆς κατὰ τὴν μέλλουσαν ζωῆς), some nine centuries after the last New Testament book was written (PG 118; PG 124; Appendix B). And the gap persists in the view’s three fullest modern defenses: Compton’s 2004 and 2020 articles and Woods’s 2004 article — some ninety journal pages between them, answering the grammatical and contextual objections in detail — nowhere interact with any ancient interpreter’s reading of the verse. Woods’s only church-history discussion concerns whether the *gifts* continued (a question he sets aside as “a historical argument rather than an exegetical one”); Compton’s articles do not mention a church father at all. The reception-historical evidence is not answered; it is unaddressed.

5. The problem of timing. If “the perfect” arrived around 100 AD when the last New Testament documents were written, why did the canon not become settled and universally recognized for another two to three centuries? The canon was disputed into the 4th century. If “the perfect” has a specific arrival date, it is not clear what that date is.

A companion difficulty was pressed by Schreiner and answered by Compton. If the perfect is the completed canon, then Christ could not have returned before the canon closed — which conflicts with the New Testament’s teaching that each generation of believers, including the first, could hope for the Lord’s return in its lifetime (Jas. 5:8-9; 1 Cor. 1:7; 1 Thess. 4:17, where Paul writes “we who are alive”). Compton’s reply: God revealed the timing of neither event, so “from Paul’s perspective, the completion of the canon, like the Lord’s return, could take place within his generation” — no felt conflict (*DBSJ* 25 [2020]: 45-46). The reply is coherent, but note what it purchases and at what price: it requires that Paul held out the possibility of the canon completing within his own lifetime — a canon whose concept, scope, and completion-event the New Testament nowhere describes — which returns the argument to the anachronism problem (Challenge 1), now with the added premise that Paul reckoned with the canon’s completion as a datable event within his own lifetime.

6. The “faith, hope, and love” problem. Verse 13 says:

“And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.” — 1 Corinthians 13:13 (KJV)

Paul says these three *abide* (“now abideth,” *νυνὶ δὲ μένει*). Faith and hope are present-age realities — they are not needed in the same way once we see face to face (cf. Romans 8:24: “hope that is seen is not hope”). If “the perfect” arrived in 100 AD, and faith and hope still abide now in the same sense they did then, the structure of Paul’s argument becomes difficult to account for.

7. Cessationism has not, in fact, needed this verse. The view’s most rigorous supporting argument is the open-canon consequence (Argument 9): if “the perfect” is not the canon, the revelatory gifts of verse 8 remain normative and the canon is

functionally open. The stakes are real. But the tradition that most needs cessationism has repeatedly affirmed a closed canon and ceased gifts *without* this verse.

B.B. Warfield's *Counterfeit Miracles* (1918) — the classic scholarly cessationist case — never cites 1 Corinthians 13:10 at all (Decker). Richard Gaffin, in *Perspectives on Pentecost* (P&R, 1979), argues cessation on redemptive-historical grounds while judging that the coming of the perfect and the “then” of verse 12 “no doubt refer to the time of Christ’s return” and that the canon reading “cannot be made credible exegetically” — adding, in the same breath, that the continuationist inference from the passage is “likewise gratuitous” (p. 109; verified against the 1979 printing via archive.org, snippet in Primary-Sources). John MacArthur reads “the perfect” as the eternal state and carries cessation on the *παύσονται* argument and the gifts’ apostolic-age function (*1 Corinthians*, MacArthur New Testament Commentary, 1984); Robert L. Thomas reads *τὸ τέλειον* as the maturity of the body of Christ, with the terminus “whatever comes first: the passing from childhood to adulthood or the return of Christ” (JETS 17 [1974]: 88, filed under View 3 in this study) — neither man rests the canon’s closure on 1 Corinthians 13:10. The Byzantine heirs of Chrysostom — pseudo-Oecumenius, Theophylact — held that the gifts had already faded within history while still reading “the perfect” eschatologically (Appendix B). If the canon’s closure rests on the once-for-all apostolic office, it does not need this verse.

The pattern is not confined to Reformed cessationism. Within the dispensationalist tradition that produced the canon reading’s most extensive defenses, the same conclusion arose internally over three-and-a-half decades. Grace Theological Seminary — whose faculty and graduates produced David F. Miller’s 1977 Th.D. *Concerning Spiritual Gifts*, one of the fullest published dispensationalist defenses of the canon reading — also produced the reading’s sharpest internal critics. Warren E. Tamkin’s 1949 B.D. under Alva J. McClain (Grace’s founding president) shows the canon view was already the seminary’s working reading before the charismatic movement’s institutional shockwave. But the strain that would break open in the late-1970s dissent was already registering by 1970. Robert T. Stamp’s 1970 M.Div. under James L. Boyer — treated at length in Challenge 2 above under the split-referent retreat — takes the canon reading of verse 10 for granted while reading verse 12 on the merits, and coins a “modified second coming” decoupling to hold both when a single-frame reading fails. One student, one thesis; but the position had to be engineered, and Reid, Webb, and Rothhaar in the next decade would abandon the engineering and revise verse 10 itself. Lester R. Reid’s 1978 M.Div. thesis on 1 Corinthians 13:10, supervised by Smith, moves to the eternal-state reading. David R. Webb’s 1982 Th.M. thesis *Is the Canon Complete?*, dual-supervised by Smith and George J. Zemek Jr., concludes that “building a theology of a completed canon upon a problem passage would doubtless be an exercise in unsound hermeneutics” (p. 13). James E. Rothhaar’s 1984 M.Div. *An Exegetical Investigation of 1 Corinthians 13:10*, under Gary T. Meadors, moves to a modified maturity reading, writing that “the concept of a completed New Testament canon would have been totally foreign to the Corinthians at that time and so the word ‘perfect’ would have actually obscured Paul’s meaning rather than explaining it” (p. 47). Smith’s decision to supervise two theses that reject his own 1970 position is remarkable for scholarly honesty — and telling for the state of the exegesis inside the tradition (all seven theses verified against direct copies; see the verification notes in Primary-Sources: Rothhaar-Miller-Grace-theses-verified.md, Smith-1970-dissertation-verification-note.md, and Stamp-1970-fold-recommendations.md).

One further datum from the history of interpretation. The canon reading, by its content,

entails the cessation of the revelatory gifts — so it is no surprise, and no evidence of anything, that all its published advocates are cessationists; a continuationist advocate would be a near-contradiction in terms. The observation is empirical: no counter-example has been located in the literature surveyed. The informative pattern lies on the other side. The eschatological reading *underdetermines* the gifts question, and its adherents accordingly split — Chrysostom, Edwards, Gaffin, MacArthur, and Schreiner remaining cessationists; Fee and Grudem continuationists. What work Argument 9 performs alongside the verse’s own use as a proof of cessation is a question the reader is equipped to answer (see Chapter 5).

The attestation-purpose argument (Argument 10) receives the same reply. Its premise proves the *Gaffin* conclusion, not the canon one. Hebrews 2:3-4 is past-referring — God *bore* witness to the apostolic generation’s preaching; attestation attaches to revelators, not to a book-completion event. That the gifts’ purpose was bound to the apostolic, foundation-laying era is exactly the other-grounds cessationism of Warfield, Gaffin, and Ephesians 2:20 — which its own holders decline to locate in 1 Corinthians 13:10.

8. The sub-arguments (Core Claim lexical negative, “abiding” triad, Hebrews bridge) each admit an eschatological answer. The Core Claim’s supporting lexical negative — “*teleion* is never used in the New Testament to depict the second coming, the millennium, or the eternal state” (Gromacki, via Weaver) — is true as far as it goes, and it cuts symmetrically: *τέλειος* is never used of a scriptural collection either. James 1:25’s “perfect law” is the law of liberty, not a canon; the substantivized neuter here is a contrast-term paired with *τὸ ἐκ μέρους*, not a technical title for anything. Weaver’s realm-argument (that “*to teleion* must refer to God’s complete revelation of truth” because *to ek merous* refers to the transmission of divine truth by revelation) is answered by verse 12’s own definition of the realm: the completeness in view is knowing “even as I am known.”

The “abiding” triad timing argument (Argument 7) is real but underdetermines its conclusion. The same three-stage structure was deployed by Robert L. Thomas for the *maturity* terminus, not just for the canon. On the logical reading of *νυνὶ δέ* — the majority view — verse 13 ranks rather than schedules, and the triad’s “abiding” is its permanence-in-kind over against the gifts’ instrumentality across the whole age, not a stopwatch. Even on the temporal reading, the triad abides *through the age until* the perfect, which is exactly what the eschatological reading affirms.

The Hebrews 1:1 bridge (Argument 8) reads the *πολυμερῶς/ἐκ μέρους* root-echo as installment-mode superseded by definitive speaking. But Hebrews’s contrast is prophets-versus-Son, not prophets-versus-book — and the Son is the very one whom “we shall see... as he is” at his appearing (1 John 3:2). Followed to its end, the bridge leads to the parousia reading, not to the canon.

View 2: Christ’s Return

Held By (View 2)

This is the majority view among modern commentators across traditions. Its most important scholarly advocates are Gordon D. Fee, whose *The First Epistle to the Corinthians* (NICNT, Eerdmans, 1987) remains the standard evangelical critical commentary on the letter, and Anthony C. Thiselton, whose *The First Epistle to the Corinthians* (NIGTC, Eerdmans, 2000) is the most thorough scholarly commentary in English. D.A. Carson

argued for this view explicitly and against the canon interpretation in *Showing the Spirit* (Baker, 1987). F.F. Bruce, Leon Morris, Ben Witherington III, and the majority of Pentecostal, charismatic, Catholic, and Orthodox interpreters also hold this position.

Core Claim (View 2)

“The perfect” is the return of Jesus Christ. When he appears, what is now partial — prophecy, tongues, word of knowledge — will be entirely superseded by direct, face-to-face fellowship with God. The gifts will not so much be “turned off” as rendered obsolete by the infinitely better thing that replaces them, just as a child’s incomplete knowledge is not “turned off” but superseded by the fuller knowledge of maturity.

Strongest Arguments (View 2)

1. “Face to face” is personal-encounter language. As noted above, *πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* echoes the Mosaic privilege:

“And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend.” — Exodus 33:11 (KJV)

“And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face.” — Deuteronomy 34:10 (KJV)

The phrase indicates direct, personal, unmediated encounter. At Christ’s return, what Moses experienced uniquely will be the common experience of all believers. This is confirmed by 1 John 3:2:

“Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.” — 1 John 3:2 (KJV)

2. “Know even as I am known” points to the resurrection. The future knowledge Paul describes — knowing with the thoroughness with which God knows us — exceeds any earthly epistemological state. It matches the resurrection condition. Paul elsewhere describes resurrection knowledge as qualitatively different:

“For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face.” — 1 Corinthians 13:12a (KJV)

The “dark glass” (*ἐν αἰνίγματι*, “in a riddle/enigma”) describes the indirect, mediated, partial nature of all present knowledge of God. This includes Scripture. Direct vision awaits the resurrection.

3. The “now...then” contrast is Pauline eschatological shorthand. Paul consistently uses *ἄρτι* (“now”) and *τότε* (“then”) to mark the present age versus the age to come:

“For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us.” — Romans 8:18 (KJV)

“For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory.” — 2 Corinthians 4:17 (KJV)

This “now/then” pattern is the characteristic signature of Pauline eschatology, not of a completed-canon argument.

4. The broader context of 1 Corinthians is eschatological. Paul opens the letter by saying:

“So that ye come behind in no gift; waiting for the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ: Who shall also confirm you unto the end, that ye may be blameless in the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.” — 1 Corinthians 1:7-8 (KJV)

And closes it:

“Maranatha” (1 Corinthians 16:22)

The entire letter is framed by eschatological expectation. Chapter 15, immediately following chapter 13 in sequence (though separated by ch. 14), is Paul’s definitive treatment of the resurrection. “The perfect” arriving at Christ’s return fits this frame precisely.

5. Near-unanimous patristic support. Almost every ancient interpreter from the Didache to Augustine who commented on this passage read it in an eschatological direction (Shogren’s phrase: “almost every church father”). Origen, Chrysostom, and Augustine understood “then shall I know even as also I am known” as a promise about the resurrection and the beatific vision (each pinned to work and translation in Chapter 3), and Theodoret’s verse-by-verse commentary reads the passage of this age’s partial, “childish” knowledge over against the coming face-to-face vision (*Interpretatio in xiv epistulas s. Pauli*, on 1 Cor 13; digest and pins in Shogren, *JPT* 15 [1999]). Within the study’s ancient window Clement of Alexandria is the significant departure, reading the passage as present spiritual maturity (his direct exegesis of v. 12 in *Paedagogus* 1.6 nonetheless remains eschatological); and the survey’s last father, John of Damascus (8th c.), takes “the perfect” as the law of Christ over against the law of Moses — neither an eschatological reading nor a canon-completion one. Native Greek readers, notably, saw no grammatical obstacle: no extant Greek father remarks any difficulty in applying the neuter τὸ τέλειον to the eschaton (Shogren). This near-unanimity is significant: the early church, which was still in the period when canonical gifts were operative (by the canon view’s own logic), never read this verse as referring to the canon.

6. Revelation 22:4 as the fulfillment. The book of Revelation, which canon-view advocates use to mark the close of the canon, ends with exactly the “face to face” promise Paul anticipates:

“And they shall see his face; and his name shall be in their foreheads.” — Revelation 22:4 (KJV)

Pastoral Fruit (View 2)

- A robust eschatological hope that keeps believers oriented toward Christ’s return
- The gifts remain available for the church’s edification throughout the present age, without needing to justify every claimed manifestation by appeal to a post-biblical period
- The “not yet” quality of present knowledge produces the theological humility Paul is calling for — we prophesy “in part,” we know “in part,” and this should make us gentle with one another
- Strong motivation for holiness and readiness: “we shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2)

Honest Challenges (View 2)

- **The neuter-gender objection.** *Tò τέλειον* is grammatically neuter, and a neuter substantive more naturally names an event or state than a person. Canon-view advocates press this point (Gromacki, Compton) as the exegetical objection to identifying “the perfect” with Christ himself. The view’s ablest advocates concede the force by speaking of “the state of affairs at Christ’s coming” rather than of Christ *simpliciter* — at which point this view begins to merge with View 4 (eternal state). Two mitigations deserve honest recording: (a) neuter substantives can bear personal reference to Christ elsewhere in the New Testament — Jesus of himself: “*something greater* (μεῖζον, neuter) than the temple is here” (Matt. 12:6), “*something greater* (πλεῖον, neuter) than Jonah is here” and “than Solomon is here” (Matt. 12:41-42); 1 John 1:1’s ὁ ἦν ἀπ’ ἀρχῆς (“that which was from the beginning”) likewise takes a neuter relative for the Word of life; and (b) Shogren observes that “none of the extant Greek fathers even remarks on any supposed difficulty of applying the neuter gender to the eschaton” (*JPT* 15 [1999]; the observation is developed in Chapter 1’s *τὸ τέλειον* grammatical note) — the objection is a modern one, unfelt by the Greek-native readers of the passage.
 - If gifts continue until Christ’s return, how should the church evaluate contemporary claims to prophecy and tongues? This view does not itself provide criteria for discernment, though other passages do (1 Corinthians 14:29, 1 Thessalonians 5:21, 1 John 4:1).
 - The view can seem to defer the entire question of gifts indefinitely, making it practically difficult for churches to set any policy on charismatic practice beyond “wait and see.”
 - Some cessationist scholars (e.g., Gaffin) argue that even if “the perfect” is the eschaton, the gifts may have ceased for *other* redemptive-historical reasons — the close of the apostolic age, the completion of the foundational revelation — meaning this passage does not settle the gifts question either way.
-

View 3: Church Maturity

Held By (View 3)

This view is less common than the eschatological readings, but it is not without able advocates. Its most careful modern exegetical defense is Robert L. Thomas’s “Tongues... Will Cease” (*Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 17 [1974]: 81-89, developed in *Understanding Spiritual Gifts*, 1978): Thomas argues from the νήπιος/άνηρ analogy of verse 11 and the Ephesians 4:11-16 parallel that *τὸ τέλειον* is the maturing body of Christ, reaching complete maturity at the parousia — with the canon’s completion at most one possible station within that growth. Clement of Alexandria held something resembling this view in the 2nd century, speaking of the *teleios* (perfect/mature one) as an already-achievable spiritual state for the Gnostic Christian — though his framework is not directly transferable to the cessationist debate.

Core Claim (View 3)

“The perfect” refers to the spiritual maturity of the church as a corporate body (or, in some versions, of individual believers). As the body of Christ grows into the “fullness of Christ” described in Ephesians 4, the scaffolding instruments of the immature church

— extraordinary revelatory gifts — give way to the settled, mature operation of the body in love.

Strongest Arguments (View 3)

1. Ephesians 4 explicitly links gifts, maturity, and the word τέλειον:

“And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ: Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man (εἰς ἄνδρα τέλειον), unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.”
— Ephesians 4:11-13 (KJV)

This passage explicitly connects gifts, their purpose (“till we all come...”), and the word τέλειον — making it a natural cross-reference for 1 Corinthians 13:10.

2. Paul uses τέλειος for present, achievable maturity elsewhere:

“Howbeit we speak wisdom among them that are perfect (τελείους): yet not the wisdom of this world.” — 1 Corinthians 2:6 (KJV)

“Let us therefore, as many as be perfect (τέλειοι), be thus minded.” — Philippians 3:15 (KJV)

“That we may present every man perfect (τέλειον) in Christ Jesus.” — Colossians 1:28 (KJV)

In each case τέλειος describes a present, human state of maturity — not an eschatological condition. If this is Paul’s primary use of the word, it shapes how we should read 1 Corinthians 13:10. The intra-epistle case is particularly striking: Paul opens the argument of chapter 3 by calling this same Corinthian congregation νηπίοις — “as unto babes (νηπίους) in Christ” (1 Cor. 3:1) — the same word he then uses of himself in 13:11 (“when I was a child,” ὅτε ἤμην νήπιος). The letter’s own lexical arc runs from νήπιος at 3:1 to τέλειον at 13:10: the very audience Paul diagnoses as spiritually infantile is the audience being told that “the perfect” will supersede the partial. On this reading, the trajectory is the one Paul demands of them: from νήπιοι to τέλειον, from milk to meat, within history.

3. The childhood-to-adulthood analogy naturally describes maturation as a process rather than an event. Paul himself became a man; this happened in time, gradually, through growth. The analogy invites a reading of “the perfect” as similarly gradual.

4. Hebrews uses τελείων for present, achievable maturity:

“But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age (τελείων), even those who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil.” — Hebrews 5:14 (KJV)

5. The view’s strongest modern form claims a twofold maturity, not an arrived one. Thomas’s developed position (JETS 17 [1974]: 85-87) does not claim the church has reached the ἄνδρα τέλειον of Ephesians 4:13. It reads the illustration of verse 11 as *relative*, increasing maturity — the body of Christ “growing up as one body... reaching complete maturity at the parousia” — and verse 12 as the *absolute*, fixed maturity of that consummation. On this form, the gifts serve until the goal is reached,

and Paul, not knowing which would come first, “under divine inspiration carefully chose vocabulary and illustrations that would allow for either possibility”: “Tongues... will cease,” in Thomas’s closing summary, “with whatever comes first: the passing from childhood to adulthood or the return of Christ.”

Pastoral Fruit (View 3)

- Emphasizes that the gifts are instruments for building up, not ends in themselves — they serve maturity and then yield to it
- Encourages continuous growth; the church is always moving toward greater fullness in Christ
- Offers a flexible framework: does not require a firm dogmatic position on whether gifts have ceased or will cease
- Coheres with the “building up” language of chapters 12-14 as a whole

Honest Challenges (View 3)

Even at its strongest published form, the maturity view faces residual difficulties:

- 1. Has the church ever demonstrably reached maturity?** The history of the church is a history of schism, heresy, persecution, and profound failure of love. If “the perfect” is church maturity, it has not arrived in any recognizable form — which means by this view’s own logic the gifts should still be operating. (The view’s strongest form, Thomas’s, accepts precisely this consequence in principle and locates the terminus at “whatever comes first” — at which point, for the question of *τὸ τέλειον* itself, the view becomes functionally hard to distinguish from the eschatological readings, and its distinctive cessationist payoff must be carried entirely by the middle-voice argument it advances only tentatively and by the relative-maturity observations.)
- 2. “Face to face” resists a maturity reading.** Even the most spiritually mature person does not encounter God “face to face” in the sense of Moses or the resurrection. The phrase implies a qualitative transformation, not a quantitative increase.
- 3. “Know even as I am known” exceeds any earthly state.** No degree of spiritual maturity brings any human being close to the thoroughness with which God knows us. This knowledge asymmetry points toward the resurrection and the eternal state, not toward ecclesial development.
- 4. The “now...then” structure suggests a decisive transition** rather than a gradual process. *Ὅταν δὲ ἔλθῃ τὸ τέλειον* (“but when the perfect comes/arrives”) uses an aorist subjunctive with *ὅταν*, suggesting an event with a definite arrival rather than a process that unfolds.
- 5. Individual maturity creates a fragmented picture.** If “the perfect” refers to individual maturity, does each person experience the cessation of gifts when they individually mature? This would make the promised state of 1 Corinthians 13:12 a personal achievement rather than a corporate eschatological event — but Paul consistently frames it as a shared future state.

View 4: The Eternal State

Held By (View 4)

This view overlaps substantially with View 2. Its distinctive emphasis is that “the perfect” is not just Christ’s return (a moment in time) but the consummated kingdom — the new heavens and new earth of Revelation 21-22, when God dwells directly with his people in the completed renewal of creation. Augustine’s teaching on the *beatific vision* is related to this view: the fullest knowledge of God comes in eternity, not at any single moment, and the “face to face” of 1 Corinthians 13:12 is realized most completely in the unending direct vision of God.

Core Claim (View 4)

“The perfect” is the consummated kingdom — the eternal state described in Revelation 21-22 — when every partial and creaturely means of knowing God (including prophecy, tongues, and Scripture itself as a mediated form of knowledge) will be superseded by direct, unending, beatific communion with God.

Strongest Arguments (View 4)

1. Revelation 21-22 describes the eternal state in exactly the terms Paul anticipates:

“And I heard a great voice out of heaven saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them, and they shall be his people, and God himself shall be with them, and be their God. And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away.” — Revelation 21:3-4 (KJV)

“And they shall see his face; and his name shall be in their foreheads.” — Revelation 22:4 (KJV)

This is the fulfillment of “face to face” — not at a single moment of Christ’s return but in the unending state that follows.

2. “Know even as I am known” fits the eternal state more fully than any single moment. God’s knowledge of us is not a one-time event; it is continuous and comprehensive. If Paul’s future knowing is to match God’s knowing of us, the fulfillment should also be continuous and unending — which points to the eternal state rather than a single eschatological moment.

3. Augustine’s beatific vision. Augustine in *De Trinitate* and *The City of God* speaks of the soul’s final rest in direct vision of God as the completion of all earthly seeking. The “face to face” of 1 Corinthians 13:12 is for Augustine the promise of the *visio beatifica* — the blessed vision that constitutes eternal life. This is not merely Christ’s return but the state that follows and never ends.

4. The “abiding” triad (v.13) makes better sense with an extended arc. If faith and hope and love “abide” (present tense, μένει), and if faith and hope belong especially to the present age (Romans 8:24-25 on hope; 2 Corinthians 5:7 on faith as contrasted with sight), then the transition to “the perfect” is not a single moment but the horizon of a long age of hope and faith — which eventually yields to the eternal state where faith becomes sight and hope becomes possession.

Pastoral Fruit (View 4)

- The ultimate hope of the Christian life is grounded in God’s final purposes for creation, not merely in a sequence of end-times events
- All present suffering and limitation is genuinely temporary; the eternal state is the context in which “face to face” will be fully realized
- Keeps the church oriented toward what God is ultimately doing: not just rescuing souls but renewing all things

Honest Challenges (View 4)

- For most practical purposes, Views 2 and 4 are identical: both say gifts continue until the eschaton, and both point to the same future reality. The distinction matters theologically but rarely changes the pastoral conclusion.
- Paul seems to present “the perfect” as something with a specific arrival (*ὅταν ἔλθῃ* — “when it comes”), not as an unfolding eternal reality. The language of arrival implies a moment, not a mode of existence.
- The Corinthians were asking about gifts in their present assemblies (chapters 12-14). An answer pointing to the eternal state is true and important, but it may be a more remote answer than their immediate question requires.

Comparative Analysis

Dimension	Canon (View 1)	Christ’s Return (View 2)	Church Maturity (View 3)	Eternal State (View 4)
Timing	c. 90-100 AD	Future (parousia)	Gradual / ongoing	Future (eschaton)
“Face to face” means	Completed Scripture	Seeing Christ personally	Mature spiritual fellowship	Beatific vision
Key passage support	2 Tim 3:16-17; Jude 3	1 John 3:2; Rev 22:4	Eph 4:11-13; Phil 3:15	Rev 21-22; Augustine
Early church support	None	Near-unanimous (Clement excepted)	Clement of Alexandria	Augustine and later
Gifts implication	Ceased c. 100 AD	No terminus before the parousia asserted	Yield gradually to maturity	No terminus before the eschaton asserted
Pastoral strength	Scripture’s sufficiency	Eschatological hope	Ongoing growth	Ultimate hope
Main exegetical weakness	“Face to face” anachronism	Defers discernment question	Church has not arrived	Confuses arrival with state

The Cessationist-Continuationist Intersection

The practical urgency of this debate is rarely about 1 Corinthians 13:10 in isolation. The question “what is the perfect?” is almost always a proxy for the larger question: “Do revelatory spiritual gifts — prophecy, tongues, word of knowledge — continue to operate in the church today?”

The alignment is broadly as follows:

Cessationists (gifts have ceased) typically hold View 1, or hold View 2 while arguing that gifts ceased for *other* redemptive-historical reasons — the close of the apostolic age, the completion of the foundational revelation — independent of what “the perfect” means. Richard Gaffin represents this nuanced position: he argues for the eschatological reading of “the perfect” but maintains cessationism on the grounds that prophetic gifts were uniquely tied to the apostolic foundation of the church (Ephesians 2:20).

Continuationists (gifts continue) typically hold Views 2, 3, or 4. Gordon Fee is a prominent example: he holds View 2 and argues that gifts continue until Christ’s return.

The separation of the two questions is real, but it is not symmetrical, and honesty requires saying so. On the eschatological reading, the verse *entails* neither position: one can hold that reading and remain cessationist, as Gaffin does. (On the canon reading, by contrast, the verse straightforwardly entails cessation — the separation thesis is conditional on the reading this study judges strongest.) Nor does “no terminus asserted” collapse into “continuation entailed”: the cessationist counter-move, in Gaffin’s form, is that verses 8-10 address the partial *mode of knowledge* of the whole church between the advents, not the duration of each individual charisma — so a particular gift could lapse within the age without the verse addressing it. But the burden thereby shifts: on the eschatological reading, the case for cessation must be carried entirely by arguments outside this text (Ephesians 2:20, the apostolic-foundation argument, the historical record). The verse does not settle the debate; it does assign the homework.

That this separation is livable is not a modern discovery. Chrysostom held both sides of it in the fourth century: he read “the perfect” as the resurrection *and* observed that the gifts “then used to occur but now no longer take place” (Homily 29.1). Calvin held both sides of it in the sixteenth: his commentary reads verse 10’s perfection as beginning “at death” and “not completely manifested until the day of judgment,” while his Institutes teach that “the gift of healing disappeared with the other miraculous powers which the Lord was pleased to give for a time” (Comm. 1 Cor. 13:10; Inst. 4.19.18). The Puritan John Owen — a firm cessationist and the tradition’s great theologian of the Spirit — carried the case through the close of the extraordinary offices; his *Discourse Concerning the Holy Spirit* does not argue it from this verse. Jonathan Edwards held both sides of it in the eighteenth: in *Charity and Its Fruits* he taught that “the canon of Scripture being completed when the apostle John had written the book of Revelation... these miraculous gifts were no longer continued in the church” — yet his sermon on this very passage, “Heaven, a World of Charity or Love,” reads “that which is perfect” as heaven, the perfect state of the church. The man who believed the gifts ended at the canon’s close never read the canon into this verse. And John MacArthur — arguably the most prominent living cessationist — reads “the perfect” as the eternal state and rejects the canon view outright, carrying cessation instead on the *παύσονται* argument and the apostolic-age function of the gifts (*1 Corinthians*, MacArthur New Testament Commentary, 1984). Among living scholars, Thomas R. Schreiner — a self-described “nuanced cessationist” — reads “the perfect” as the second coming, rejects the canon

view and the verb-voice argument outright, and states the asymmetry in his own words: 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 “is a good argument for all the gifts lasting until the second coming, but this text does not demand that all the gifts continue” (*Spiritual Gifts: What They Are and Why They Matter*, B&H, 2018). The modern debate in miniature: R. Fowler White’s comparison of Richard Gaffin and Wayne Grudem (“Richard Gaffin and Wayne Grudem on 1 Cor 13:10,” *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 35/2 [1992]: 173-181) examines a cessationist and a continuationist who *agree* that “the perfect” arrives at Christ’s return — and locate their disagreement elsewhere; White defends the exegetical backbone of the other-grounds case in a companion piece on the apostolic-foundation reading of Ephesians 2:20 (“Gaffin and Grudem on Eph 2:20: In Defense of Gaffin’s Cessationist Exegesis,” *Westminster Theological Journal* 54 [1992]: 321-330).

Three important clarifications:

First, one can hold View 2 (the eschatological reading) and still be functionally cessationist — the historical witnesses above prove the combination livable. The exegesis of 1 Corinthians 13:10 does not by itself settle the gifts debate, though on the eschatological reading the settling must happen elsewhere.

Second, the gifts debate has a life beyond this passage. 1 Corinthians 12-14, Romans 12, Ephesians 4, Acts, and the question of the apostolic foundation (Ephesians 2:20) all bear on it independently.

Third — and most important — Paul’s purpose in 1 Corinthians 13 is not to answer the gifts question. His purpose is to show that love is greater than any gift and will outlast them all. The Corinthians were using gifts as status markers and sources of division. Paul’s answer is not “your gifts will cease soon” but “your gifts are partial, temporary, and vastly inferior to love, which never fails.” The interpreter who treats this passage primarily as a proof text for cessationism or continuationism has, in an ironic way, repeated the Corinthian error: using gifts (or the argument about them) for purposes other than love.

Pastoral Considerations

Across all four views, several things remain constant — and these are more important for the life of the church than the interpretive question that divides them.

Love is Paul’s argument. Verses 1-3 establish the premise that a person can exercise every gift with maximum intensity and still be nothing without love. Verses 4-7 describe what love is. Verses 8-12 argue that love is permanent while gifts are temporary. Verse 13 declares love the greatest of the three permanent virtues. The structure of the chapter does not make gifts the subject — love is the subject, and gifts are the foil that makes love’s greatness visible.

The “glass darkly” calls for humility now. Whatever one thinks “the perfect” is, verse 12 establishes that present knowledge is partial:

“For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.” — 1 Corinthians 13:12 (KJV)

Knowing “in part” applies to everyone’s reading of this passage, including the present chapter’s author. The appropriate posture is not confidence that one has correctly identified “the perfect,” but humility about the limits of present knowledge — which is, quite precisely, what Paul is teaching.

Something better is coming. All four views agree on this. Whether “the perfect” arrived in 100 AD (View 1) or is still coming (Views 2-4), every interpreter acknowledges that the present mode of knowing God is incomplete and will one day be superseded. This shared conviction is more important for Christian hope than the interpretive disagreement.

Gifts without love are already noise. The debate about when gifts will cease becomes practically moot if they are being exercised without love. Paul’s prior point — that prophecy and tongues and knowledge without love are “sounding brass” and “tinkling cymbal” — applies regardless of when they will end.

“Beloved, let us love one another: for love is of God; and every one that loveth is born of God, and knoweth God.” — 1 John 4:7 (KJV)

Summary (Reality)

On the evidence assembled in this study, the eschatological interpretations — Views 2 and 4 — appear to hold the strongest exegetical and historical ground. “Face to face,” “know even as I am known,” and the near-unanimous testimony of the early church (Clement of Alexandria excepted) all point toward Christ’s return and the eternal state as the referent of “the perfect.” The maturity view (View 3) captures something genuine in Paul’s broader theology of gifts as instruments for building up, even if it struggles with the specific language of verses 11-12. The canon view (View 1) expresses a genuine and important conviction about Scripture’s sufficiency, and it has produced serious and godly interpreters — but it faces exegetical difficulties that its most honest advocates acknowledge: the “face to face” language, the knowledge asymmetry of verse 12, the absence of any patristic support, and the anachronism of expecting Paul’s Corinthian readers to have the concept of a 27-book New Testament in mind.

A thoughtful reader who weighs this evidence carefully should approach the remaining question — whether gifts continue today — with both seriousness and charity. The text does not resolve that question as directly as either side of the contemporary debate sometimes implies. What the text does resolve is the surpassing greatness of love. That conclusion is not partial. It is not “through a glass, darkly.” It is the one thing in this chapter that Paul states without qualification: *“the greatest of these is charity.”*

Chapter 5: Synthesis — Where Do We Stand?

1. What Has Come Before

Four chapters have built the case, layer by layer. Before asking where the evidence lands, it is worth pausing to state what each layer actually established.

Scripture (Chapter 1): The grammar of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 clearly presents a future contrast — partial knowledge now, complete knowledge then — but the text deliberately leaves the referent of τὸ τέλειον (“the perfect”) unresolved. The “face

to face” language echoes the Moses-at-Sinai tradition of Numbers 12:8, placing the future knowing in the category of what was once Moses’s exclusive privilege. Four candidate interpretations are exegetically possible; none is grammatically compelled. The middle voice of *παύσονται* (tongues “will cease”) is a real grammatical variation from *καταργηθήσεται* (prophecy and knowledge “will be rendered inoperative”), and its interpretive weight is genuinely disputed. What is not disputed: love never fails, gifts are temporary, and the partial is destined to be superseded.

Christocentrism (Chapter 2): The Christocentric lens confirms that “face to face” has deep Mosaic typology and that its fullest referent is the vision of Christ himself — confirmed by 1 John 3:2 (“we shall see him as he is”) and Revelation 22:4 (“they shall see his face”). Jesus’s use of *τέλειος* in Matthew 5:48 (“Be ye therefore perfect”) establishes that the same word describes a present ethical pursuit, not only a future eschatological event — complicating any reading that places “the perfect” entirely beyond the present age. The already/not-yet character of Jesus’s kingdom teaching maps directly onto the interpretive tension: “the perfect” may have both a present dimension (the ongoing pursuit of love) and a future arrival (Christ himself at the Parousia). Jesus’s own prayer in John 17:23 — “that they may be made perfect in one” — uses the same *teleioō* root and locates it in the context of unity and love, two things Paul is equally concerned with in 1 Corinthians 12-14.

Antiquity (Chapter 3): The early church read 1 Corinthians 13:10 with striking consistency: “the perfect” is eschatological. From the Didache’s call to “be made perfect in the last time,” through Irenaeus’s argument that complete knowledge belongs to the age to come, through Tertullian’s reserving of the face-to-face encounter “to some future time” (*Against Praxeas* 14), through Chrysostom’s exposition that when the perfect comes “we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more,” to Augustine’s beatific vision of *De Trinitate* 15: the weight of the ancient tradition is unanimous against the canon reading and near-unanimous in its eschatological direction. Two departures deserve honest recording: Clement of Alexandria reads “the perfect” as present spiritual maturity (though his direct exegesis of v. 12 in *Paedagogus* 1.6 remains eschatological), and John of Damascus (8th c.) reads it as the law of Christ over against the law of Moses — neither of them a canon-completion reading. No ancient interpreter, before or after the formal closing of the canon, connected *τὸ τέλειον* with the completion of Scripture. That interpretation has no patristic attestation and must stand on exegetical grounds alone.

Reality (Chapter 4): The four major views today — completed canon, Christ’s return, church maturity, and the eternal state — each have genuine exegetical footing, though they are not equally supported. The canon view faces the challenges of anachronism, the personal-encounter force of “face to face,” the knowledge asymmetry of verse 12, and the total absence of ancient support. The maturity view captures Paul’s broader theology of gifts as instruments for building up, but struggles with the decisive arrival language of *ὅταν ἔλθῃ* and the impossibility of any present human state matching “know even as I am known.” On the evidence assembled here, the eschatological views appear to hold the strongest exegetical and historical ground. Crucially, one can hold the eschatological reading of this passage and still be functionally cessationist on other grounds — meaning this text does not by itself settle the cessationist-continuationist debate, whichever way you read it.

2. Areas of Agreement

The debate about “the perfect” can obscure how much common ground all serious readers of 1 Corinthians 13 share. The agreements are not trivial concessions — they are the substance of Paul’s argument.

Love is permanent and supreme. Every tradition that has ever engaged this text agrees that love holds the preeminent position. Paul says it directly:

“Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away.” — 1 Corinthians 13:8 (KJV)

Cessationist, continuationist, Catholic, Orthodox, Reformed, Pentecostal — all agree: love never fails. It does not cease with the gifts; it outlasts them. It is not one virtue ranked first; it is the character of God himself.

Present knowledge is genuinely partial. This is Paul’s explicit claim and no interpreter denies it:

“For we know in part, and we prophesy in part.” — 1 Corinthians 13:9 (KJV)

Whether partial knowledge will be superseded at 100 AD, at the Parousia, or in the eternal state — every view agrees that it *is* partial now. Every preacher, every theologian, every commentator who has written on this passage knows “in part.” That shared limitation ought to produce shared humility.

A future completion is coming. All views agree that the “then” of verse 12 is genuinely future from Paul’s perspective in his own argument, and genuinely better than the “now”:

“For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.” — 1 Corinthians 13:12 (KJV)

Something is coming. Something changes the mode of knowing entirely. Whatever we call it, its arrival renders the partial instruments unnecessary. The question is when and what — not whether.

The gifts serve the body’s edification. Across chapters 12-14, Paul is consistent: gifts exist to build up the body of Christ, not to confer status on individuals. This is equally clear to cessationists and continuationists. Gifts are for service; they are never the point.

“Face to face” is our destiny. All traditions confess that believers will one day see God directly — whether at Christ’s return, in the resurrection, or in the eternal state. The disagreement is about timing and mechanism, not about the promise itself. Every reader of this text is waiting for the same thing.

Faith, hope, and love remain through all present circumstances. Paul’s closing triad describes the shape of the Christian life now, in the between-times:

“And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.” — 1 Corinthians 13:13 (KJV)

No view disputes this. Faith, hope, and love are the characteristic graces of the present age. Love is the greatest because it alone extends beyond this age into the eternal

state. All agree — and this agreement is more than a consolation. It is the very thing Paul set out to establish.

3. Areas of Tension

Agreement on the large things does not resolve the smaller ones. The genuine disagreements deserve to be named honestly and precisely, without forcing a resolution they have not yet found.

Tension 1: The Referent of τὸ τέλειον

The canon view's strongest argument: The same *τέλειος* root that Paul uses in 1 Corinthians 13:10 appears in 2 Timothy 3:17 to describe what Scripture makes a believer — thoroughly furnished for every good work — and in James 1:25 to describe “the perfect law of liberty”; if the word can attach to the completed written word of God in those contexts, and if the Spirit’s promise to guide the apostles into “all truth” (John 16:13) was fulfilled in the apostolic writings, then the completed canon is a legitimate candidate for what Paul calls “the perfect.”

The eschatological view's strongest argument: “Face to face” (*πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον*) is consistently used in the Old Testament for direct, personal divine encounter — Moses at the tent (Exodus 33:11), the eulogist’s assessment at Moses’s death (Deuteronomy 34:10) — and the phrase is nowhere applied to a text in the Greek Old Testament; it demands a person, and 1 John 3:2 names him: “we shall see him as he is.”

The maturity view's strongest argument: Paul uses *τέλειος* for present, achievable human maturity throughout his letters (1 Corinthians 2:6; Philippians 3:15; Colossians 1:28), and Ephesians 4:13 explicitly uses *ἄνδρα τέλειον* (“a perfect man”) for the corporate maturity of the body toward which gifts are serving — making the gifts-to-maturity trajectory the most natural Pauline parallel available, since it uses the same word, the same gift-context, and the same “until” logic as 1 Corinthians 13:8-10.

This tension is real. Grammar does not settle it. Context is disputed. Honest readers land in different places.

Tension 2: The Middle Voice of παύσονται

The cessationist reading: The grammatical variation between *καταργηθήσονται* (future passive: prophecy and knowledge will be *rendered* inoperative by an external cause — the coming of the perfect) and *παύσονται* (future middle: tongues will cease *of themselves*) is intentional and theologically significant; tongues have their own internal cessation, prior to and independent of the coming of the perfect, suggesting they belong to a different timeline from prophecy and knowledge.

The continuationist response: The middle voice of *παύω* is simply the standard intransitive form of this verb in Hellenistic Greek; asserting that it implies a different mechanism or timing of cessation from the passive *καταργηθήσονται* overloads a common grammatical form; both verbs describe the same future transition without specifying different schedules, and Paul is not treating tongues as exceptional — he is treating them as parallel.

Why this matters pastorally: If the cessationist reading of the middle voice is correct, it provides a grammatical basis for concluding that tongues ceased within the apostolic period itself, independent of any debate about “the perfect” — a conclusion that would directly affect every charismatic and Pentecostal church practicing glossolalia today. If the continuationist response is correct, the verse provides no such basis. The stakes of this grammatical question reach directly into Sunday morning practice across millions of congregations.

Tension 3: The Timing of “Then” (τότε)

The already-happened reading: “Then face to face” describes a condition that arrived with the completion of the New Testament; we now have the completed canon, and while present knowledge is still partial in the sense that no individual knows all of Scripture perfectly, the “perfect” revelation is present and available; the “then” belongs to the past from our vantage point.

The not-yet reading: “Then shall I know even as also I am known” — the future knowing is compared to God’s knowing of Paul, which is comprehensive, thorough, and personal; no one who holds the completed canon in their hands knows God with the thoroughness with which God knows them; the “then” is therefore still ahead, pointing toward the resurrection and the direct vision of God that no completed text, however inspired, can supply.

Tension 4: The Cessationist-Continuationist Divide

This is the practical reason the debate about *τὸ τέλειον* burns so intensely in contemporary churches. The question “what is the perfect?” is often not really about Paul’s Greek. It is about whether the person in the next pew who claims to speak in tongues is practicing something authentic and biblical, or something to be discouraged or corrected.

That is a real question, and it deserves a real answer. But 1 Corinthians 13:10 does not directly supply it — in either direction. As Chapter 4 established, one can hold the eschatological reading of “the perfect” and still conclude on other grounds that revelatory gifts have ceased — Chrysostom, Edwards, and Gaffin all did. And one can hold the canon view and still acknowledge that the “face to face” language of verse 12 sits uneasily with the arrival of a written document. The separation is real but not symmetrical: on the eschatological reading, the verse asserts no terminus for the gifts before the parousia, so the cessationist case must be made from other texts. The verse does not settle the debate; it assigns the homework.

What must be said clearly is this: Paul’s purpose in 1 Corinthians 13 is not to settle the gifts question. His purpose is to relativize the gifts in the light of love. Using this passage as a proof text in either direction has a certain irony to it — the chapter exists precisely to expose the danger of letting gifts, or arguments about gifts, become more important than love.

4. The Weight of Evidence

Without declaring a winner, honesty requires acknowledging where the evidence actually tilts.

The grammar establishes a future, indefinite arrival — from Paul’s vantage. Any referent later than 55 AD, canon completion included, satisfies the construction; the *eschatological* tilt comes from verse 12’s content and Paul’s parallel usage, not from the construction alone. The *ὅταν* + *aorist subjunctive* construction of verse 10 (*ὅταν δὲ ἔλθῃ τὸ τέλειον* — “but whenever the perfect comes”) uses the same construction Paul uses for events of future and uncertain timing (cf. 1 Corinthians 15:54, *ὅταν δὲ τὸ φθαρτὸν τοῦτο ἐνδύσῃται ἀφθαρσίαν*; 1 John 3:2 makes the same future-uncertainty point with a conditional, *ἐὰν φανερωθῇ*). The future middle *ἐπιγνώσομαι* (“I shall know fully”) in verse 12 is unambiguous: this knowing does not yet belong to Paul, and it will not while he lives. The *τότε* (“then”) that governs verse 12 is the natural counterpart to *ἄρτι* (“now”) in the same verse — and Paul uses *ἄρτι* throughout the letter to mark the present age, contrasted with a future he genuinely awaits.

The patristic evidence is unanimous against the canon reading, and near-unanimous in its eschatological direction. Not one interpreter from the Didache to Augustine read “the perfect” as the completed canon. Tertullian set Numbers 12:6-8 beside 1 Corinthians 13:12 and reserved the face-to-face encounter “to some future time” as though no other reading needed answering. Chrysostom stated the future completion as simple exegesis: “we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more.” Augustine built an entire theology of present limitation and future beatific vision on this passage. Clement of Alexandria’s maturity reading is the one exception to the direction — and even he never glances at a canon. The early church was not a homogeneous tradition — Tertullian and Origen disagreed on many things — but on this passage all but one agree, and the agreement spans East and West, Greek and Latin, pre-Nicene and post-Nicene.

The canon view faces challenges that its most honest advocates acknowledge. B.B. Warfield’s *Counterfeit Miracles* (1918) never cites 1 Corinthians 13:10 at all (Decker); Richard Gaffin explicitly holds the eschatological reading of “the perfect” while maintaining cessationism on other grounds. That is a significant concession: the scholars who have thought most carefully about this passage within the cessationist tradition are not confident that the canon view is exegetically defensible. The “face to face” language, in particular, is difficult to reconcile with the arrival of a text — however precious the text, it is not a face.

The maturity view captures something real. Paul’s broader theology does treat gifts as servants of maturation. Ephesians 4:11-13 is a genuine parallel. The childhood analogy of verse 11 does invite a reading that includes process and growth. A purely event-eschatological reading that ignores the present dimension of *τέλειος* in Paul misses something that Clement of Alexandria, whatever his philosophical debts, correctly perceived. The maturity view functions better as a corrective to over-realized eschatology than as a complete account of 1 Corinthians 13:10, because it cannot account for the personal intensity of “face to face” and “know even as I am known” — states that exceed any present human achievement, however mature.

Each reader must weigh the evidence and decide. The conclusions above are offered honestly, not as a verdict. The text is genuinely open at several points, and the exegetical question remains in honest dispute among careful scholars. What the evidence does not support is the casual confidence that sometimes attaches to each position — as if the Greek settled what the Greek has, in fact, left open.

5. Questions for the Reader

These questions are not rhetorical. They are designed to help you weigh the evidence along each SCAR axis. They have answers — but the answers are yours to work out.

From Scripture

- When Paul says “then face to face,” the Old Testament background of *πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* is consistently a description of direct divine encounter (Genesis 32:30; Exodus 33:11; Deuteronomy 34:10). Can you imagine the Corinthian hearers of this letter understanding that phrase as a metaphor for receiving a completed collection of apostolic documents?
- “Then shall I know even as also I am known” (τότε δὲ ἐπιγνώσομαι καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην) — the passive *ἐπεγνώσθην* describes Paul being fully known, most naturally by God. Does God know Paul *through a text*, or directly and comprehensively? If the latter, what kind of event could supply a knowing analogous to that?
- Can the neuter τὸ τέλειον naturally refer to a collection of books? Greek uses the neuter for abstract states, events, and even persons by quality — but can you find another instance in the New Testament where a neuter τέλειον substantive refers to a written document?
- The ὅταν + *subjunctive* construction places the arrival of “the perfect” as a future contingency from Paul’s vantage — which an arrival c. 100 AD satisfies as readily as the parousia does. The question is therefore not grammatical but material: does the *content* of verses 11-12 — seeing face to face, knowing as known — fit an arrival within the first readers’ generation?

From Christocentrism

- Jesus taught in Matthew 5:48 that τέλειος describes a present ethical goal: “Be ye therefore perfect, as your Father which is in heaven is perfect.” Does this use of the same root make it impossible to read 1 Corinthians 13:10 as purely eschatological? Or does the already/not-yet framework of the kingdom allow “the perfect” to be both a present pursuit and a future arrival?
- The Moses typology runs through both chapters: “face to face” in 1 Corinthians 13:12 echoes Numbers 12:8 and Deuteronomy 34:10, and Jesus is the new and greater Moses (Hebrews 3:1-6; John 1:17-18). If the “then face to face” of 1 Corinthians 13:12 is fulfilled by seeing Moses’s antitype — seeing Christ as he is (1 John 3:2) — does the typological argument favor the eschatological reading?
- Jesus prayed in John 17:23 that his people “may be made perfect in one” (τετελειωμένοι εἰς ἓν) — the same root, in the context of unity among believers. Does this suggest that *teleioō* has an inescapably relational and corporate dimension that purely individual or textual readings miss?

From Antiquity

- Why did no ancient interpreter, across the roughly three and a half centuries of patristic comment from the Didache to Augustine, connect “the perfect” with the completed biblical canon — even though several of those interpreters lived during

the very period when the canon was being assembled? Is this sustained silence merely an absence of evidence, or does it constitute evidence of absence?

- Does the unanimity of the patristic tradition on the eschatological reading carry probative weight for you? If the early church was wrong about this, at what point did they go wrong, and why would the error be so consistent across geography, language, and theological tradition?
- Clement of Alexandria's "maturity" reading stands largely alone in the ancient period and is shaped by his Platonic-Stoic philosophical context. Does this context make his interpretation more or less persuasive? Is a philosophically-inflected reading suspect, or does Clement see something in Paul that others missed?

From Reality

- When you survey the major commentators on 1 Corinthians, do you notice that cessationist interpreters tend toward the canon view and continuationist interpreters tend toward the eschatological views? If so, what does that pattern suggest about the relationship between prior theological commitments and exegetical conclusions? Is it possible to read this text without being shaped by a prior position on the gifts?
- The canon view's case runs in two directions. In one direction, the verse proves the gifts have ceased: the perfect has come, therefore the partial is done away. In the other, the gifts' cessation helps establish what the perfect is: if the perfect were still future, the temporary gifts would remain normative for the entire church age — which cannot be right, so the perfect must already have come (Chapter 4, Argument 9). Read the two motions in sequence and ask of each: which claim is doing the proving, and which is being proved? What is the verse itself contributing? And what would the identification rest on if the question of the gifts were set aside entirely?
- Notice, too, how the historical record is handled within the same case. The post-apostolic fading of the gifts is offered as supporting evidence (Chapter 4, Argument 6). Yet when the record runs the other way — Irenaeus, Tertullian, Novatian, and Augustine testifying to gifts operating long after the canon closed — the view's fullest modern defense replies that historical arguments are "subject to interpretation" and that claimed miracles may "emanate from sources other than God" (Woods, citing Exodus 7:10-13 and Matthew 24:24). Ask: under this handling, what possible occurrence of a gift, in any century, could count as evidence against the view? If no occurrence could, is "the gifts have ceased" functioning as a historical claim or a doctrinal one? Then ask the continuationist the symmetrical question: what possible pattern of absence would count as evidence against continuation? The concrete candidates are real: Chrysostom's fourth-century observation that the gifts had already faded ("this whole place is very obscure: but the obscurity is produced by our ignorance of the facts referred to, and by their cessation, being such as then used to occur but now no longer take place," Homily 29.1); the sparse post-apostolic historical record itself; and the trajectory from Paul's own weighing of prophecy (1 Cor. 14:29; 1 Thess. 5:21) to prophecy's effective disappearance from later church order. A continuationism that treats these as non-evidence risks the mirror-image of the difficulty just named.
- Consider a datum from within the canon reading's own institutional tradition.

Grace Theological Seminary produced substantial early dispensationalist defenses of the canon view — Smith’s 1970 Th.D. (later published as *Tongues in Biblical Perspective*, BMH, 1972), Miller’s 1977 Th.D., and, at the seminary’s foundation, Grace’s founder McClain supervising Tamkin’s 1949 argument for it; the tradition’s later scholarly extension is R. Bruce Compton’s Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal defenses (2004, 2020). Yet over the same three-and-a-half decades Grace also produced the reading’s sharpest internal strain and critics — Stamp 1970 engineering a “modified second coming” decoupling to hold both an inherited canon reading of verse 10 and an honest parousia reading of verse 12; Reid 1978 revising verse 10 to the eternal state; Webb 1982 concluding that “building a theology of a completed canon upon a problem passage would doubtless be an exercise in unsound hermeneutics”; Rothhaar 1984 revising verse 10 to modified maturity — with the same faculty member, Charles R. Smith, both *authoring* the seminary’s 1970 defense and *supervising* two of the three open dissents (Reid, Webb) that reject it. Reading these dispensationalist critics on the exegetical difficulty is not the same thing as reading Fee or Grudem: the tradition’s own internal readers do not need to be persuaded of cessationism to weigh what verse 12 says. Ask: what weight does the tradition’s own internal critique carry, when the critics remain committed to the doctrinal conclusion the disputed reading was supposed to defend?

- Richard Gaffin, a careful cessationist scholar, argues for the eschatological reading of “the perfect” while maintaining cessationism on other grounds (the close of the apostolic age, the foundational role of apostles and prophets in Ephesians 2:20). Does this suggest that the cessationist-continuationist debate can be genuinely separated from the question of what τὸ τέλειον means?
- The church maturity view produces a pastoral puzzle: if the gifts should yield when the church reaches maturity, and the church has manifestly not reached maturity in two thousand years of schism and failure, what does that imply for the view’s timeline? Does the ongoing failure of the church’s love and unity count as evidence against this reading?

6. The Love Imperative

Whatever conclusions you reach about τὸ τέλειον, Paul’s purpose in writing 1 Corinthians 13 is not obscure. It has not been obscured by two thousand years of debate. It is stated as plainly as anything in the New Testament.

Paul introduces Chapter 13 with a promise:

“But covet earnestly the best gifts: and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.” — 1 Corinthians 12:31 (KJV)

The “more excellent way” is not a way that replaces the gifts. It is the way by which the gifts must be governed, or they are nothing at all. Paul then lays out the argument in three movements.

The frame (vv. 1-3): Gifts without love are not merely inferior — they are nothing. Speaking in tongues without love: noise. Prophecy without love: nothing. Knowledge without love: nothing. Giving to the poor without love: nothing. Even martyrdom without love: profits nothing. This is a radical claim. The most spectacular spiritual

achievements, devoid of love, have zero spiritual value in Paul's accounting. The Corinthians who were most impressed by tongues and most proud of their gifts needed to hear precisely this.

The content (vv. 4-7): Love's character is not abstract. It is a series of concrete behaviors: patient, kind, not envious, not self-promoting, not easily angered, not keeping accounts of wrongs, not rejoicing in evil but rejoicing in truth, bearing all things, believing all things, hoping all things, enduring all things. These are not descriptions of a feeling. They are descriptions of a way of acting toward specific people in specific situations — including, presumably, toward people who disagree about τὸ τέλειον.

The timeline (vv. 8-13): Love outlasts everything. Gifts are for now; love is forever. Whatever "the perfect" is, love survives its arrival intact. Love does not belong to the partial age any more than it belongs to the perfect age — it belongs to both, because it belongs to the nature of God himself.

Paul returns from Chapter 13 to the practical questions of Chapter 14 with a double imperative that holds both pursuits together:

"Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy." — 1 Corinthians 14:1 (KJV)

Follow after charity *first*. Desire spiritual gifts *also*. The two imperatives are not in competition — they are in sequence. The pursuit of love does not eliminate the pursuit of gifts; it governs it. And both are genuine pursuits, not one.

The argument concludes — as it began, as it always returns — with love:

"And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity." — 1 Corinthians 13:13 (KJV)

Faith, hope, and love remain. In the midst of the interpretive debate about what comes next, these three remain now. They do not wait for the resolution of the τέλειον question. They are the shape of Christian life in the present age, and love is the greatest of them.

7. Final Reflection

The question "What is the perfect?" is genuinely difficult. It has occupied careful exegetes for two thousand years without producing consensus. This study has tried to present the evidence fully and honestly — the grammar, the Old Testament background, the Christological typology, the patristic witness, the major views and their pastoral fruits. What the evidence does not support is the conclusion that the question is easy, or that one tradition has the obvious reading and everyone else is being dishonest with the text.

But the question "What matters most?" is not difficult at all. Paul answered it without ambiguity. Love is greatest. Love never fails. The gifts are partial; love is not. The gifts will be superseded; love will not. Whatever "the perfect" is, it will not supersede love — it will be its fullest expression.

This means that the debate about τὸ τέλειον must itself be conducted in accordance with the commandment that τὸ τέλειον answers to. If our interpretation of this text

damages love — if cessationists use it to dismiss continuationist brothers as credulous, if continuationists use it to dismiss cessationist concerns as faithlessness — then something has gone wrong. Not necessarily with our exegesis. With how we are holding it. A technically correct interpretation held with contempt for those who disagree is a contradiction in terms, measured by the standard of the very chapter we are interpreting.

The early church, for all its disagreements, read 1 Corinthians 13 with its eyes on the horizon. It was waiting for something. “We shall see him as he is.” “They shall see his face.” “Then face to face.” Their primary orientation was hopeful, not polemical. They were less interested in which gifts were ending than in what was coming to replace them. That posture — eyes forward, love governing the present, hope sustaining the waiting — is perhaps the most faithful response to a text that has so much to say about the difference between what is partial and what endures.

Whatever “the perfect” is, it has not yet come. We are still, every one of us, seeing through a glass. That is precisely why love is the command of the hour.

Navigation: return to Chapter 0: Overview for the executive summary, or to the study landing page for the full table of contents.

Appendix A: Hebrew and Greek Word Study

This appendix collects and expands all key word studies from 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 that bear on the interpretation of “the perfect” (τὸ τέλειον). Each entry is designed as a standalone reference: you can read the full appendix for depth or consult a single section as needed. The goal is not to drive you to a conclusion but to equip you to read the Greek text more precisely than any English translation allows.

The method: for each term, we examine the root meaning, the full semantic range, how Paul uses it elsewhere, how it is translated across versions, and what it contributes to the central interpretive question.

Perfect, Complete, Mature — *teleios / to teleion* (Strong’s G5046)

Greek: τέλειος / τὸ τέλειον **Root meaning:** From τέλος (telos, G5056), “end, goal, completion.” Something that has reached its telos — its designed endpoint. **Semantic range:** Perfect; complete; lacking nothing; mature; full-grown; adult; fully developed; entire.

Morphology

The form in 1 Corinthians 13:10 is τὸ τέλειον — a neuter singular adjective substantivized by the definite article τὸ. This construction means “the perfect thing” or “the perfect state.” Greek regularly uses article + adjective to create a noun phrase. The gender is important:

- **Neuter (τὸ τέλειον):** suggests a state, condition, or thing — “the complete state,” “the perfection”

- **Masculine (ὁ τέλειος):** would more naturally point to a person — “the perfect one”
- **Feminine (ἡ τελεία):** would follow a feminine noun

Paul chose neuter. This does not absolutely exclude a personal referent (neuter can refer to concepts that include persons), but it does make “the perfect” sound more like a state or era than a specific individual. Interpreters who identify τὸ τέλειον with Christ must reckon with this morphological datum.

BDAG Definition

BDAG (3rd ed., pp. 995–996; entry content verified against the scanned text) opens the entry “gener. ‘attaining an end or purpose, complete’ ” and gives two main senses:

1. **“Pert. to meeting the highest standard”** — “of things, perfect”
2. **“Pert. to being mature, full-grown, mature, adult”**

For 1 Corinthians 13:10 the entry’s actual wording is instructive — and hedged: “Subst. τὸ τέλειον *what is perfect* Ro 12:2; **perh.** 1 Cor 13:10 (opp. ἐκ μέρους).” Two things follow. BDAG files the verse (tentatively) under the qualitative “highest standard” sense, not the “mature” sense — and its “perh.” concedes that even the standard lexicon regards the classification as uncertain.

Usage in key passages (teleios)

- **Matthew 5:48:** “Be ye therefore perfect (τέλειοι), even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect (τέλειός ἐστιν).” Here τέλειοι is plural and personal — describing persons called to moral completeness in the manner of God. This is the “ethical perfection” sense.
- **1 Corinthians 2:6:** “We speak wisdom among them that are perfect (τελείοις).” Paul addresses the mature or spiritually adult within the congregation. The contrast is with νηπίοις (“infants,” 3:1). This is the “maturity” sense.
- **1 Corinthians 14:20:** “Brethren, be not children in understanding; howbeit in malice be ye children, but in understanding be men (τέλειοι).” Again personal, contrasted with children — the “adulthood” sense.
- **Ephesians 4:13:** “Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man (ἄνδρα τέλειον), unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.” Corporate maturity of the Church, aimed at an eschatological fullness.
- **Philippians 3:15:** “Let us therefore, as many as be perfect (τέλειοι), be thus minded.” Paul includes himself as “perfect” in some sense, yet in v.12 he says he has “not already attained” — showing the word can describe both a present and a future state depending on context.
- **Colossians 1:28:** “...that we may present every man perfect (τέλειον) in Christ Jesus.” Goal of apostolic ministry, future-oriented but expressed as a present aim.
- **Colossians 4:12:** “That ye may stand perfect (τέλειοι) and complete (πεπληρωμένοι) in all the will of God.” (πεπληρωμένοι is the TR reading behind the KJV’s “complete”; NA28/SBLGNT read πεπληροφορημένοι, “fully assured.”) Two terms together; both point toward a state of spiritual wholeness.
- **Hebrews 5:14:** “But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age (τελείων).” The mature as contrasted with infants who drink milk.

- **James 1:4:** “Let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect (τέλειοι) and entire (όλόκληροι), wanting nothing.” The pairing with όλόκληρος (“whole, complete, lacking no part”) clarifies the “lacking nothing” dimension of the word.
- **James 1:17:** “Every good gift and every perfect gift (δώρημα τέλειον) is from above.” Used of things, not persons — “perfect gifts.”
- **James 1:25:** “But whoso looketh into the perfect law (νόμον τέλειον) of liberty, and continueth therein... this man shall be blessed in his deed.” The law of God described as “perfect” in the sense of complete and entire.
- **James 3:2:** “For in many things we offend all. If any man offend not in word, the same is a perfect (τέλειος) man, and able also to bridle the whole body.” Full moral self-command.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:10 (teleios)

Translation	Rendering	Notes
KJV	“that which is perfect”	Neuter construction preserved
ESV	“the perfect”	Minimal, preserves ambiguity
NASB (2020)	“the perfect”	Same
NIV	“completeness”	Interprets the term as “fullness/completeness”
LSB	“the perfect”	Follows NASB tradition
NRSV	“the complete”	Rendered as abstraction

Significance for the study: τὸ τέλειον establishes that “the perfect” is a state or condition, not merely an attribute of a person. The word’s semantic range spans ethical perfection, maturity, and eschatological completion. The context of 1 Corinthians 13 — particularly the ἄρτι/τότε (“now/then”) contrast and the “face to face” language of v.12 — must determine which shade of meaning Paul intends. The word itself does not settle the question; it opens the interpretive space.

Render Inoperative, Supersede — *katargeō* (Strong’s G2673)

Greek: καταργέω **Root meaning:** From κατά (down, against, intensive) + ἀργέω (to be idle, inactive), from ἀργός (inactive, idle). The compound means “to make inactive, render inoperative, put out of use.” **Semantic range:** To render inoperative; to make idle; to nullify; to abolish; to do away with; to bring to nothing; to be freed from. Importantly: NOT necessarily “to destroy” — the thing rendered inoperative may still exist, but it no longer functions or is needed.

Paul’s signature word

Paul uses καταργέω 25 times in his letters. No other New Testament writer uses it more than twice. This is a characteristically Pauline term, and tracing his usage

across the corpus reveals a consistent pattern: something *temporary* or *preparatory* is rendered inoperative by something *permanent* or *superior*. The old is not annihilated; it is superseded.

Usage in key passages (katargeō)

- **Romans 3:3:** “For what if some did not believe? shall their unbelief make the faith of God without effect (καταργήσει)?” God’s faithfulness cannot be nullified.
- **Romans 3:31:** “Do we then make void (καταργοῦμεν) the law through faith? God forbid: yea, we establish the law.” Faith does not render the law inoperative — Paul insists on the law’s ongoing validity even as its role changes.
- **Romans 6:6:** “Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him, that the body of sin might be destroyed (καταργηθῇ), that henceforth we should not serve sin.” The body of sin “rendered inoperative” — it loses its power to compel.
- **1 Corinthians 1:28:** “And base things of the world, and things which are despised, hath God chosen, yea, and things which are not, to bring to nought (καταργήσῃ) things that are.” God’s election nullifies human status categories.
- **1 Corinthians 2:6:** “Howbeit we speak wisdom among them that are perfect: yet not the wisdom of this world, nor of the princes of this world, that come to nought (τῶν καταργουμένων).” The rulers of this age are being rendered inoperative — ongoing, present-tense process.
- **1 Corinthians 6:13:** “Meats for the belly, and the belly for meats: but God shall destroy (καταργήσει) both it and them.” The stomach and food will one day be superseded by resurrection life.
- **1 Corinthians 13:8,10,11:** Four uses in the passage: prophecy will be καταργηθήσονται (rendered inoperative), knowledge will be καταργηθήσεται, the partial will be καταργηθήσεται when the perfect comes — and Paul applies the same verb to himself in verse 11: κατήργηκα τὰ τοῦ νηπίου, “I have put away childish things.”
- **1 Corinthians 15:24:** “Then cometh the end, when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father; when he shall have put down (καταργήσῃ) all rule and all authority and power.” At the eschatological consummation, all rival powers rendered inoperative.
- **1 Corinthians 15:26:** “The last enemy that shall be destroyed (καταργεῖται) is death.” Death — the most powerful adversary — rendered inoperative at resurrection.
- **2 Corinthians 3:7,11,13,14:** Four uses in the “letter kills, Spirit gives life” argument. The old covenant ministry had glory — but a “fading” (καταργουμένην) glory, being rendered inoperative. The veil on Moses’s face hid what was being done away with. The covenant is being superseded, not annihilated.
- **Galatians 3:17:** “And this I say, that the covenant, that was confirmed before of God in Christ, the law, which was four hundred and thirty years after, cannot disannul (καταργῆσαι) it.” The law cannot nullify the prior promise.
- **Galatians 5:4:** “Christ is become of no effect (κατηργήθητε) unto you, whosoever of you are justified by the law; ye are fallen from grace.” To seek justification by law is to render Christ inoperative in your life.
- **Ephesians 2:15:** “Having abolished (καταργήσας) in his flesh the enmity, even the law of commandments contained in ordinances.” Christ rendered inoperative the specific regulatory aspect of the Mosaic law.
- **2 Thessalonians 2:8:** “And then shall that Wicked be revealed, whom the Lord shall consume with the spirit of his mouth, and shall destroy (καταργήσῃ) with

the brightness of his coming.” The man of lawlessness rendered inoperative at Christ’s return.

- **2 Timothy 1:10:** “But is now made manifest by the appearing of our Saviour Jesus Christ, who hath abolished (καταργήσαντος) death, and hath brought life and immortality to light through the gospel.” Christ has already rendered death inoperative — though we await its final cessation (1 Cor 15:26).

The pattern

Across all 25 uses, the pattern is consistent: καταργέω describes the supersession of something real and functional by something greater. The old covenant’s glory is genuine — but it yields to the new. The law’s regulatory demands are real — but they yield to Christ’s fulfillment. Death is real — but it yields to resurrection. Prophecy and knowledge are real gifts of the Spirit — but they yield to “the perfect.”

This is not annihilation but succession. The gifts are genuine. Their cessation is the result of something better arriving, not their own failure.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:8,10 (katargeō)

Translation	Rendering	Notes
KJV	“fail” / “vanish away” (v.8), “done away” (v.10)	Varies within the passage
ESV	“pass away” (v.8), “pass away” (v.10)	Consistent but “pass away” softens the force
NASB (2020)	“be done away with”	Closest to the literal force
NIV	“cease” / “pass away” (v.8), “disappear” (v.10)	“Disappear” loses the supersession nuance
LSB	“be done away”	Follows NASB

Significance for the study: The word choice is theologically loaded. “Done away” or “rendered inoperative” is more precise than “destroyed” or “disappear.” The gifts are not failing; they are being superseded. The question of *when* they are superseded is what separates the interpretive camps — but all can agree that the gifts are genuine and the supersession is real.

Cease, Stop — *pauō* (Strong’s G3973)

Greek: παύω **Root meaning:** To bring to a halt; to stop; to cause to cease. The middle voice (which is the form in 1 Cor 13:8) carries the sense of stopping oneself, ceasing of one’s own accord. **Semantic range:** Active: to cause to stop, restrain, bring to an end. Middle: to cease, stop of oneself, come to rest.

The grammatical debate

This is among the most technically contested points in the entire debate. In 1 Corinthians 13:8, Paul uses three different constructions for three gifts:

“whether there be prophecies, they shall fail (καταργηθήσονται — future passive); whether there be tongues, they shall cease (παύσονται — future middle); whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away (καταργηθήσεται — future passive)” — 1 Corinthians 13:8 (KJV, with Greek forms noted)

Prophecy and knowledge: future *passive* of καταργέω — they will be *rendered inoperative* (by something outside themselves, presumably by “the perfect”).

Tongues: future *middle* of παύω — they will *cease* (with the middle voice suggesting self-cessation).

The cessationist argument (advanced as early as Stanley D. Toussaint, “First Corinthians Thirteen and the Tongues Question,” *BSac* 120 [1963]: 311-16, who paired it with an eschatological reading of τὸ τέλειον; developed most fully by Thomas R. Edgar; Robert L. Thomas advances it tentatively — “perhaps no great significance may be attached to this distinction,” *JETS* 17 [1974]: 81): The middle voice is significant. When Paul uses the future passive for prophecy and knowledge, he indicates they will be *brought to an end* by the coming of “the perfect.” But when he uses the future middle for tongues, he indicates tongues will *cease of themselves* — they will die out on their own, before the other gifts are superseded. This is taken to mean tongues ceased in the apostolic age, independently of “the perfect.”

The continuationist counterargument (associated with D.A. Carson, Gordon Fee, and others): The voice distinction cannot bear the weight placed on it:

1. **παύω is naturally middle-tending.** In the New Testament, παύω appears rarely in the active voice. The middle form is nearly idiomatic — Greek authors often use παύω in the middle simply because that is how the verb most naturally appears, not because they are making a theological point about self-cessation.
2. **Stylistic variation.** Paul avoided repeating καταργηθήσεται three times in succession by using a synonymous verb for tongues. Greek style favors variation (*variatio*). A change of verb does not require a change of meaning.
3. **The context does not support separate timing.** The entire paragraph argues for a single eschatological moment: the coming of “the perfect.” Reading the middle voice as establishing a separate, earlier cessation imports a conclusion the grammar alone cannot establish.
4. **παύσονται does not specify when or why tongues cease.** Even if we grant self-cessation, the grammar leaves open whether they ceased in 70 AD, at the close of the canon, or at the eschaton.

Resolution

The middle voice of παύσονται is a genuine grammatical observation and should not be dismissed. But honest exegesis requires acknowledging that the grammatical form alone does not settle the timing question. To establish that tongues ceased before prophecy and knowledge — and specifically that they ceased in the apostolic age — requires additional historical and theological arguments beyond what the voice distinction alone supplies. The grammar opens a door; it does not itself walk through it.

Usage in key passages (pauō)

- **Luke 8:24:** “And they came to him, and awoke him, saying, Master, master, we perish. Then he arose, and rebuked the wind and the raging of the water: and they ceased (ἐπαύσαντο).” The storm stopped — middle voice, natural cessation.
- **Acts 5:42:** “And daily in the temple, and in every house, they ceased (οὐκ ἐπαύοντο) not to teach and preach Jesus Christ.” They did not stop teaching — ongoing activity.
- **Acts 20:1:** “And after the uproar was ceased (μετὰ τὸ παύσασθαι τὸν θόρυβον — the articular aorist infinitive of παύω), Paul called unto him the disciples.” The riot stopped of itself.
- **1 Peter 4:1:** “For he that hath suffered in the flesh hath ceased from sin (πέπαιται ἁμαρτίας).” Suffering produces cessation from sin — middle voice, internal cessation.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:8 (pauō)

Translation	Rendering of παύσονται	Notes
KJV	“shall cease”	Neutral; does not flag the voice
ESV	“will cease”	Same
NASB (2020)	“will cease”	Same
NIV	“will be stilled”	Slightly more passive in feel
LSB	“will cease”	Same

Significance for the study: Every translation obscures the grammatical distinction that cessationists rely on. To engage this argument, a reader must examine the Greek. The cessationist case from the middle voice is not frivolous — it is a real grammatical observation. But the continuationist reply — that the voice distinction is stylistic rather than theological — is equally well-grounded. Readers should know that this debate exists and that it cannot be resolved by the English text alone.

Mirror — *esoptron* (Strong’s G2072)

Greek: ἑσοπτρον **Root meaning:** From εἰς (into) + the ὁπ- root of seeing (cf. ὄψομαι; ὁράω supplies the present stem) — literally “the seeing-into thing,” an instrument for looking into one’s own face. **Semantic range:** Mirror. The word is simple and specific; there is no significant range of meanings to navigate. The interpretive weight falls entirely on what ancient mirrors were like.

Ancient mirrors: the Corinthian context

Ancient mirrors were not glass with silver backing — they were polished metal. Bronze, silver, or copper, polished to a reflective sheen; such mirrors were fixtures of first-century life, in Corinth as everywhere. Pliny the Elder (*Natural History*, 34.6–8) records that Corinthian bronze (*aes Corinthium*) was the most prized metalwork in the ancient world, formed — according to legend — when gold, silver, and bronze alloys melted

together in the great fire of 146 BC when Corinth was destroyed by Rome and later rebuilt.

A polished bronze mirror gives a recognizable image but not a perfect one. The reflection is real — you can see yourself, recognize your features — but the image is dim, distorted by the curvature and surface imperfections of the metal, dulled by oxidation, and colored by the bronze itself. You know what you look like in a general way, but you do not see yourself with the clarity of direct light.

Paul’s Corinthian readers would have understood the metaphor immediately and precisely. They owned these mirrors. They knew their limitations. The best mirror available to them still produced only an approximation of reality.

The word “darkly” (ἐν αἰνίγματι)

The KJV “through a glass, darkly” combines two Greek phrases:

1. **δι’ ἐσόπτρου**: “through a mirror” — the instrument
2. **ἐν αἰνίγματι**: “in a riddle/enigma” — the *mode* of seeing

The mirror is not dark because mirrors are inherently obscure. It is obscure *in the manner of a riddle* — indirect, puzzling, requiring interpretation. See the next entry (αἰνιγμα) for the full significance of this word.

NT occurrences

Only two: - **1 Corinthians 13:12**: The mirror as metaphor for present partial knowledge. - **James 1:23**: “For if any be a hearer of the word, and not a doer, he is like unto a man beholding his natural face in a glass (ἐν ἐσόπτρῳ).” James uses the mirror as something revealing truth that can be ignored.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:12 (esoptron)

Translation	Rendering	Notes
KJV	“through a glass, darkly”	“Glass” was a period word for mirror
ESV	“in a mirror dimly”	“Dimly” captures the poor image quality
NASB (2020)	“in a mirror dimly”	Same
NIV	“in a mirror; we see only a reflection”	Paraphrastic; adds “only a reflection”
LSB	“in a mirror, dimly”	Same as NASB/ESV

Significance for the study: The mirror metaphor establishes that present knowledge of God is *real but indirect*. We genuinely see something. The image is not false or illusory — it is recognizable. But it is not the same as direct perception. The contrast with “face to face” in the second half of v.12 drives the point home: there is a coming state in which the indirection disappears. What that state is — the closing of the canon, the return of Christ, the eternal state — is what the interpretive debate is about.

The one other Pauline mirror: 2 Corinthians 3:18. Paul’s only other mirror passage uses the cognate verb, not the noun: “But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass (κατοπτριζόμενοι) the glory of the Lord, are changed into the same image.” It matters for our passage in both directions: it shows Paul can describe a present, gospel-mediated beholding in mirror-language — a point canon-view advocates may press — and it confirms that even that transforming beholding is still *mirror-mode*, not face to face. The one other Pauline mirror leaves the ἄρτι/τότε line of 13:12 exactly where it stands.

Riddle, Enigma — *ainigma* (Strong’s G135)

Greek: αἰνίγμα **Root meaning:** From αἰνίσσασθαι (to speak obscurely, to hint at, to speak in riddles). The noun names the thing spoken: an indirect, puzzling communication. **Semantic range:** Riddle; dark saying; enigmatic speech; indirect communication that requires interpretation to understand.

The single NT occurrence

αἰνίγμα appears only once in the entire New Testament: 1 Corinthians 13:12. This rarity makes the word’s background particularly important for interpretation.

The LXX allusion: Numbers 12:8

This is the critical connection. The Septuagint (LXX) uses αἰνίγμα in Numbers 12:8, where God speaks to Miriam and Aaron after they criticize Moses:

“With him will I speak mouth to mouth (στόμα κατὰ στόμα), even apparently, and not in dark speeches (οὐ δι’ αἰνιγματῶν): and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold.” — Numbers 12:8 (KJV, with LXX forms noted)

The Hebrew underlying this passage: הָפִיךְ אֶלֶּי הָאָדָם וְבִרְבֵּי הָאָדָם לֹא הָפִיךְ (“mouth to mouth I speak with him, and in vision, and not in riddles”). The LXX renders תְּרִיחַ (riddles, dark sayings) as αἰνιγματῶν.

The structure of Paul’s allusion:

Numbers 12:8	Moses’s privilege	“Not in riddles (οὐ δι’ αἰνιγματῶν)”	Direct clarity
1 Cor 13:12	Our present state	“In a riddle (ἐν αἰνίγματι)”	Indirect, obscure
1 Cor 13:12	Our future state	“Face to face”	Direct, like Moses

Paul does not quote Numbers 12:8, but he uses its distinctive vocabulary. The connection would have been audible to any reader steeped in the LXX, which Paul’s congregations were.

Paul is saying: What Moses uniquely had — direct, non-riddle communication with God — is what *all believers* will have when “the perfect” comes. This is a radical democratization of the Mosaic privilege. The “not yet” is that we currently experience what Moses was specifically said *not* to experience: enigmatic, indirect communication.

In Greek culture

In the broader Greek world, αἰνίγμα was associated with the riddles of oracles (the Delphic oracle spoke in αἰνίγματα — cryptic pronouncements requiring interpretation) and with the Sphinx’s riddle in the Oedipus legend. The word carried connotations of truth veiled behind puzzling language — present but requiring work to extract. Any educated Corinthian would have recognized the resonance.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:12 (ainigma)

Translation	Rendering of ἐν αἰνίγματι	Notes
KJV	“darkly”	Captures the obscurity but loses the “riddle” connotation
ESV	“dimly”	Same issue — “dim” is visual, αἰνίγμα is communicative
NASB (2020)	“dimly”	Same
NIV	“only a reflection as in a mirror”	Paraphrastic; loses the “riddle” entirely (NIV 2011)
LSB	“dimly”	Same as NASB

No English translation fully preserves the “riddle” sense that makes the Numbers 12:8 allusion visible. A reader of only the English text misses the Moses connection entirely.

Significance for the study: The allusion to Numbers 12:8 is exegetically decisive for understanding the *kind* of “perfection” Paul has in mind. It is not merely the completion of a canon, nor only personal moral maturity — it is the condition of having direct, unmediated communion with God in the manner that Moses uniquely enjoyed. When Paul says “then face to face,” he is promising that *all* believers will stand where Moses stood. Whatever “the perfect” is, it must be something capable of delivering that direct divine encounter.

Face to Face — *prosōpon pros prosōpon*

Greek: πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον **Root meaning:** πρόσωπον means “face” (literally “toward-eye” — the part of the head that faces the observer). The prepositional phrase πρὸς πρόσωπον means “toward the face,” and the doubled construction means “face to face” — direct, unmediated encounter. **Semantic range:** Direct personal encounter; unmediated presence; seeing someone as they truly are.

Hebrew background: the panim tradition

The phrase echoes the Hebrew *פָּנֶיךָ לְפָנֶיךָ* (*panim el panim*, “face to face”) and *פֶּה לְפֶה* (*peh el peh*, “mouth to mouth”). The LXX renders these with *πρόσωπον κατὰ πρόσωπον* or *πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* — slight variations of the same construction Paul uses. The OT background is essential:

Genesis 32:30 (English versification; MT and LXX Rahlfs number the verse 32:31):

“And Jacob called the name of the place Peniel: for I have seen God face to face (*פָּנֶיךָ לְפָנֶיךָ*), and my life is preserved.” — Genesis 32:30 (KJV)

Jacob’s wrestling encounter. The experience is life-threatening — seeing God “face to face” is not casually accessible. He survives, and the encounter transforms him (he walks with a limp; he receives a new name).

Exodus 33:11:

“And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face (*פָּנֶיךָ לְפָנֶיךָ*), as a man speaketh unto his friend.” — Exodus 33:11 (KJV)

The defining characterization of Moses’s unique prophetic relationship with God. “As a man speaketh unto his friend” — the intimacy of friendship, not the terror of theophany. This is the relational ideal.

Numbers 12:8:

“With him will I speak mouth to mouth (*פֶּה לְפֶה*), even apparently, and not in dark speeches (*תְּדִיחַ*): and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold.” — Numbers 12:8 (KJV)

God’s own definition of Moses’s uniqueness. Three elements: (1) mouth to mouth, (2) apparently (visibly, clearly), (3) not in riddles. All three contrast with every other prophet’s mode of receiving revelation (dreams, visions, riddles — Num 12:6).

Deuteronomy 34:10:

“And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face (*פָּנֶיךָ לְפָנֶיךָ*).” — Deuteronomy 34:10 (KJV)

The eulogy for Moses at the close of the Torah. His “face to face” relationship is cited as the defining mark of his uniqueness. No other prophet reached this level.

Paul’s construction vs. the LXX

The LXX renders the idiom with several constructions: *πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* in Genesis 32:30 (LXX/MT 32:31) and Judges 6:22; *πρόσωπον κατὰ πρόσωπον* in Deuteronomy 5:4 and 34:10; *ἐνώπιος ἐνωπίω* in Exodus 33:11; and *στόμα κατὰ στόμα* (“mouth to mouth”) in Numbers 12:8. Paul’s *πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* coincides exactly with the Genesis/Judges form — he is not coining a variant but writing squarely inside the Septuagint’s theophany vocabulary.

The democratization of the Mosaic privilege

The theological weight of this allusion is considerable. The “face to face” experience was:
- Jacob’s terrifying once-in-a-lifetime encounter - Moses’s unique ongoing relationship

— explicitly denied to all other prophets - Deuteronomy 34:10's declaration that *no one after Moses* had this

Paul promises that “then” — when “the perfect” comes — *all* believers will see face to face. Every member of the eschatological community will have what was Moses's exclusive privilege. This is not merely “better knowledge” — it is the democratization of the highest communion with God available in the Old Testament.

Cross-references

- **1 John 3:2:** “Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.” The same “not yet / then” pattern; the face-to-face vision is associated with Christ's appearing.
- **Revelation 22:4:** “And they shall see his face (τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ ὄψονται); and his name shall be in their foreheads.” The eschatological consummation includes direct vision of God's face — language drawn from the same OT tradition.
- **Matthew 18:10:** “Take heed that ye despise not one of these little ones; for I say unto you, That in heaven their angels do always behold the face (πρόσωπον) of my Father which is in heaven.” Continuous access to the divine face.

Significance for the study: “Face to face” is not a loose metaphor for “better understanding.” It carries the full weight of the OT Moses tradition: direct, unmediated, unriddled communion with God. Any interpretation of τὸ τέλειον must be capable of delivering this. The completion of a written canon, however valuable, does not in itself constitute “face to face” encounter with God. The eschatological and resurrection-oriented readings bear more naturally on what “face to face” means in the OT background Paul is invoking.

Know Fully — *epiginōskō* (Strong's G1921) vs. Know — *ginōskō* (Strong's G1097)

Greek: ἐπιγινώσκω / γινώσκω **Root meaning:** γινώσκω: general knowledge, perception, recognition, understanding. ἐπιγινώσκω: the same verb with the prefix ἐπί (upon, over, intensifying) — knowledge that is thorough, complete, full. (The intensification argument in 13:12 rests on Paul's deliberate switch inside that verse, not on any claim that the compound always carries the fuller sense — see the simplex usage in 1 Cor 8:2-3 and Gal 4:9 below.) **Semantic range:** - γινώσκω: to know; to perceive; to understand; to recognize; to come to know. Very broad. ~220 NT occurrences. - ἐπιγινώσκω: to know fully; to recognize completely; to know through and through; to know in the sense of identifying precisely. ~44 NT occurrences.

The verb shift in 1 Corinthians 13:12

The shift within a single verse is deliberate and precise:

ἄρτι γινώσκω ἐκ μέρους, τότε δὲ ἐπιγινώσομαι καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην. “Now I know in part; but then shall I know fully (ἐπιγινώσομαι) even as also I am fully known (ἐπεγνώσθην).” — 1 Corinthians 13:12 (KJV, with Greek forms noted)

Three stages in a single sentence:

1. **ἄρτι γινώσκω ἐκ μέρους** — “now I know partially” (simple verb, present tense, qualified by ἐκ μέρους)
2. **τότε ἐπιγνώσομαι** — “then I will know fully” (intensive verb, future tense, no qualification)
3. **καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην** — “even as I am fully known” (intensive verb, aorist passive — God’s thorough knowing of me is the *standard* and *model* for my future full knowing)

BDAG definitions

γινώσκω (BDAG p. 199-201): “to arrive at a knowledge of someone or something, know.” The most basic term for cognitive grasp of something or someone.

ἐπιγινώσκω (BDAG p. 368-369): “to know exactly, completely, through and through.” The ἐπί prefix intensifies: the same act of knowing, but pursued to completion.

The passive: “as I am fully known”

The phrase καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην (“even as I am known”) is critical. The passive voice means *someone else* does the knowing: God knows Paul fully. God’s knowledge of the believer is: - Already complete (aorist tense — a completed action) - Fully thorough (ἐπιγινώσκω)

Our future full knowing will be patterned on (καθὼς — “even as, just as”) God’s present full knowing of us. This does not mean we will become omniscient — God’s knowledge is infinite, ours will remain creaturely. The comparison is in *kind*, not *degree*: we will know with the same thoroughness and directness that characterizes God’s knowledge of us. The indirection, the “in part,” the enigma will be gone.

Usage in key passages (epiginōskō)

γινώσκω: - **John 17:3:** “And this is life eternal, that they might know thee (γινώσκωσιν) the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent.” Eternal life defined as knowing God. - **1 Corinthians 8:2-3:** “And if any man think that he knoweth any thing, he knoweth nothing yet as he ought to know. But if any man love God, the same is known (ἐγνώσται) of him.” Every knowing-verb in these verses is the simplex γινώσκω (ἐγνώκειναι, ἔγνω, γινώσκειν, ἐγνώσται) — a caution, from three chapters before our passage, against overloading the ἐπι- prefix: Paul can express even God’s knowing of us with the simplex. - **Galatians 4:9:** “But now, after that ye have known (γινόντες) God, or rather are known (γνωσθέντες) of God...” Again both verbs are the simplex γινώσκω — Paul renders “known of God,” his most intimate knowing-claim, without the compound. The ἐπι- intensification argument in 13:12 therefore rests on the deliberate switch *within that verse*, supported by the genuine simplex/compound contrasts elsewhere (Matt. 11:27’s exclusive-knowledge saying uses the compound ἐπιγινώσκει; cf. Rom. 1:32; Col. 1:6), not on any claim that the compound always carries the fuller sense.

ἐπιγινώσκω: - **Matthew 11:27:** “...neither knoweth any man the Father, save the Son, and he to whomsoever the Son will reveal him.” The kind of knowing Jesus has of the Father — full, mutual, complete — is what Jesus gives to others. - **Romans 1:32:**

“Who knowing (ἐπιγινόντες) the judgment of God, that they which commit such things are worthy of death.” Full recognition of God’s standard. - **Colossians 1:6**: “...and knew (ἐπέγνωτε) the grace of God in truth.” Full, genuine knowledge of grace.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:12 (epiginōskō)

Translation	γινώσκω	ἐπιγινώσσομαι	Notes
KJV	“I know”	“I know”	Flattens the contrast; verb shift invisible
ESV	“I know”	“I will know fully”	Captures the shift
NASB (2020)	“I know”	“I will know fully”	Same
NIV	“I know”	“I shall know fully”	Same
LSB	“I know”	“I will know fully”	Same

The KJV does not distinguish the two verbs. Modern translations (ESV, NASB, NIV, LSB) render ἐπιγινώσκω as “know fully,” which is correct. A reader of only the KJV sees “I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known” — the verb shift is invisible.

Significance for the study: The two-verb construction is one of the clearest signals in the passage that Paul envisions a *qualitative leap* in knowing, not merely a quantitative increase. Present knowing is real but partial (γινώσκω + ἐκ μέρους). Future knowing will be thorough and direct (ἐπιγινώσκω), patterned on God’s thorough knowing of us. This full knowing is not currently available in any degree — it is reserved for “then,” when “the perfect” comes.

In Part, Partially — *ek merous*

Greek: ἐκ μέρους **Root meaning:** From ἐκ (from, out of) + μέρος (G3313: part, portion, share). Literally “out of a part” — deriving from or constituting only a portion of the whole. **Semantic range:** In part; partially; to some degree; incompletely. μέρος itself can mean a part of a whole, a portion, a share, a piece, a side, a region.

Occurrences in 1 Corinthians 13

The phrase appears five times in the passage, creating a structural rhythm:

- **v.9:** “For we know *in part* (ἐκ μέρους), and we prophesy *in part* (ἐκ μέρους).”
- **v.10:** “But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is *in part* (τὸ ἐκ μέρους) shall be done away.”
- **v.12:** “Now I know *in part* (ἐκ μέρους).”

The phrase τὸ ἐκ μέρους in v.10 is the direct antithesis of τὸ τέλειον. The structure is elegant and deliberate:

Term	Meaning	Status
τὸ ἐκ μέρους	“that which is partial”	Present — will be superseded
τὸ τέλειον	“that which is perfect/complete”	Future — will supersede

What “in part” does and does not mean

What it does mean: - Our present knowledge is incomplete. It does not encompass the whole. - Our present prophetic word is partial. No single prophecy or prophet delivers the full picture. - The gifts, however genuine and Spirit-given, are partial instruments.

What it does NOT mean: - That present knowledge is false or illusory. A puzzle piece is genuinely part of the picture, even if you cannot see the whole from it alone. The partial is real; it is simply not complete. - That the gifts are defective or sub-standard. They are partial because the *situation* is partial — we live between the ages, knowing in part because we have not yet arrived at “the perfect.”

Translation comparison (ek)

Translation	Rendering	Notes
KJV	“in part”	Literal and accurate
ESV	“in part”	Same
NASB (2020)	“in part”	Same
NIV	“in part”	Same
LSB	“in part”	Same

Unusual uniformity — all translations agree here.

Significance for the study: The ἐκ μέρους / τέλειον antithesis is the interpretive spine of the passage. Whatever “the perfect” is, it must be the *completion* of what is currently partial — not merely more of the same, but the whole of which our current state is a fragment. This argues against any interpretation that sees “the perfect” as a qualitative extension of present experience. It must be categorically different: what a complete picture is to a single piece.

Related: Hebrews 1:1. The adverb πολυμερῶς (“at sundry times,” lit. “in many parts”) in Hebrews 1:1 is built on the same μέρος and describes revelation delivered in installments — superseded, Hebrews says, by God’s speaking in his Son. Canon-view advocates read Paul’s ἐκ μέρους/τέλειον antithesis as the same movement (see Chapter 4, View 1, argument 8, with the reply: the Hebrews contrast is prophets-versus-Son, and the Son is the one still awaited face to face).

But Now — *nyni de* (13:13)

Greek: νυνὶ δέ **Root meaning:** νῦν (now) with an emphatic iota suffix: νυνί. The particle δέ is adversative/transitional: “but,” “however,” “and.” **Semantic range:** This two-word phrase carries significant interpretive weight, because it can be read two ways.

The two readings

Reading 1 — Temporal: “But now, at the present time, faith, hope, and love remain.” Under this reading, *νυνὶ δέ* marks the present age: in contrast to what has just been described (the partial giving way to the perfect), at the present moment these three abide.

Reading 2 — Logical: “But as things stand / in the last analysis, faith, hope, and love are the permanent realities.” Under this reading, *νυνὶ* is not strictly temporal but argumentative — it draws a logical conclusion: “given everything said above, the upshot is this.”

Which reading fits?

Paul uses *νυνὶ δέ* in both senses elsewhere: - **Temporal uses:** Romans 6:22, Romans 7:6, Ephesians 2:13 — “but now” marking a transition from a prior state. - **Logical uses:** Romans 3:21, 1 Corinthians 15:20 — “but as it is” drawing a conclusion.

In 1 Corinthians 13:13, most commentators favor the *logical* reading for two reasons:

1. If *νυνὶ* is temporal (“at present”), then faith, hope, and love “remain” *until* the perfect comes — implying they will eventually cease too. But Paul’s whole argument is that love *never* fails (v.8: ἡ ἀγάπη οὐδέποτε πίπτει). A temporal reading creates tension with v.8.
2. The logical reading (“as things stand in the grand scheme”) allows faith, hope, and love to be permanent in a way the gifts are not. The gifts are partial and temporary; the three are abiding.

The “remaining” of faith and hope

Here the temporal reading offers a pointed argument in the opposite direction: if *νυνὶ* is temporal, then faith and hope “remain” only in the present age — when “the perfect” comes, faith gives way to sight (2 Cor 5:7: “For we walk by faith, not by sight”) and hope gives way to reality (Rom 8:24: “For we are saved by hope: but hope that is seen is not hope”). On this reading, “the perfect” must be the eschaton, because that is the only moment when faith becomes sight and hope becomes possession. The temporal reading actually strengthens the eschatological interpretation of τὸ τέλειον.

Translation comparison: 1 Corinthians 13:13 (nyni)

Translation	Rendering	Notes
KJV	“And now abideth”	“And now” is mildly temporal
ESV	“So now faith, hope, and love abide”	“So” captures the logical/conclusive sense
NASB (2020)	“But now faith, hope, and love remain”	“But now” is ambiguous (NASB95 read “abide”)
NIV	“And now these three remain”	Neutral

Translation	Rendering	Notes
LSB	"But now abide faith, hope, love"	Verb-first; retains the NASB95 "abide" tradition

Significance for the study: The temporal reading of *ἡμεῖς* δέ produces a significant argument for eschatological interpretation: if faith and hope "remain" only until "the perfect," then "the perfect" must be the moment when faith becomes sight and hope becomes reality — the resurrection or the eternal state. This is a legitimate and often under-noticed argument from within the immediate context. The logical reading is grammatically defensible but removes this argument. Either reading is possible; the interpreter must be transparent about which choice is being made.

Summary (Word Study)

The word study reveals that Paul's language in 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 is both technically precise and deeply rooted in OT theology, especially the Moses tradition. Six findings stand out:

1. τὸ τέλειον is neuter. The grammatical form suggests a state or condition rather than a specific person. Interpreters who identify "the perfect" with Christ must explain why Paul used the neuter rather than the expected masculine if he had a person in mind.

2. The middle voice of παύσονται is debated but not decisive. The cessationist argument from the middle voice is a genuine grammatical observation: tongues "will cease" may carry a self-cessation nuance not present in the passive constructions for prophecy and knowledge. But the counterargument — that this is Pauline stylistic variation using a naturally middle-tending verb — is equally grounded. The grammar opens a question; it does not answer it.

3. The mirror metaphor is grounded in Corinthian material culture. Paul's audience knew exactly what bronze mirrors were: recognizable but imperfect. The metaphor establishes that present knowledge is *real but indirect* — not false, not adequate.

4. The αἰνιγμα / "face to face" language deliberately echoes Numbers 12:8. Paul is not using "riddle" and "face to face" as loose metaphors. He is invoking the specific OT tradition in which Moses uniquely enjoyed direct, unriddled communion with God — and promising that all believers will have this when "the perfect" comes. Whatever "the perfect" is, it must be something capable of delivering the Moses-level encounter.

5. The two different verbs for knowing signal a qualitative leap. The shift from γινώσκω (simple knowing, present, partial) to ἐπιγινώσκω (full knowing, future, thorough) is not stylistic variation. It is a deliberate escalation. The passive "as I am fully known" establishes that God's knowing of us is both the *pattern* and *standard* for our future knowing.

6. The permanence of faith, hope, and love (v.13) points toward the eschaton — on the temporal reading of ἡμεῖς δέ, a live minority option. If *ἡμεῖς δέ* is temporal

(“now, at present”), then faith and hope “remain” only until “the perfect” comes. Faith is replaced by sight, hope by reality (2 Cor 5:7; Rom 8:24). This implies “the perfect” must be the moment of consummation — resurrection or the eternal state — when faith and hope are no longer needed because their objects have arrived.

Together, these six findings create a cumulative case that “the perfect” in 1 Corinthians 13:10 points toward the eschatological consummation rather than any event within history — while remaining honest that word studies alone do not constitute a proof. The grammar and vocabulary consistently *favor* the eschatological reading, but the interpretive question ultimately turns on how the entire passage fits within Paul’s theology of the present and coming age.

Bibliography

Source	Details
BDAG	Bauer, Danker, Arndt, Gingrich. <i>A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature</i> , 3rd ed. University of Chicago Press, 2000.
Liddell-Scott (LSJ)	Liddell, H.G. and Scott, R. <i>A Greek-English Lexicon</i> . Clarendon Press, 1996.
Thayer	Thayer, Joseph. <i>Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament</i> . Baker, 1977.
Spicq	Spicq, Ceslas. <i>Theological Lexicon of the New Testament</i> . 3 vols. Hendrickson, 1994.
TDNT	Kittel, Gerhard, ed. <i>Theological Dictionary of the New Testament</i> . Eerdmans, 1964–1976.
Pliny LXX	<i>Natural History</i> 34.6–8. On Corinthian bronze. Rahlfs, Alfred, ed. <i>Septuaginta</i> . Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1935.
Gaffin	Gaffin, Richard B. <i>Perspectives on Pentecost</i> . Presbyterian and Reformed, 1979. (Redemptive-historical cessationism from Eph. 2:20; explicitly does not rest on παύσονται or on reading τὸ τέλειον as the canon.)
Carson	Carson, D.A. <i>Showing the Spirit: A Theological Exposition of 1 Corinthians 12–14</i> . Baker, 1987. (Continuationist reply.)
Fee	Fee, Gordon D. <i>The First Epistle to the Corinthians</i> . NICNT. Eerdmans, 1987.
Thomas	Thomas, Robert L. “Tongues...Will Cease.” <i>Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society</i> 17 (1974): 81–89. (Maturity/Body view of τὸ τέλειον; middle-voice point advanced tentatively.)
Edwards	Edwards, Jonathan. <i>Charity and Its Fruits</i> . 1852 (posthumous; preached 1738). (Reads “the perfect” as heaven in the final lecture; ties gift-cessation to the canon’s completion elsewhere in the same work.)

Source	Details
Warfield	Warfield, B.B. <i>Counterfeit Miracles</i> . 1918. (The classic scholarly cessationist case; never cites 1 Cor 13:10.)
Calvin	Calvin, John. <i>Commentary on the Epistles of Paul the Apostle to the Corinthians</i> , vol. 1. Calvin Translation Society, 1848. (On 13:10: perfection begins at death, “not completely manifested until the day of judgment.”)
Hodge	Hodge, Charles. <i>An Exposition of the First Epistle to the Corinthians</i> . 1857. (Eschatological on v. 10.)
Robertson-Plummer	Robertson, Archibald, and Alfred Plummer. <i>A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the First Epistle of St Paul to the Corinthians</i> . ICC, 2nd ed. T&T Clark, 1914. (Eschatological.)
Godet	Godet, Frédéric. <i>Commentary on St. Paul’s First Epistle to the Corinthians</i> . 1889. (Eschatological.)
Decker	Decker, Rodney J. “A History of Interpretation of ‘That Which Is Perfect’ (1 Cor 13:10) with Special Attention to the Origin of the ‘Canon View.’” Paper, 1994. (Traces the view’s origin to the modern period; the earliest known 19th-century mention, Robert Govett, reports the view only to refute it — see Chapter 0.)
White	White, R. Fowler. “Richard Gaffin and Wayne Grudem on 1 Cor 13:10: A Comparison of Cessationist and Noncessationist Argumentation.” <i>Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society</i> 35/2 (1992): 173–181.
Toussaint	Toussaint, Stanley D. “First Corinthians Thirteen and the Tongues Question.” <i>Bibliotheca Sacra</i> 120 (October-December 1963): 311–16. (Eschatological τὸ τέλειον with early tongues-cessation via the middle voice; position verified via Gromacki’s digest, pp. 127–28; original obtained via Galaxie, Primary-Sources.)
Compton	Compton, R. Bruce. “1 Corinthians 13:8–13 and the Cessation of Miraculous Gifts.” <i>Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal</i> 9 (2004): 97–144. (Canon-view ADVOCATE — “to defend... that ‘the perfect’ in 13:10 refers to the completed New Testament canon” — not a neutral survey; the tradition’s most extensive scholarly defense. Original obtained via Galaxie; Primary-Sources.)
Compton-2020	Compton, R. Bruce. “First Corinthians 13 and the Cessation of Miraculous Gifts: A Critique of Thomas Schreiner’s <i>Spiritual Gifts</i> .” <i>Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal</i> 25 (2020): 25–49. (The most recent scholarly defense of the canon reading; source of the Schreiner-imminence exchange in Chapter 4. Original obtained via Galaxie; Primary-Sources.)

Source	Details
McDougall	McDougall, Donald G. "Cessationism in 1 Cor 13:8-12." <i>The Master's Seminary Journal</i> 14/2 (2003): 177-213. (Survey of positions.)
Gromacki	Gromacki, Robert. <i>The Modern Tongues Movement</i> . Presbyterian and Reformed, 1967. (Canon-view survey and advocacy; quotes Weaver's 1964 quantitative-parallelism argument, pp. 126-27; digests Toussaint, pp. 127-28. Verified via archive.org lending.)
Unger	Unger, Merrill F. <i>New Testament Teaching on Tongues</i> . Kregel, 1971. (Canon-view advocate; see p. 97.)
Smith	Smith, Charles R. <i>Tongues in Biblical Perspective</i> . BMH, 1972. (Canon-view advocate; see p. 79.)
MacArthur	MacArthur, John. <i>1 Corinthians</i> . MacArthur New Testament Commentary. Moody, 1984. (Cessationist; reads "the perfect" as the eternal state and rejects the canon view.)
Aquinas	Thomas Aquinas. <i>Super I Epistolam ad Corinthios</i> , cap. 13 (Reportatio Vulgata; Latin text at corpusthomisticum.org). ("The perfect" = <i>perfectio gloriae</i> ; face-to-face vision in patria.)
Owen	Owen, John. <i>Pneumatologia: A Discourse Concerning the Holy Spirit</i> . 1674. (Grounds the gifts' cessation in the close of the extraordinary offices.)
Vine	Vine, W. E. <i>1 Corinthians</i> . London: Oliphants, 1951. (Canon-view advocate, p. 184, verified against the 1961 printing via archive.org lending; the same page adds the Parousia as a second horizon, and his v. 12 note cites Num. 12:8 on the enigma.)
Woods	Woods, Andy M. "The Meaning of 'the Perfect' in 1 Corinthians 13:8-13." <i>CTS Journal</i> 10/2 (Fall 2004); posted at spiritandtruth.org (© 2012). (The fullest modern published defense of the canon reading — an explicit advocate, not a neutral survey; engaged throughout Chapter 4, View 1. Also documents Vine's advocacy. Read in full from the spiritandtruth.org PDF; copy in Primary-Sources.)
Ruthven	Ruthven, Jon. <i>On the Cessation of the Charismata: The Protestant Polemic on Post-Biblical Miracles</i> . Sheffield Academic Press, 1993. (The standard historical monograph on the cessationist polemic.)
Shogren	Shogren, Gary S. "How Did They Suppose 'the Perfect' Would Come? 1 Corinthians 13.8-12 in Patristic Exegesis." <i>Journal of Pentecostal Theology</i> 15 (1999): 99-121. (Independent survey of the patristic exegesis of this passage; corroborates the no-canon-reading finding.)

Source	Details
Shogren-JETS	Shogren, Gary S. "Christian Prophecy and Canon in the Second Century: A Response to B.B. Warfield." <i>Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society</i> 40/4 (1997): 609–26. (Second-century prophecy and the canon; cited in his JPT survey.)
Houghton	Houghton, Myron J. "A Reexamination of 1 Corinthians 13:8-13." <i>Bibliotheca Sacra</i> 153/611 (July 1996): 344–56. (Canon-view advocate — "this writer's 'completed canon' view"; his "know as known" tu quoque, n. 27, is engaged in Chapter 4. Original obtained via Galaxie — PDF and text in Primary-Sources; quotation verified verbatim.)
Gentry	Gentry, Kenneth L., Jr. <i>The Charismatic Gift of Prophecy: A Reformed Response to Wayne Grudem</i> . 2d ed. Memphis: Footstool, 1989. (Reformed postmillennialist advocate of the canon reading — the notable Reformed-Presbyterian exception, per Chapter 4's expanded "Held By" list which now records other non-dispensational advocates including Chantry, Budgen, and Judisch; his mirror-as-self-sight exegesis, pp. 55–57, is engaged in Chapter 4. Quoted via Woods.)
Dean	Dean, Robert, Jr. "Three Arguments for the Cessation of Tongues." Paper, Conservative Theological Society, Fort Worth, TX, 2002; later printed in the <i>Conservative Theological Journal</i> 9:26 (March 2005). (Canon-view advocate; source of the open-canon consequence argument. Author's text obtained — Primary-Sources — and all quotations adopted via Woods verified against it.)
White-WTJ	White, R. Fowler. "Gaffin and Grudem on Eph 2:20: In Defense of Gaffin's Cessationist Exegesis." <i>Westminster Theological Journal</i> 54 (1992): 321–330.
Schreiner	Schreiner, Thomas R. <i>Spiritual Gifts: What They Are and Why They Matter</i> . B&H, 2018. (Nuanced cessationist; reads "the perfect" as the second coming; rejects the canon view.)

Appendix B: Early Church and Patristic Sources

This appendix collects all patristic and early church sources cited in Chapter 3 into a single chronological reference. It is designed to be consulted independently — readers need not search through Chapter 3 to locate a quotation or trace a citation. Sources are arranged in the order in which they appear historically, grouped by era.

A note on translations and honesty: Where a quotation is a direct translation from the ANF or NPNF, this is noted. Where Chapter 3 presents a paraphrase, summary of an argument, or author's rendering rather than a published translation, this appendix says so plainly. Patristic primary texts are cited by their standard reference systems:

PG = Patrologia Graeca (Migne); PL = Patrologia Latina (Migne); ANF = Ante-Nicene Fathers (Roberts-Donaldson); NPNF = Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (Schaff).

Apostolic Era (c. 70–150 AD)

Didache (“Teaching of the Twelve Apostles”), Ch. 16 (c. 70–100 AD)

Context: The *Didache* is one of the earliest surviving Christian documents outside the New Testament, probably originating in Syria. It functions as a church manual covering baptism, fasting, prayer, the Eucharist, and eschatological watchfulness. Chapter 16 is an urgent call to readiness for the Lord’s coming. The document does not interpret 1 Corinthians 13:10 directly; its significance here is the use of *teleioō* (the verbal cognate of *teleios*, the root of “the perfect” in 1 Cor 13:10) in an explicitly eschatological context.

Source: ANF Vol. 7, p. 382 (M. B. Riddle translation; Roberts and Donaldson are the series editors, but the *Didache* — a late addition to the series after its 1873 rediscovery — was translated by Riddle). Greek text in Schaff, *Teaching of the Twelve Apostles* (1885). The *Didache* is not in the Patrologia Graeca.

“Watch for your life’s sake. Let not your lamps be quenched, nor your loins unloosed; but be ready, for you know not the hour in which our Lord comes. But often shall you come together, seeking the things which are befitting to your souls: for the whole time of your faith will not profit you, if you be not made perfect in the last time.” — Didache 16:1-2 (M. B. Riddle translation, ANF Vol. 7)

This is a direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 7.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: The *Didache* does not interpret the verse directly. Its significance is that it uses *teleioō* (“be made perfect / be completed”) in explicit connection with “the last time” (*en tō eschatō kairō*) — the same semantic field from which Paul’s *to teleion* is drawn. Completion belongs to the eschatological horizon, not to any present achievement.

Clement of Rome, *First Letter to the Corinthians* (1 Clement), Chs. 49–50 (c. 96 AD)

Context: Clement of Rome wrote to the fractious church at Corinth around 96 AD — the same congregation Paul had addressed decades earlier. His letter is the earliest surviving post-apostolic Christian document outside the *Didache*. Chapters 49–50 contain an extended meditation on love saturated in the vocabulary of 1 Corinthians 13, though Clement does not quote the chapter explicitly or interpret verse 10 directly.

Source: ANF Vol. 1, pp. 18–19 (Roberts-Donaldson translation). Critical text in Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers* Part I, Vol. 2; also in PG 1.

“Let him who has love in Christ keep the commandments of Christ. Who can describe the [blessed] bond of the love of God? What man is able to tell the excellence of its beauty, as it ought to be told? The height to which love exalts

is unspeakable. Love unites us to God. Love covers a multitude of sins. Love bears all things, is long-suffering in all things. There is nothing base, nothing arrogant in love. Love admits of no schisms: love gives rise to no seditions: love does all things in harmony. By love have all the elect of God been made perfect; without love nothing is well-pleasing to God.” — 1 Clement 49:1-5 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

“Blessed are we, beloved, if we keep the commandments of God in the harmony of love; that so through love our sins may be forgiven us.” — 1 Clement 50 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

Both quotations are direct translations as they appear in ANF Vol. 1. The phrase “by love have all the elect of God been made perfect” uses eteleiōthēsan — the same root as teleios in 1 Cor 13:10.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Clement does not interpret the verse directly. His significance is that he writes in 1 Corinthians 13’s conceptual vocabulary (“love bears all things” parallels “charity beareth all things,” 1 Cor 13:7 — though the Greek verbs are Clement’s own, not Paul’s; see Chapter 3) and links *teleioō* with love as the instrument of final completion — a completion Clement does not confine to the present age.

Ignatius of Antioch, Letter to the Ephesians, Ch. 14 (c. 107 AD)

Context: Ignatius, bishop of Antioch, wrote seven letters while under military escort to Rome for execution, probably during Trajan’s reign (98–117 AD). He is the first post-apostolic writer to quote Paul’s letters with regularity. He does not interpret 1 Corinthians 13:10 directly, but his *telos*-language in the letter to the Ephesians places love within the same conceptual framework as Paul’s argument.

Source: ANF Vol. 1, p. 57 (Roberts-Donaldson translation). Critical text in Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers Part II*, Vol. 2; also in PG 5.

“None of these things is hid from you, if you perfectly possess that faith and love towards Christ Jesus which are the beginning and the end of life. For the beginning is faith, and the end is love.” — Ignatius, *To the Ephesians* 14:1 (Roberts-Donaldson translation, ANF Vol. 1)

Direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 1. The key Greek phrase is ἀρχὴ μὲν πίστις, τέλος δὲ ἀγάπη — “beginning is faith, end/completion (telos) is love.”

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Ignatius does not interpret the verse. His significance is conceptual: he maps Paul’s movement from faith (present, partial) to love (the *telos*, the completion) using the identical root word. His framework aligns with Paul’s own argument that love is the eschatological completion toward which all present gifts are oriented.

Ante-Nicene Era (c. 150–325 AD)

Irenaeus of Lyon, *Against Heresies* (*Adversus Haereses*), 2.28.3 (c. 180 AD)

Context: Irenaeus (c. 130–202 AD), bishop of Lyon, was a disciple of Polycarp, who was himself a disciple of John. His major work, *Against Heresies* (written c. 180 AD), is a sustained refutation of Gnostic systems that claimed superior, complete, hidden knowledge. Book 2, chapter 28, argues that human beings cannot comprehend God’s full purposes and that intellectual humility is the proper Christian posture. Irenaeus grounds this argument in Paul’s statement that we know “in part”: the Gnostics’ claim to complete present knowledge is precisely what Paul denies.

Source: ANF Vol. 1, p. 401 (Roberts-Rambaut translation). The original Greek of *Against Heresies* is largely lost; we have an anonymous ancient Latin version and (for Books 4-5) Armenian fragments. Text with surviving Greek fragments in PG 7. Critical edition: Harvey, *Sancti Irenaei Libros Quinque Adversus Haereses* (1857).

“If, therefore, even with respect to creation, there are some things [the knowledge of] which belongs only to God, and others which come within the range of our own knowledge, what ground is there for complaint, if, in regard to those things which we investigate in the Scriptures (which are throughout spiritual), we are able by the grace of God to explain some of them, while we must leave others in the hands of God, and that not only in the present world, but also in that which is to come, so that God should for ever teach, and man should for ever learn the things taught him by God? As the apostle has said on this point, that, when other things have been done away, then these three, faith, hope, and charity, shall endure.” — Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 2.28.3 (Roberts-Rambaut translation, ANF Vol. 1, p. 401)

Direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 1, p. 401. Irenaeus’s surrounding argument explicitly invokes the “in part / when that which is perfect is come” logic of 1 Corinthians 13:9-10, though he summarizes it rather than quoting it verbatim at this point. The phrase “not only in the present world, but also in that which is to come” is his own inference from Paul’s partial/perfect distinction.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Complete knowledge belongs to the age to come, not the present age. Irenaeus uses this to counter Gnostic claims of present complete knowledge. The “perfect” is what awaits believers in the future divine presence. Note: Irenaeus lived during the period when the New Testament canon was still being assembled. He does not connect “the perfect” with the completion of Scripture — the very category did not exist in his time.

Irenaeus of Lyon, *Against Heresies*, 5.6.1 (c. 180 AD)

Context: Book 5 of *Against Heresies* addresses resurrection, eschatology, and the nature of the complete resurrected human being. The passage uses *teleios* to describe the fully restored person in the age to come — illustrating how Irenaeus understands the word-family throughout his work.

Source: ANF Vol. 1, p. 531 (Roberts-Rambaut translation). Text in PG 7.

“Now the soul and the spirit are certainly a part of the man, but certainly not the man; for the perfect man consists in the commingling and the union of the soul receiving the spirit of the Father, and the admixture of that fleshly

nature which was moulded after the image of God.” — Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 5.6.1 (Roberts-Rambaut translation, ANF Vol. 1, p. 531)

Direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 1, p. 531. Here teleios (“perfect man”) denotes the complete, resurrected human being.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Irenaeus does not directly apply this passage to 1 Cor 13:10, but his usage of *teleios* here shows that for him the word consistently points forward to the resurrection state — the fully restored human person — not to any present spiritual achievement or textual completion.

Clement of Alexandria, *Stromata* 7.10 and *Paedagogus* 1.6 (c. 195–215 AD)

Context: Titus Flavius Clemens (not Clement of Rome), head of the Catechetical School of Alexandria, wrote the *Stromata* as a sprawling collection of theological reflections synthesizing Christian faith with Greek philosophy. Clement developed the concept of the “true Gnostic” — the mature Christian believer who has progressed from simple faith to deeper knowledge through virtue and contemplation. He is the earliest advocate for the “maturity” reading of *to teleion* — but his direct handling of verses 11-12 places the face-to-face vision in the future world, complicating the classification.

Source: ANF Vol. 2 (William Wilson translation). Greek text in PG 8, cols. 247–684 (*Paedagogus*) and PG 9, cols. 9–602 (*Stromata* Books 5–8; Books 7–8 at cols. 401–558; *Stromata* Books 1–4 follow the *Paedagogus* in PG 8, cols. 685–1382). The two loci verified for this study are *Stromata* 7.10.57 (PG 9, col. 473) for the general partial-to-mature framework, and *Paedagogus* 1.6 (PG 8; ANF Vol. 2) for the direct handling of 1 Cor 13:11-12.

Critical caution: The ANF Vol. 2 translation of Clement is well known to contain substantial paraphrase and condensation rather than strict translation of the Greek. No verbatim quotation of Clement on 1 Corinthians 13:10 is offered here, because the ANF rendering is itself unreliable as a verbatim translation. Readers wishing to verify Clement’s exact wording should consult PG 8 (*Paedagogus*) and PG 9 (*Stromata*) directly. What follows is a faithful representation of his argument.

Stromata 7.10.57 (PG 9, col. 473): Clement argues that faith is the foundation and knowledge (*gnosis*) is what is built upon it — a progression from partial to more complete apprehension of divine truth available in this life through growth in virtue and contemplation. This general framework is the seedbed of his maturity reading; it is not itself a direct exegesis of 1 Corinthians 13:10.

Paedagogus 1.6 (ANF Vol. 2): Clement’s direct handling of 1 Corinthians 13:11-12. He reads “when I was a child” as Paul’s life under the law (“when I was a Jew... I thought as a child, when I followed the law; but after becoming a man, I no longer entertain the sentiments of a child”) — a salvation-historical rather than developmental reading of verse 11. And on verse 12 Clement himself writes that the “meat” the Corinthians could not yet bear “may indicate the clear revelation in the future world, like food, face to face. For now we see as through a glass, the same apostle says, but then face to face.” Even the tradition’s one maturity-reader, when he handles verse 12 directly, places the face-to-face in the future world.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Clement reads *to teleion* as the mature spiritual knowledge available to the dedicated believer in this life through progressive growth

from faith to gnosis — shaped by Platonic philosophical inheritance and an apologetic project of demonstrating Christianity’s intellectual respectability. He is the earliest and, in the pre-Nicene period, the only witness to the “maturity” interpretation of *to teleion*. But his classification is more complicated than it first appears: his direct exegesis of verse 12 in *Paedagogus* 1.6 remains eschatological. His maturity reading concerns the believer’s *present* growth in *gnosis*; the face-to-face vision he assigns to the future world.

The Anonymous Anti-Montanist, in Eusebius, *Church History* 5.17.4 (c. 192/193 AD)

Context: An unnamed churchman answering the Montanist “New Prophecy,” writing about the fourteenth year after the death of the prophetess Maximilla (early 190s). His is the earliest datable exegesis of 1 Corinthians 13:8-12 in Christian literature (see Chapter 3).

Source: Eusebius, *Church History* 5.17.4 (McGiffert translation, NPNF Series 2, Vol. 1); Greek in PG 20.

“For the apostle thought it necessary that the prophetic gift should continue in all the Church until the final coming.” — in Eusebius, *HE* 5.17.4 (McGiffert translation)

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: The prophetic gift continues “until the final coming” — the eschatological reading, at the fountainhead of the interpretive tradition, deployed *against* the era’s completed-revelation claim (Montanism) rather than derived from one.

Tertullian of Carthage, *Adversus Praxeas* (Against Praxeas), Ch. 14 (c. 208–213 AD)

Context: Quintus Septimius Florens Tertullianus (c. 155–240 AD) was the first major Latin theological writer, working from Carthage. He is notable for his Montanist sympathies in his later career — he believed in the continuation of spiritual gifts. *Against Praxeas* is his treatise on the distinction of the divine Persons. In chapter 14, arguing about the visibility of God, he sets Numbers 12:6-8 — God’s “mouth to mouth” speech with Moses, “not enigmatically” — directly beside 1 Corinthians 13:12.

Source: ANF Vol. 3 (Holmes translation), p. 609. Latin text in PL 2. Critical Latin text in CCSL 2.

“...not as with Moses, with whom I shall speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, that is to say, in truth, and not enigmatically, that is to say, in image; as the apostle also expresses it, ‘Now we see through a glass, darkly (or enigmatically), but then face to face.’ Since, therefore, He reserves to some future time His presence and speech face to face with Moses — a promise which was afterwards fulfilled in the retirement of the mount (of transfiguration), when as we read in the Gospel, Moses appeared talking with Jesus — it is evident that in early times it was always in a glass, (as it were,) and an enigma, in vision and dream, that God, I mean the Son of God, appeared

— to the prophets and the patriarchs, as also to Moses indeed himself.” —
Tertullian, *Against Praxeas* 14 (Holmes translation, ANF Vol. 3)

Direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 3 (verified against the New Advent edition of the Holmes translation).

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Tertullian does not comment on verse 10 directly, so his exact understanding of “the perfect” cannot be pinned (Decker’s history-of-interpretation survey reaches the same conclusion). What he gives us is significant on two other counts: he explicitly connects Numbers 12:6-8 with 1 Corinthians 13:12 — the Moses-and-enigma typology this study’s Chapter 1 develops — and he “reserves to some future time” the face-to-face encounter, referring it to the visible manifestation of Christ. Writing as a Montanist who believed the gifts continued in his own day, he shows no awareness of any canon-completion reading.

Origen of Alexandria, *De Principiis* (On First Principles), 2.11.3–4 (c. 225 AD)

Context: Origen (c. 185–254 AD), born in Alexandria and later based in Caesarea, was the most prolific and philosophically sophisticated of the Ante-Nicene fathers. *De Principiis* is the first systematic Christian theology. Book 2, chapter 11, discusses the afterlife, the progressive education of souls, and what awaits believers in the age to come. Origen’s commentary on 1 Corinthians survives only in fragments preserved in later catena manuscripts.

Source: ANF Vol. 4, pp. 297–298 (Frederick Crombie translation). The original Greek of *De Principiis* is largely lost; we have primarily Rufinus’s Latin translation. Greek fragments in PG 11, cols. 237–240. Critical text of Rufinus’s Latin in GCS (Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller), Origenes Werke Vol. 5.

Note on this passage: The most directly relevant material — Origen’s argument in *De Principiis* 2.11.3-4 about how partial knowledge is replaced by comprehensive understanding when believers enter God’s direct presence — is presented in Chapter 3 as the author’s summary of Origen’s argument rather than a direct quotation from a published translation. This is because the Rufinus Latin is at times an adaptation rather than a strict translation, and the Greek is fragmentary. The argument summarized is Origen’s own.

From the Commentary on 1 Corinthians (fragments in catenae): Fragments attributed to Origen on 1 Corinthians 13, preserved in the Cramer Catena on the Pauline epistles (Cramer, *Catenae Graecorum Patrum*, vol. 5; critically edited by Claude Jenkins, “Origen on I Corinthians,” *Journal of Theological Studies* 9-10 [1908-1909]), indicate that he understood the “in part” as the condition of every believer in the present age — knowledge mediated through Scripture, the Spirit, analogy, and type — and “the perfect” as direct, unmediated knowledge of God in the age to come. The attribution is generally accepted, but these fragments are not fully established critical texts. The Greek distinction that mattered to Origen was between *gnōsis ek merous* (partial knowledge) and *epignōsis* (complete, face-to-face recognition) — the very distinction Paul draws in verse 12: *tote de epignōsomai kathōs kai epegnōsthēn* (“then I shall know fully, even as I have been fully known”).

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Origen holds a “progressive eschatology” position. Knowledge grows in the present age (through the Spirit and Scripture) and continues

to grow in the age to come (through direct divine presence), but the decisive transition — when the partial is finally “done away” — is the eschatological moment of entering God’s direct presence. “The perfect” is not a present achievement but the future state of direct divine knowledge.

Methodius of Olympus, *Banquet of the Ten Virgins* (Symposium), Discourse 9.2 (c. 290–311 AD)

Context: Methodius, bishop and martyr under the last persecution, cast the *Banquet* as a Christian counterpart to Plato’s Symposium: ten virgins discourse on chastity and the resurrection hope. In Discourse 9 he sets law, church, and coming kingdom in a shadow-image-reality sequence and quotes 1 Corinthians 13 directly.

Source: ANF Vol. 6 (William R. Clark translation). Greek text in PG 18.

“For now we know in part, and as it were through a glass, since that which is perfect has not yet come to us; namely, the kingdom of heaven and the resurrection, when that which is in part shall be done away.” — Methodius, *Banquet of the Ten Virgins* 9.2 (William R. Clark translation, ANF Vol. 6)

Direct translation as it appears in ANF Vol. 6 (verified against the New Advent edition).

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: Among the most explicit identifications in the pre-Nicene tradition: Methodius supplies the referent himself — “namely, the kingdom of heaven and the resurrection” — and continues, “For then will all our tabernacles be firmly set up, when again the body shall rise.”

Post-Nicene Witness (included for reference; beyond the pre-325 primary boundary)

The SCAR framework places primary weight on pre-Nicene evidence. The following post-Nicene sources are included because they represent the most sustained and influential patristic interpretation of this specific passage, and their readings illuminate the trajectory of the tradition that began before Nicaea.

Ambrosiaster, *Commentary on 1 Corinthians*, on 13:9–12 (c. 366–384 AD)

Context: The anonymous author of the earliest complete Latin commentary on Paul (Rome, later fourth century), whose work traveled for centuries under Ambrose’s name — hence the modern coinage “Ambrosiaster.” Chapter 3’s post-Nicene section gives the fuller introduction.

Source: Latin text in PL 17 (Comment. in Epist. I ad Cor., cols. 257ff); critical edition CSEL 81. English: Charles A. Sullivan’s translation of the PL 17 text.

“It has now been revealed to see the images by faith, then the events themselves. ... That is, I will see what has been promised even as I am being seen. This is to be present near the Lord where Christ is.” — Ambrosiaster, *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 13:12 (Sullivan translation of the PL 17 text)

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: The earliest Latin commentator refers the “then” of verse 12 to the future life “near the Lord where Christ is,” pairs the passage with 1 John 3:2, and treats the gifts as “purged” when imperfection “is completed into truth.” No connection with a completed canon appears anywhere in his treatment.

John Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians*, Homily 34 (c. 390 AD)

Context: John “Chrysostom” (c. 347–407 AD), bishop of Constantinople, was the greatest preacher of antiquity. His *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* (delivered probably in Antioch before 398 AD) provide the most sustained patristic exegesis of 1 Corinthians 13 in the ancient tradition. Homily 34 covers 1 Corinthians 13:8-13 in detail and states Chrysostom’s interpretation of “the perfect” directly.

Source: NPNF Series 1, Vol. 12, pp. 196–205 (Talbot W. Chambers translation; Philip Schaff, series editor). Greek text in PG 61, cols. 285–294.

On the meaning of “the perfect” (1 Cor 13:10):

“It is not therefore knowledge that is done away, but the circumstance that our knowledge is in part. For we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more. ... But then shall we know somewhat more and clearer concerning these things.” — Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 34.2 (Chambers translation, NPNF Series 1, Vol. 12, p. 202)

On the mirror analogy (1 Cor 13:12):

“For now we see in a mirror. Further, because the glass sets before us the thing seen indefinitely, he added, darkly, to show very strongly that the present knowledge is most partial. But then face to face. Not as though God has a face, but to express the notion of greater clearness and perspicuity.” — Chrysostom, *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 34 (Chambers translation, NPNF Series 1, Vol. 12)

Both quotations are direct translations as they appear in NPNF Series 1, Vol. 12.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: “The perfect” = the complete knowledge of the age to come, when believers see God directly (Decker’s survey characterizes Chrysostom’s position the same way: complete knowledge, “which from the context of his remarks, will be when we see God”). He argues that the partial mode of knowing gives way when the complete arrives — not because a canon was completed. At the same time, Chrysostom regarded the miraculous gifts as having already ceased in his own day: “This whole place is very obscure: but the obscurity is produced by our ignorance of the facts referred to, and by their cessation, being such as then used to occur but now no longer take place” (Homily 29.1, Chambers translation, NPNF 1.12). He thus held the eschatological reading of verse 10 and a de facto cessationism together — without ever connecting the gifts’ cessation to the canon.

Augustine of Hippo, *De Trinitate* (On the Trinity), 15.8.14 and 15.23.44 (c. 399–419 AD)

Context: Augustine (c. 354–430 AD), bishop of Hippo in North Africa, wrote *De Trinitate* over roughly twenty years as his most sustained theological project — an investigation of the Trinity through the analogy of the human mind. Book 15 brings the inquiry to a conclusion by turning to 1 Corinthians 13:12 as the key text for understanding the limits of all present knowledge of God. His treatment is the most meticulous patristic analysis of what “through a mirror, in an enigma” means, and his conclusions are relevant to the question of whether “the completion of Scripture” could be what Paul means by “the perfect.”

Source: NPNF Series 1, Vol. 3, pp. 200–228 (Arthur West Haddan translation, revised by W.G.T. Shedd). Latin text in PL 42, cols. 1057–1098. Critical Latin text in CCSL 50A (Corpus Christianorum Series Latina).

On “through a mirror” and “in an enigma” (1 Cor 13:12):

“...and yet a man so great and so spiritual [as Paul] says, ‘We see now through a glass, in an enigma, but then face to face.’ If we ask what and of what sort is this glass, this assuredly occurs to our minds, that in a glass nothing is discerned but an image.” — Augustine, *De Trinitate* 15.8.14 (Haddan translation, NPNF Series 1, Vol. 3)

On the “face to face” vision:

“But when the sight shall have come which is promised anew to us face to face, we shall see this not only incorporeal but also absolutely indivisible and truly unchangeable Trinity far more clearly and certainly than we now see its image which we ourselves are.” — Augustine, *De Trinitate* 15.23.44 (Haddan translation, NPNF Series 1, Vol. 3)

Both quotations are direct translations as they appear in the Haddan translation of NPNF Series 1, Vol. 3 (verified against the New Advent edition).

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:10: “The perfect” = the beatific vision of God — “the sight... which is promised anew to us face to face” — in the life to come. Augustine’s argument is particularly significant for the question of Scripture and canon: for Augustine, Scripture itself belongs to the present age of mediated knowledge — it is part of the “mirror” through which we now see partially. Scripture mediates the divine but is not the direct vision. This directly undercuts any reading that identifies “the completion of Scripture” with “the perfect”: for Augustine, Scripture belongs to the “mirror” side of the equation, not the “face to face” side.

Theodoret of Cyrrhus, *Interpretatio in xiv epistulas s. Pauli*, on 1 Corinthians 13 (c. 435–450 AD)

Context: Theodoret, bishop of Cyrrhus, wrote the last great Antiochene commentary on the Pauline epistles — one of only five extant ancient commentaries to expound 1 Corinthians 13:8-12 (with Origen, Chrysostom, Ambrosiaster, and the later Pseudo-Primasius; the count is Shogren’s).

Source: Greek text in PG 82 (the 13:10-13 comments fall at approximately cols. 336-337). Verified directly against two independent digitizations of the PG 82 scan:

the Open Greek and Latin PG OCR (github.com/OGL-PatrologiaGraecaDev, Vol.-82, scan njp.32101077772802, pp. 183-184) and the archive.org scan's OCR, which agree throughout. English digest also in Shogren, "How Did They Suppose 'the Perfect' Would Come?", *JPT* 15 (1999): 99-121, whose characterization the Greek confirms.

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:8-10: "For the life to come has no need of these (Ὁ γὰρ μέλλων βίος τούτων ἀνενδεής). Prophecy is superfluous when the things themselves are present; tongues too are useless, their difference being removed; and the lesser knowledge ceases when the greater is supplied." On the child analogy: "He likened the knowledge given us in the present life to the knowledge of children, and the knowledge awaited (τὴν προσδοκωμένην) to that of full-grown men (τῇ τῶν τελείων ἀνδρῶν)" (translation ours from the PG text).

Interpretation of 1 Cor 13:12: "The present things, he says, are a shadow (σκιά) of the things to come. For in holy baptism we see the *type* of the resurrection; but then we shall see the resurrection itself. Here we behold the *symbols* of the Lord's body; there we shall see the Lord himself (ἐκεῖ δὲ αὐτὸν ὁψόμεθα τὸν Δεσπότην). For this is 'face to face.' And we see of him not the unseeable nature, invisible to all, but the nature taken from us" — the Antiochene qualification: the risen humanity is what is seen. On "even as I am known": "He does not mean 'I shall know him as I am known'; rather, 'I shall see him more exactly, as one made his own (προσφκειωμένος).' For he put ἐπεγνώσθην ('I was known') in place of ὡκειώθην ('I was made his own')" — Theodoret qualifies the καθώς from *within* the eschatological reading, without moving the arrival out of the resurrection. On verse 13: "Faith is superfluous in the life to come, the things being plainly manifest... so too hope is superfluous there... but love there has its dominion all the more" (translations ours).

Theodoret also turned the passage polemically against the Montanists and Arians (Eusebian tradition; *Historia ecclesiastica* 1.3) — always as a text about the present age's partial knowledge, never about a completed canon.

Byzantine Continuation (post-patristic; included for reference)

The Greek exegetical tradition did not end with the fathers. Its two great medieval epitomators — both digesting Chrysostom — carried the same reading into the Byzantine Middle Ages, a millennium after Paul.

Pseudo-Oecumenius, *Commentarius in epistolam I ad Corinthios*, on 13:8-12 (10th–11th century compilation)

Source: Greek text in PG 118. Verified directly against the Open Greek and Latin PG OCR (github.com/OGL-PatrologiaGraecaDev, Vol.-118, scan njp.32101077772992, pp. 601-602); exact column numbers not yet pinned (the commentary's 1 Cor 13 section; PG 118 carries the pseudo-Oecumenian corpus on Acts and the Pauline epistles).

Interpretation: On "shall be done away": "What then? — for he said the knowledge is to be abolished with respect to the time to come (περὶ τοῦ μέλλοντος χρόνου). Shall we then live in ignorance? God forbid (Μὴ γένοιτο)! He speaks of the *present* knowledge, the in-part knowledge... for when the perfect knowledge comes (ἐπὶ ἂν ἔλθῃ ἡ τελεία γνώσις), the in-part will have its end, abolished by the perfect knowledge." On the child analogy, the decisive gloss: "When therefore we become perfect — that is, in the

time to come (ὅ ἐστιν ἐν τῷ μέλλοντι χρόνῳ) — we shall cast off all the childish things. For the present knowledge and prophecy and way of life are like childhood compared to that which is to come.” On “face to face”: “Not as though God has some bodily or sensible face (Οὐχ ὡς σωματικόν τι ἢ αἰσθητὸν πρόσωπον τοῦ Θεοῦ ἔχοντος), but [signifying] the plainer [knowledge]” — Chrysostom’s qualification, preserved verbatim in the epitome (translations ours). He also carries Chrysostom’s historical observation that prophecies and tongues, existing for the spreading of the faith, would idle as superfluous once faith was everywhere — “and this will be so even now, and much more in the [age] to come”: within-history fading of the gifts alongside an eschatological τὸ τέλειον, with no canon in sight.

Theophylact of Ohrid, *Expositio in epistolam I ad Corinthios*, on 13:8-13 (c. 1078–1108)

Source: Greek text in PG 124 (the 1 Corinthians expositio). Verified directly against the University of Crete / Open Greek and Latin PG OCR corpus (Zenodo record 15780625, PG124, pp. 371-372 of the processed volume); exact column numbers not yet pinned.

Interpretation: “The in-part knowledge will be abolished when the perfect [knowledge] comes — namely, that of the life to come (δηλονότι, τῆς κατὰ τὴν μέλλουσαν ζωῆς). For we shall then know not so much, but far more.” On the man/child analogy: “That is, when in the age to come (ἐν τῷ μέλλοντι) I have the more manly knowledge, then the small and childlike knowledge we have here will be abolished.” On “face to face”: “Not as though God has a face (Οὐχ ὡς πρόσωπον τοῦ Θεοῦ ἔχοντος), but by this showing the clearer and plainer and unveiled (ἀνακεκαλυμμένην) knowledge.” On verse 13: faith, hope, and love outlast the gifts within the age, “and greater than these is love, since it stretches into the age to come (εἰς τὸν μέλλοντα αἰῶνα παρεκτείνεται). For when the consummation (συντελείας) comes, faith and hope will cease, but love remains, becoming stronger and more intense” (translations ours). Like his source Chrysostom, Theophylact holds the gifts themselves faded within history once the faith had been spread — while τὸ τέλειον remains the perfection of the age to come. A completed canon appears nowhere.

Chronological Summary Table

Author	Date	Work	Primary Reading / Orientation (1 Cor 13:10-12)	Source
Didache	c. 70-100	<i>Didache</i> 16:1-2	Eschatological completion (indirect; uses <i>teleioō</i> of “the last time”)	ANF Vol. 7
Clement of Rome	c. 96	<i>1 Clement</i> 49-50	Love as instrument of completion; no direct interpretation of v. 10	ANF Vol. 1
Ignatius	c. 107	<i>To the Ephesians</i> 14:1	Love as <i>telos</i> of faith; no direct interpretation of v. 10	ANF Vol. 1
Irenaeus	c. 180	<i>Against Heresies</i> 2.28.3; 5.6.1	Future age: complete knowledge vs. present partial knowledge	ANF Vol. 1; PG 7

Author	Date	Work	Primary Reading / Orientation (1 Cor 13:10-12)	Source
Anony- mous anti- Montanist	c. 192/193	in Eusebius, <i>HE</i> 5.17.4	Prophetic gift continues “until the final coming”	NPNF 2.1; PG 20
Clement of Alexandria	c. 200	<i>Stromata</i> 7.10; <i>Paedagogus</i> 1.6	Present maturity via gnosis (<i>Stromata</i>); v. 12 face-to-face → future world (<i>Paedagogus</i> 1.6)	ANF Vol. 2; PG 8 (<i>Paed.</i>), PG 9 (<i>Strom.</i>)
Tertullian	c. 208-213	<i>Against Praxeas</i> 14	Future encounter (on v. 12 “face to face,” reserved “to some future time”; links Num 12:6-8 with 1 Cor 13:12; v. 10 not directly glossed)	ANF Vol. 3; PL 2
Origen	c. 225	<i>De Principiis</i> 2.11.3-4; 1 Cor. catenae	Eschatological: direct divine presence supersedes partial knowledge	ANF Vol. 4; PG 11
Methodius	c. 290-311	<i>Banquet of the Ten Virgins</i> 9.2	“The kingdom of heaven and the resurrection”	ANF Vol. 6; PG 18
Ambrosi- aster	c. 366-384	<i>Comm. 1 Corinthians</i> on 13:9-12	Future life “near the Lord where Christ is” (on v. 12)	PL 17; CSEL 81
Chrysos- tom	c. 390	<i>Homilies on 1 Cor.</i> 29, 34	Complete knowledge of the age to come: “we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more”	NPNF 1.12; PG 61
Augustine	c. 415	<i>De Trinitate</i> 15.8.14; 15.23.44	Beatific vision: “the sight... which is promised anew to us face to face”	NPNF 1.3; PL 42
Theodoret	c. 435-450	<i>Interpretatio</i> , on 1 Cor 13	“The life to come has no need of these”; here symbols, “there we shall see the Lord himself”	PG 82:336-337
Ps.- Oecumenius	10th-11th c.	<i>Comm. 1 Cor.</i> , on 13:8-12	“Perfect — that is, in the time to come”; “not as though God has a bodily face”	PG 118
Theophy- lact	c. 1078-1108	<i>Expositio 1 Cor.</i> , on 13:8-13	The perfect knowledge “of the life to come”; at the consummation faith and hope cease, love remains	PG 124

Patterns in the Ancient Testimony

Four observations emerge from this corpus taken as a whole.

1. No ancient interpreter connects “the perfect” with canon completion.

This is the most significant datum in the table above. Not one of the ancient sources listed here (the patristic core of the table, Didache through Augustine) — spanning the roughly three and a half centuries of surviving comment and every major region of early

Christianity — identifies *to teleion* with the closing of the biblical canon. The fathers who lived while the canon was being formed (Irenaeus, Tertullian, Origen) did not make the connection. The fathers who wrote after the canon had been formally defined by Athanasius (367 AD) and affirmed by Hippo (393 AD) and Carthage (397 AD) — Chrysostom and Augustine — still did not make the connection. This is a sustained silence across the entire ancient tradition. The canon-completion interpretation has no ancient attestation. And the silence extends beyond antiquity: the Byzantine epitomators who carried the Greek exegetical tradition into the Middle Ages — pseudo-Oecumenius and Theophylact, both digesting Chrysostom — still gloss the perfect's arrival as belonging to the age to come, a millennium after Paul and some nine centuries after the last New Testament book was written (PG 118; PG 124; see the Byzantine Continuation section above).

2. The dominant reading is eschatological.

From the Didache's "be made perfect in the last time," through Irenaeus's argument that complete knowledge belongs to the age to come, through Tertullian's reserving of the face-to-face encounter "to some future time," through Origen's multi-stage eschatology, to Chrysostom's "we shall not only know as much, but even a great deal more" and Augustine's sight "promised anew to us face to face" — the overwhelming weight of the tradition identifies "the perfect" with the future state accompanying Christ's return, the resurrection, or the beatific vision of God in eternity.

3. Clement of Alexandria is the lone early voice for the maturity reading.

Clement's interpretation of *to teleion* as the mature spiritual knowledge available to the dedicated believer in this life is a genuine and historically significant reading. It is not a misreading. But it stands alone in the pre-Nicene period, shaped by Clement's Platonic philosophical inheritance and his apologetic agenda of demonstrating Christianity's intellectual respectability. No other pre-Nicene father follows him in this. The "maturity" reading's ancient support consists of one voice, from one school, in one city.

4. The "knowledge" theme runs through all ancient interpretations.

Whether eschatological (Irenaeus, Tertullian, Origen, Chrysostom, Augustine) or developmental (Clement), every ancient interpreter anchors his reading in the knowledge dimension of Paul's argument: knowing "in part" now, knowing "fully" then. The gifts — prophecy, tongues, knowledge — are partial precisely because our knowledge of God is partial. What completes the gifts is not a document but a state of being: the direct, unmediated presence of God. The ancient church's interest was not in the cessation of gifts as an accomplished historical fact; it was in the promise of divine vision as an eschatological hope.

(See also Appendix A: Word Study for analysis of the Greek terms teleios, ek merous, and related vocabulary in 1 Corinthians 13:9-12.)